how loud your heart gets

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/41220177.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Entrapta & Scorpia (She-Ra), Catra & Razz (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Marlena (He-Man), Randor (He-Man), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Friends to Enemies, Enemies to Friends, Slow Burn, Found Family, Miscommunication, Lack of Communication, Denial of Feelings, POV Catra (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - High School, some very brief underage drinking, is it gay to help someone woo your enemy/former best friend for money?, yes obviously, catra and adora have loving parents, Texting, Pretending to be someone else, romcom, Teen Romance, Teen Angst

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Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables, fav

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by pettylabelle

Summary

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"Maybe that' s a sign that you shouldnt date," Catra pointed out, taking her own life into her hands.

Huntara just gave her a condescending laugh. "You're not exactly knuckle-deep in girls so you dont get to judge. Has anyone ever even asked you out?"

Yes. Once, at least. It felt ironic to bring that up in this particular conversation so Catra just moved forward.

"But what the shit does this have to do with me then?" Catra asked, desperately wanting to be far away from this conversation and anything to do with the topic of Adora Gray.

"You write good."

"Well," Catra corrected in a bit of a daze. She was starting to have a terrible feeling about where this might be going.

"And well," Huntara repeated, letting the point float completely over her giant mohawked head, "You can write out what I should say to her."

If You, If You Could Return

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra was late. Which was *not* her fault. Her only mode of transportation had been suspiciously slower these last few days. The gear thingy on her bike was starting to look more like a square than a circle and she was pretty sure that couldn't be correct. She didn't know shit about bikes.

Balls. Was she gonna have to learn about bikes now? She definitely couldn't afford repairs and wouldn't have even been able to get the bike in the first place if she hadn't seen her kooky court-appointed guardian throwing it out and asked if she could take it instead. It was Catra's idea for Razz to declutter her house in the first place so she didn't have to be tripping over broken furniture, abandoned knickknacks, and random crap every time she came down to check on the old biddy. And Razz didn't even bother giving Catra a heads up about any of the good shit she was hiding in there!Out of spite, contrary to what Razz had suggested, Catra didn't spend the money she'd be saving on bus fare on a helmet.

So as she was speeding down the busy street behind her high school, watching the idiots she went there with get dropped off (or *worse* – park cars that their parents had bought them), she was well aware that she'd be rushing into homeroom looking like she hadn't brushed her long, curly hair this morning. There was a 70% chance she wore this outfit yesterday, the faded black jeans and green flannel she'd found on the floor this morning. She mentally prepared herself for all the snickering in the halls between classes.

Some asshole was hovering near the almost-full bike rack, right at the spot where Catra usually locked hers up. It's not like anyone would bother to steal the beater. But some of these fuckers might

duct tape it to a basketball hoop or something stupid just to mess with her.

"Clear the way , dumbass," Catra called out, hoping the person would move aside before she crashed into them.

They didn't. The closer Catra got, the more she realized this wasn't just some doofus texting their friends while they stood in the most inconvenient place possible. No, this was a purple hulk of a person, standing stock still in her sweatpants, football jersey , and jean jacket, staring right at Catra. The slight breeze shifted the person's waist-length white braid but seemed to stop just as she glared at it.

In an attempt to throw the girl off, Catra pulled her bike to a stop, mere inches away from hitting her.

"Huntara," Catra tried to growl. "I know you probably can't read but the sign says bicycle parking only .' Not 'idiot quarterback parking.' Move it. I'm late."

"W atch it, D'iluth," Huntara said back, actually pulling of f the threatening growl that Catra definitely hadn't quite. "There' s still 5 minutes til homeroom. Plenty of time for me to break you *and* your piece of shit bike in half."

"I gotta see a girl about a thing. So can you just schooch along?"

Huntara didn't really move but Catra built up the courage to get of f the bike and shimmy into the small space the jock managed to not take up. She slapped the chain and padlock that she'd repurposed (aka found in the junk behind the hardware store) and dashed into school.

Not wasting any time, Catra rushed through the halls, ignoring all the sea of plebes lazing around or mindlessly gossiping before class, until she was standing in front of someone who she definitely did not want to see this early in the morning.

"Octavia," was all Catra said in greeting before she tried to discreetly shove a 5-page paper into the tall green delinquent's hand. Not that Catra was judgy about the 'delinquent' part. She knew her struggling peers were basically her bread and butter and pulling themes from some old dead guy's words wasn't really a useful skill in the real world anyway.

Octavia didn't even look up in response, head still leant against her locker while she scrolled on her phone. She snatched the paper out of Catra's grip and dropped a half-balled $20 in its place.

Instead of a thanks, Octavia tossed Catra a half-assed peace sign. Catra zipped her backpack and was about to run off for another drop when Kyle gently waved from the next locker over. Her face was already apologetic.

"Again?" Catra asked.

"I just totally forgot-"

Catra interrupted with a quick "Don't care," before retrieving another paper from her bag. "You're lucky I was in a generous mood last night and wrote extras." Mr. Archer always assigned the same book to all four of his 12th grade English classes. It was easy enough for Catra to bang out 2 or 3 more essays on top of the ones people had commissioned in advance.

"Just write your name in pencil on the top. If Archer asks any questions, tell him you were too dumb to remember to actually put a heading. That should be easy enough to believe."

After plucking the cash from Kyle, Catra took off to make the rounds, frantically hunting everyone down on her way to homeroom. She'd made about $100 before she noticed Kyle (the other one, the one they usually just called 'Guy Kyle') staring fearfully over her shoulder as Catra gave him his homework. People were usually intimidated by her, maybe even a little shook, but never downright terrified.

Catra glanced over her shoulder and finally noticed Huntara impatiently glaring at her.

"For fuck's sake, are you still following me?" She pushed past Kyle to huff it to her class before the late bell rang out.

"You want this money or not?" Huntara asked in a voice that was threatening enough to make a couple nearby people scurry off.

Catra came to a sudden stop. She made sure to seem completely disinterested as she slowly turned to face Huntara.

"What do you need?"

Huntara took a few steps closer so she could lower her voice. "Adora Gray."

Catra had to fight to keep from physically shaking.

"Like… trapped in your basement?"

The death look that Huntara gave her made Catra feel like it was more likely *she'd* end up in Huntara's basement.

"On a date."

There were many questions that Catra had about this. For some dumb reason, she decided to ask "Why?"

Huntara shrugged her boulder of a shoulder. "She's cute enough. Not bad to talk to. We just run out of stuff to say to each other all the time."

"Maybe that's a sign that you shouldn't date," Catra pointed out, taking her own life into her hands.

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"You write good."

"Well," Catra corrected in a bit of a daze. She was starting to have a terrible feeling about where this might be going.

"And well," Huntara repeated, letting the point float completely over her giant mohawked head, "You can write out what I should say to her. Quick notes though, I don't have a whole lot of time." Huntara chewed on that thought for a second as Catra was grateful that she couldn't afford to eat breakfast and therefore wouldn't have anything to vomit up out of nerves right now. "Maybe you can write a couple texts for me to send to her."

"That doesn't make sense," Entrapta replied. She didn't bother to look up from her seat on the floor of the computer lab. There was a desktop tower in her lap but the insides of it were both haphazardly just lying in there or strewn about on the floor and on her legs. It was definitely too many wires. Entrapta frowned a little before adding, "You and Adora were incredibly close for several grades. Does Huntara not remember that?"

"I don't think everyone catalogs other people's behavior like you do," Catra replied, lounging on a nearby desk. She was lazily using a pen to pick some dried mud off her boots.

Entrapta pondered on that idea for a moment. "Seems like a missed opportunity for you all. Anyway, why would Huntara ask someone who already dated Adora to help *her* date Adora?"

"We didn't date!" Catra argued. Her voice was just all over the fucking place, going from screeching to stammering to disappearing into her empty stomach. "We were just friends."

"Incredibly *close* friends then. I don't think I've ever seen two people so close. Are you *sure* you didn't-"

"Yeah, I'm sure."

"Didn't she take you to a sophomore dance?"

"We rode in the same car and then stood near each other." Catra wasn't about to include the other details about how Adora had shyly asked her. How they'd gotten ready together. How they'd hid under the bleachers to slow dance alone. How that would be the last time they were friends.

"So your public breakup was in fact, not actually a break up?" Entrapta pushed.

"It was not! And it wasn't public!"

"Multiple witnesses saw your argument," Entrapta added, like Catra didn't replay that moment in her head often and wasn't extremely aware of every painful detail of it.

"It's high school -aren't people supposed to forget these things?"

"You overestimate the amount of interesting things happening in Bright Moon."

"Fair. Anyway, will you help?"

"Oh. You took the job?" Entrapta looked up from her wires for the first time. The gaze she gave Catra had the same type of determined yet puzzled expression. "Sure. Happy to be of service."

Catra gave a relieved nod. "Thanks."

"I'll just fill Scorpia in," Entrapta added casually. She had her phone out and was rapidly texting before Catra could stop her.

Not 5 minutes later, Scorpia rushed in, red-faced and out of breath. She looked like she was burning up in her thick red and gold letterman jacket.

"Wildcat!" Scopia wheezed out. "You and Adora are getting back together? I'm so happy to hear that. If she hurts you again though"… For the first time since Catra had met Scorpia in 4th grade, the big bug's affable, overly friendly demeanor dropped completely as she narrowed her eyes threateningly. "I will *end* her."

Catra blinked at her slowly, tugging on the sleeve of her own dark green flannel shirt reflexively. "So 1: what the hell is up with you? 2: Adora and I were *never* together. And 3: we're never gonna *be* together! I'm just taking a job for Huntara. *She* wants to date Adora."

"Oh. Oh, wow," Scorpia said before falling into a desk chair behind her, sagging with relief. "Wait. Huntara? And Adora? Huh. Would not have guessed it. Never really see them together. And Adora's never mentioned her."

Catra tilted her head as she looked at Scorpia. Since the A-word was clearly on the list of banned discussion topics for the past 2 years, Catra had mostly forgotten that Scorpia and Adora played field hockey together. Partially because the immense gayness of that sentence was too much for her mind to comprehend. But mostly because she'd committed to wiping all the vicarious hockey knowledge she'd gained over years of friendship with Adora from her brain forever.

But! This presented a helpful opportunity. Scorpia was friendly with literally everyone. No one had it in them to be rude to someone so nice (and so clearly capable of flattening them with her muscles.) Lord knows why she chose to hang around Entrapta, who was basically an enigma to the rest of their class, or Catra, who seemed to be feared and loathed in equal measure. Scorpia built connections

with everyone though, especially her teammates and all the other jocks. If this gig required an inside angle, Scorpia could come in very handy.

"I don't like that face," Scorpia said. "You're scheming."

"Just coming up with backup plans. I'm pretty sure this won't take more than an hour – a couple notes for Huntara to copy, maybe some pics she could take to send, suggested best times to send a 'u up?' text. But if I need more, I just need a plan."

"I think it's gonna be a little more complicated than that, buddy," Scorpia said cautiously.

Catra didn't much appreciate the sadass look Scorpia was trying to hide from her.

She pretended to laugh it off. "It'll be a slam dunk. Even Huntara won't be able to fuck this up."

"Scorpia means because of your personal feelings," Entrapta said, after what felt like hours of silence from her. She had a tendency to do that, swinging back and forth from talking endlessly or just focusing so much she didn't speak for long periods of time. It had probably only been a handful of minutes since she'd decided to dive back into whatever computer autopsy she was up to, but her words felt like some grand proclamation that Catra would absolutely be having none of.

"What personal feelings? This is *business.* I need cash and Huntara's paying."

"You are being intentionally obtuse," Entrapta said. And then smartly added, "I'd like my cut upfront just in case."

After a negotiation with Entrapta that made Catra miss her entire free period, she made it to her next class early enough to grab her

favorite seat in the back.

This was her daily injection of unbearable awkwardness – the ten seconds Catra had between hearing Glitter's obnoxious laugh from the hall and the asshole entering the room with Adora and Bow in a line behind her. A brief window where Catra had to make sure that her eyes were focused on literally anything except the front of the room and that her face was locked into 'stone-cold bitch' mode.

Catra was in honors classes for basically everything else, which made it easy to avoid Adora, who was a good student but always tested terribly at the end of year cause she usually worked herself up into an anxiety spiral. As the guidance counselor had explained repeatedly, there was no Honors Art and no other art class that fit in Catra's schedule. She was doomed to spend an hour with Adora and her replacement best friends every single day.

The three quieted a little when they clearly saw Catra sitting there, same as they always did, before taking over two tables in the 2nd row. Bow, class president and beloved by everyone, and Glimmer, social chair and tolerated by most, sat together as usual. Adora, perfect Adora with her stupid smiling face greeting everyone and her clear path to prom queen or some other useless arbitrarily assigned token of popularity, sat alone. For two years, in any class that involved shared desks, Adora had filled the extra one with her bag or her sports junk or whatever . A clear sign that *no one* was welcome next to her.

That used to be Catra's spot. *Catra* wasn't welcome.

The three continued on with their conversation, just at a much lower volume. There was no doubt that Adora must have told her friends about Catra's excellent hearing. Anytime they were in the same general space, suddenly Glimmer, who could probably still be heard in a coliseum of screaming thousands, learned how to use her inside voice. Couldn't have nosey Catra overhearing their 'super cool' plans to stay up til midnight past their bedtime and braid each other's hair or whatever bullshit these idiots got up to.

They'd only been casual friends with Bow and Glimmer when Catra and Adora stopped talking. Up until then, the sparkle duo were just two kids who they saw in class or said hi to at Adora's games. With Catra out of the way, they slid immediately into Adora's life like they were meant to be there. They fit better anyway. All 'nice' kids from 'good' families with 'amazing' lives.

That fucking pile of dicks.

"Catra, are you paying attention to one single word I'm saying?" Spinnerella asked.

She had to blink a couple times to remember where she was, here and now in this shitty art room that smelled like paint and with their teacher and most of the room staring at her like the weirdo she was. Catra glanced down – no, she had not been paying attention; she'd been subconsciously drawing a pile of dicks in her notebook.

Generally, if she was in a mood – which she most definitely was today – Catra would sass back at her teacher . But Spinny was nice enough and her wife was the guidance counselor and the absolute last thing Catra needed today was another attempt at someone trying to force her to talk about her feelings.

"Sure," she grunted out.

Spinnerella clearly didn't believe that but seemed to realize it wasn't worth disrupting more of class over.

Today was a quiet day thankfully . Spinny had them working on still life so everyone just had to shut their mouths and start painting some damn apples.

"Driluth," a familiar voice said shortly . "Spare some red."

Catra looked up mid-stroke to see Glimmer standing over her table. Where Bow had become distantly polite and Adora absolutely non-

existent, Glitter's feelings toward Catra waffled from supremely annoyed to slightly bearable.

In addition to the wealth of red on her palette, Catra also had a full tube right on her desk. She slowly dropped her eyes to Glimmer's mostly empty palette before very obviously looking at the girl's impatient frown then down her body, past her lavender v-neck sweater, the hint of bare midriff it showed, and the tight fit of her pale blue jeans.

"What do I get in return?" Catra asked, making her voice sound as smarmy as possible. When she looked back up, Glimmer's frown was deepening but it couldn't mask how her cheeks warmed.

Glimmer sighed angrily like *she* wasn't the one bugging someone else. "The school paid for the paint, Dr. Hiluth. Just give me some without being a fucking creep please."

"You're no fun today," Catra replied before picking up the tube of paint and pointing it at Glimmer.

She waited until Glimmer had her hands on it, ignoring the tacky glittery nail polish she wore. Catra tugged the tube quickly to catch Glimmer off guard. With the girl suddenly teetering over, Catra shoved herself into Glimmer's space.

"Super cute top," Catra said facetiously , trying to sound like one of those empty-headed ditzes that ruled the social hierarchy around there.

Glimmer blushed more deeply before snatching the tube and rushing back to her station. As Catra returned to painting, she felt at least one set of eyes lingering on her for way too long.

"What did she say to you?" she heard Adora whisper .

Catra must've looked completely out of her mind, focusing so intently on just drawing a red circle that any kindergartner could have done.

"Nothing," Glimmer replied. She sounded like someone who was tired of having a conversation that had barely even started.

"Didn't look like nothing," Adora mumbled angrily.

Glimmer muttered something to herself but all Catra could make out was "act like a jealous idiot" and "...fucking *do* something about it"…

Catra carried on, pretending she didn't have a care in the world. Adora was so bitter and obsessed. How pathetic. It was still so easy to get under her skin.

Entrapta was wrong. This was gonna be some of the easiest cash they ever made.

Chapter End Notes

a couple months ago, i was brainstorming fic ideas with the brilliant caminante and i mentioned that i was thinking of doing a sort of cyrano-type deal but set in a high school. caminante said she didn't read many hs aus but would read mine and i thought "...challenge accepted"

i usually write slightly older (and only slightly more mature) catradora. if that's more your speed, that'll be back soon.

a million thanks to resflower, raptorred, vertical drive, and poputchik for taking an early gander at this for me. this is my very first beta'ed fic!

barring anything weird, this should update every tuesday.

Don’t Let It Burn, Don’t Let It Fade

Chapter Notes

> oh hi. thanks to everyone for reading chapter 1 and leaving fun comments!<3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra kinda liked schedules but struggled to keep up much of one for herself. After school, she ran errands for Razz and did whatever odd jobs she could pick up to help pull her own weight financially. Catra had learned from an early age that you couldn't really depend on most people. So even though Razz claimed they were fine on money —which made no sense since the weirdo had never had a job as far as anyone could tell —Catra made a couple deliveries for the bakery downtown. She had heard that the library was gonna start sending books to folks who were homebound and stopped by to ask if they needed help with that. The other Mr. Archer said he'd let her know when the program was up and running.

With that promise, Catra dropped into the bike shop to pretend that she didn't need to fix her ride but would graciously accept a quote anyway. Unfortunately, one of her more annoying classmates, that idiot that seemed to have cobbled his entire personality from fantasy books, was hanging around out front and refilling his tires. Without being asked *at all,* Sea Hawk informed her that it would cost a couple hundred for the shop to repair it but he could do her a solid and take care of it for $35. Catra offered to *not* tell the shop owners that he was loitering out front and scaring their customers away for the same price. Neither of them left happy.

Dinner consisted of a can of tuna with some mustard swirled into it along with two slices of toasted bread, eaten pretty much in one bite while Catra tried to do some math on how to pay for the repair,

shove some money Razz's way, and save to get the fuck out of Bright Moon forever.

Kocking Huntara's request out seemed like the clearest strategy. And Catra was in the perfect mental place to imagine wooing Adora for another person's benefit – angry enough to want to punish the whole world. That's the kind of annoying teenage angst that love stories were usually built on, she figured.

The small room she lived in didn't have much. When the court bounced her from Weaver over to Razz, Catra was grateful to get out of the basically-dilapidated home she'd grown up in at least. Razz lived on the other side of town and rented half a duplex from some guy who was somehow *possibly* even weirder than she was. There was a tiny in-law suite up above the garage that Catra offered to pitch in for if it meant she could have privacy and her own entrance. Between the extra junk in Razz's place and the local thrift stores, she'd managed to cobble together some decor. A comfy-enough mattress on the floor. A couple folding chairs and a hammock she hung up under the window. There was an old projector for watching movies and then a small island with a stool that doubled as a work and dining space. Catra had put up all the posters from her old room to make it feel more familiar but it wasn't exactly cozy. It was *hers* though and that's all that mattered.

It was weird sitting down and intentionally inviting thoughts of Adora into this space, this safe room that Adora had never even been to. Probably didn't even know it existed. Where did Adora think Catra lived now with the house gone? It was a small town. News probably got to her somehow. Glimmer's mom, Angella, or some other busybody who knew way too much about Catra's life.

When her laptop booted up, she already had way too many pings from Entrapta about her plan and from Scorpia about her feelings. Vowing to ignore all of those forever, Catra instead gathered the two of them onto a group thread.

Catra
How the fuck do people our age flirt?
Stars, I sound so fucking ancient already

Scorpia
Awww, wildcat
You're an old soul
And also I'm not helping
Sorry!

Entrapta
I looked this up today
Compliments, casual touching
Genuine or feigned interest in the other person's life

Catra
So romcom shit
I can do that
I mean, I can tell *Huntara* to do that

Scorpia
Right…

Catra
Shut up I'm working now

Entrapta
Dont worry
I have other ideas when this fails!

Catra promptly closed the window and opened a blank document instead. She just needed to create a list of Adora dos and donts. This was doable, Catra had basically been training her whole life for this moment. Who knew being an expert in all things Adora was a profitable skill?

Adora Tips

- *Lie about liking horses. Make up a story about how you rode once or something*
- *Send her annoying pop songs that remind you of her*
- *Compliment her outfit. Whatever it is, say it makes her eyes look nice*
- *Ask her questions about herself*
- *If all else fails, talk about jockshit*
- *Do not try to pop a pimple in front of her*
- *Make fun of anyone*
- *Do not try to give her advice unless she asks*

This all felt like obvious surface-level shit but Catra was having trouble taking this project more seriously. She couldn't really picture Adora and Huntara together, not that she would even *want to* anyway. And no matter how many times Catra tried to write it out, she couldn't bring herself to advise Huntara to touch Adora. Ever. Not even platonically.

In fact, she considered warning that Adora actually *hated* physical touch, which was a complete lie. Catra still had a scar on her elbow from when Adora tackled her into a bear hug so hard that they both fell and got scraped up. It would have been fine usually, except they were sitting in the tree in Adora's backyard at the time; Catra said she liked Adora's dimples and suddenly they were falling to their deaths.

Catra would *not* be telling Huntara about how Adora's backyard was the perfect place to hang out and see stars. Or the best footholds to climb into her bedroom window. Or which snacks to bribe Adora with if you want her to smile. Or-

With a frustrated sigh, Catra scribbled 2 or 3 more deeply unhelpful notes and saved the doc. Mr. Archer always let her print stuff for free if she stopped by the library early, incorrectly assuming that she only abused this privilege for schoolwork. One quick stop in the morning and this would all be over.

A handful of essays and one incredibly embarrassing cheat sheet on her mortal enemy burning a hole in her backpack, Catra sped through the hall, making transactions as quickly as she could. Mr. Archer had come over when the printer jammed and the look on his face as he caught sight of the Adora list would haunt Catra for the rest of her life. His deep voice had gone up to whistle-register while he squealed about young love. Catra's attempt to explain that this wasn't what he thought it was and if he could *please f or the love of god not tell B w and also shush!* didn't seem to make much of a difference.

Once she found Huntara checking her long white hair in the annex bathroom, the one people only went into to hide or pretend to be too cool, she practically threw the sheet to her.

"Here. Money now."

Huntara gave the brief list a long look that Catra definitely didn't have time for. Her face was not at all impressed. Or even interested, really.

"Hold up," Huntara protested. "You're on the hook until this works."

"That wasn't our agreement."

"Our agreement was that you help me date Adora Gray. Not give me a post-it note about horses and some wiki-how lines on flirting."

"It'll work," Catra said, making sure her voice sounded as irritated as she felt. The day had barely begun and she was already feeling sick. Maybe she'd dip out early after making some cash.

"It better," Huntara replied. She barely even had to *try* to make it sound so threatening.

It didn't work.

Over the past 2 years, Catra had trained herself to know where Adora would be so she could avoid those places at all cost. Hanging outside on the picnic tables during Lunch C? Impossible to do without having to see Adora swallowing her food whole while chatting with Bow and Glimmer and whoever else was considered cool this week. Second row of lockers in gym class? Adora had all but written her name on one of them so it was smartest to choose the farthest row just in case, even if they had such a slim chance of interacting since their classes were only back-to-back. Obviously, the field was completely off-limits forever.

Against her better judgment, Catra kept finding herself just on the periphery of these places for the rest of the week. Just hovering on the edge coincidentally and completely doing her own thing.

Three times, she watched Huntara fumble the bag. It probably looked like the usual boring chit chat but each time, Catra could see Adora's smile go from friendly to confused as she and Huntara bumbled through stiff conversation. From even far away, she could tell how hopelessly lost they both were, and not in the good cheesy way. The last time, Adora ended their talk with a punch in Huntara's shoulder that screamed 'you are never putting your tongue in my mouth.'

Catra couldn't even pretend to be shocked when Huntara stormed up to her as she was trying to sneak out the back unseen.

"What the fuck, Dr. Iluth?"

"Sorry , my office hours are closed, Huntara. Feel free to leave a message though." Catra ducked towards her bike but was stopped by a strong hand on the back of her scruff.

That was a level of humiliation that she wasn't prepared for on a casual Friday so Catra promptly held up her hands in surrender until Huntara let her go.

"Don't be cute. You told me this would work."

"I gave you all the ingredients. You gotta cook the meal yourself."

"This is impossible," Huntara muttered. Something was off in her tone.

Catra gave her a long look. Huntara wasn't angry- okay, that was a lie. She was *pissed.* But also? Frustrated maybe? And not just at Catra. No, she mostly seemed upset with herself.

"Huh. What-uhwhat happened? Exactly?"

In a flash, that vulnerability was gone and complete hardass Huntara was back. She took a step closer to Catra to growl, "If you laugh-"

"I won't!" Catra hissed back. "Besides like you said, it's not like I have any experience with girls."

Honestly, this whole thing was doomed from the start. But Catra wasn't about to risk her money by pointing that out. Huntara would've had more luck getting help from Lonnie, who hadn't been single since her braces came out and her boobs came in in 7th grade.

Huntara made a lot of very audible angry grunting sounds before reluctantly whipping out her phone, pressing a couple buttons, and handing it over. She refused to meet Catra's eyes, which really just made her embarrassed for both of them.

The text chain presented to her was a mess. Neither of them contributed much to the convo beyond 'hey' or 'wut u up to?' If seeing this interaction in person wasn't bad enough, knowing that they'd put it in writing for all eternity really made Catra appreciate her choice to never willingly attempt dating.

"Well, a few things," Catra started as she handed Huntara her phone back. "Maybe try asking her something specific? Like if she's listening to anything good these days. What her plans are on Saturday. Shit like that."

I *try,"* Huntara argued. "She doesn't really give anything."

That was true. Both sides read like two people who were forced to text their aunts just so they wouldn't be forgotten from the gift list come Christmas time.

"Did you follow any of the tips I gave you?"

"I asked for help, not homework. The season's about to start. I'm already memorizing a whole new playbook-"

"I don't need your fucking lifestory right now ," Catra interrupted. She was already trying to think through how to knock this out as quickly as possible.

Adora usually kept her head down and focused. A lot of shit flew right past her. So Adora not noticing an obvious crush, even from someone as fucking graceless as Huntara wasn't surprising. If they didn't make it completely clear , Adora would never catch on. She probably thought Huntara had just suddenly decided to be nice, even though Catra had tried to teach her for years to be suspicious of people's motives.

Clearly, Huntara was incapable of grabbing Adora's attention on her own. Catra considered taking Huntara's phone and just writing back, hey , i like you.' But Adora was likely to even find a way to misinterpret that as friendly. She'd say it back, send a thumbs up or something, and literally nothing would change.

Plus, the idea of being so bold just felt off. f for Catra. The more she thought about the possibility of ending this immediately and placing Adora right into Huntara's arms, Catra's stomach started to hurt. She'd probably just eaten lunch too fast. She'd sat with a couple of the other local queerdos today and Kyle gave her half his food for some fucking reason Catra couldn't figure out.

No. She would have to solve this issue with a lot more subtlety. But not so much that Adora completely fucking missed the point.

Catra was vaguely aware of Huntara impatiently grumbling at her while she stood there, working through all the possibilities in her mind quickly. A big showy thing? No, Adora would be too embarrassed and probably freeze up too much. She didnt like a lot of attention off the field or being put on the spot. A long, clearly written letter? No one would believe that was Huntara's style. Glimmer would probably end up convincing Adora it was a prank. A rumor? No-...maybe? It was a tried and true method for a bunch of their idiot classmates. Tell a friend that you like someone and wait for that person to find out, saving yourself the grief of having to tell them directly and risk getting shot down.

She looked up at Huntara, still all grumpy-faced, nervously making sure her hair was still perfect and that the shaved sides were smoothed down. For someone who pretended not to care very much, Huntara was putting a lot of effort into being nonchalant.

"Follow me," Catra instructed and took off without waiting.

They found DT quickly. Even on a Friday, they were in the auditorium, watching as a couple freshmen fumbled their way through some lines on stage. Catra wasnt sure which teacher was unlucky enough to end up in charge of the theater department but DT had unseated them in their sophomore year and never looked back. They ran the troupe of theater kids like their personal playhouse and the rest of the student body like they too were just a bunch of actors on a stage.

"We're not doing Pinochio, kids," they lectured, sounding bored to death. "No need to be so wooden. The audience wants to see life! They want *emotion. Drama!*"

Catra entered the row behind them instead of sitting down next to DT, who was in the center of a sea of empty chairs, stiletto-covered feet leaned against the seat in front of them.

"Speaking of drama," they said much more quietly. "Why are you sneaking up on me, Kitten?"

DT threw their head back to look at her, long, stick-straight platinum blonde hair cascading over the back of their chair and nearly whacking Catra in the face.

"What up," she said with as little enthusiasm as possible.

DT waved for the kids on stage to continue, even as they turned more in their chair to look to Catra's left. Huntara was still there, being awkward and obvious about her discomfort.

"What an interesting duo," DT observed with glee in their eyes. "Wonder what you two could *possibly* be up to." When Catra didn't continue, DT kept poking. "Maybe about a cute field hockey captain that Huntara is rumored to have her eye on as well?"

"Where you hear that?" Huntara asked. She didn't sound thrilled about this rumor.

"Darling, *everyone's* heard that."

"Yeah yeah," Catra said, rolling her eyes. "Huntara's all mushy for Adora. I heard she was gonna ask Adora to go steady."

"Steady? Unless you heard that from your elderly aunt, I'm gonna have to call bullshit, Kitten."

Catra bristled and DT added with a sigh, "Why don't you focus on getting Adora and I'll work my magic on the spin? She'll get the message about Huntara's interest. Loud and clear."

That probably could have been the end of their interaction but that sick feeling in Catra's stomach was returning. If she was gonna spew her guts out, she'd be better off just sitting still and chilling for a minute.

"You can head on your way," DT called out to Huntara, reading Catra's mind.

They even did a little condescending wave and everything, which had Huntara looking as if she'd like to murder them with her bare hands. But she left, still confused and annoyed.

Catra would've loved to ask exactly how much DT knew already but it was useless trying to get an honest answer out of them. They'd give everything away eventually anyway.

"What are you putting on?" she asked instead, nodding towards the stage.

"Cyrano," DT replied. Then something seemed to click for them and they smiled deviously. "Know it? An insecure but clever little thing woos a fair maiden through a more conventionally attractive pal."

When Catra left this podunk town behind, she wasn't sure if she'd miss DT or celebrate being rid of them forever. Honestly, it was more likely that if she ended up in a bigger place like Eternia, DT would end up there as well, a famous director or actor or sugar baby socialite on a reality show. The two of them weren't friends exactly but they'd tolerated each other for years. It was nice to have another resourceful person around from time to time.

That didn't mean Catra was above hunting them down if any of this got traced back to her.

"Just ask, kitten. I might surprise you."

"Surprise me with an ice pick in my back maybe," she muttered back.

"Fine. Suit yourself." DT turned back to face forward. "You know you can't keep a secret from me. But I'm discreet enough that it'll be just between you, me, and Huntara. I'll keep my word and you." Catra felt herself tense as they paused. "You'll owe me one. I heard Entrapta already cleaned out your cash." DT giggled quietly to themself. "Toodles, kitten."

The lunch offering today was those weird rectangle pizzas, which was one of the few things Catra would usually ever consider eating from the cafeteria. Entrapta was hard at work on who fucking knew what and Scorpia had already promised some other friends she'd sit with them today. Of course, she'd invited Catra but that was a hard pass. There was a 98% chance that Adora would be in the group of folks who Scorpia sat with and Catra was planning to avoid their table like the plague. Lonnie and her boyfriends were posted up at a table in the farthest corner of the room; they wouldn't mind Catra taking up a seat and largely ignoring them for 45 minutes.

She was still about half a dozen people away from ordering when suddenly Glimmer appeared at her elbow.

"Hey, Driluth," she said and, oddly, something about it lacked the usual annoyance that Catra had gotten used to. Glimmer was almost... semi-okay with having to talk to her right now.

"Glitter. Slumming it today?" Catra had seen her carrying her little lunch bag with her between classes, some sparkly kitschy little thing. "Or just wanted an excuse to spend more time with me?"

"You wish," she replied, sounding not at all convincing. Glimmer's eyes shot around quickly. "Just getting, uhm... milk." She shoved the person behind Catra out of the way and jumped into their spot. Ignoring the kid trying to get her attention, Glimmer instead leaned over to whisper to Catra. "Have you heard about someone having a crush on Adora?"

Catra gripped her empty tray so hard that she was sure she'd leave claw marks in it. She wasn't sure which idea she hated more – Glimmer knowing that she had anything to do with Huntara's plan to date Adora or having to talk to Glimmer about anything involving Adora and feelings.

She tried to play it all off. "I don't follow what you idiots do in your personal time."

Sparkles swiveled around Catra's right shoulder so that she could see her face. There was something devious in Glimmer's eyes that Catra didn't like.

"Really?" she teased, her free hand going to lay on Catra's forearm. "I thought you heard everything that goes on."

"Am I gonna have to tell the guidance counselor that you're bullying me again?"

Glimmer's face morphed into a sneer just as her grip tightened on Catra's arm. "Can you stop doing that? I was trying to *help* you last time by pointing out how much the paint smelled and Netossa ended up making me go through a bunch of flashcards on species sensitivity."

"I see they didn't work."

"Fine!" Glimmer huffed, stomping her foot and everything. Catra almost laughed out loud at how easy it was to mess with her. "I was just trying to see if you had any *thoughts* on Huntara's crush on Adora. Why did I listen to Bow? I knew this was a waste of time."

She didn't seem to care that it was a waste of *Catra's* time.

Fighting down all instincts to throw a chair over this whole thing, Catra pointed out Huntara up ahead in the line, directing one of her lackeys to carry her tray stacked full of food. "Why don't you just ask *her* about it? I'm not a gossip for hire." Though, it occurred to Catra, that might be a helpful skill she could market.

Hmm. Maybe this wasn't an entirely useless interaction after all…

With another huff, Glitter snatched her hand away and stormed off to yell at Huntara. Catra half-watched as she got her pizza, while Huntara looked down as Glimmer whispered loudly at her, resembling an adult dealing with an angry 6 year-old.

Glimmer wasnt trying very hard to keep her conversation private. Catra could pick her up clear as day asking Huntara if she was planning on asking anyone to homecoming. It was possible that Catra was straining a bit to hear all of this, ears perked up and facing forward.

Probably, if she hadnt been so damn nosey , Catra wouldnt have been able to accidentally hear the conversation happening several people *behind* her in the line as well.

"maybe if Glimmer wasn't always flirting with her!" Adora whispered harshly. Her voice was low and angry.

Catra could hear Bow replying, "She's not flirting. She's just... being extra welcoming?"

"She's trying to make me jealous. I know it."

"Huh. Then why is it working?" It sounded like Bow was smiling a little.

Angry Adora was always hilarious to make fun of, especially when she was wrapped up in something as dumb as who Glimmer was flirting with. Sparkles' own boyfriend didnt even seem to care. If Adora had it bad for Huntara already, maybe this job would end up going a little easier. DT had done their part well, Catra hated to admit.

As Adora continued to deny that Glimmer's method was working, lying so obviously that Catra could picture her stuttering face, Catra looked ahead to where Glimmer was clearly just trying to grill Huntara. It wasnt surprising that Glimmer had set herself up as Adora's protector. Without Catra, the dummy needed someone to help her watch out for creeps or call her out on her worst ideas.

Huntara was unwilling to play ball and impress her crush's best friend though. Not seeming to care that Glimmer was mid-sentence,

Huntara just turned and walked out of the line. She didn't even pay as she left Glimmer standing there, stewing in her rage.

Eh, it didn't *seem* particularly flirty. But what did Catra know?

Catra had just run through a bunch of small jobs and was barely in her front door when her phone started buzzing with a sound she'd never heard before. It was a loud grating rat-a-tat, like a drumroll on speed.

"The fuck?" she mumbled to herself.

"It works!" Entrapta shrieked, startling Catra so badly that she nearly dropped her bag on the floor.

Entrapta had taken up her entire island, two separate laptops running plus a few random devices that Catra didn't recognize.

"I gave you that key in case I went missing or something and Razz needed help," Catra pointed out, taking huge gulps of air to calm herself. "Not so you could just break in whenever ."

"Technically, it's not breaking in *if* I have a key."

The logic there was too infuriating to deal with so Catra settled for stomping into her own place and slamming the door. Her and Razz's shady shut-in landlord/neighbor, Hordak, would probably be leaving her a note and telling her to keep it down during Dateline, which was basically a warning and a red flag all wrapped in one.

Catra grabbed a cup of water from the tap and checked to see if she had any emergency snacks. Riding around all early evening and she'd forgotten to grab groceries again. Catra always hated bothering Razz for food or anything, not wanting to be more of a burden than she already was.

"I ordered two pizzas," Entrapta said, while Catra was examining an old box of instant oats to convince herself she was definitely someone who could eat oatmeal without being overly aware that it was just soggy cardboard.

"Did you invite anyone over?" Catra asked. Maybe Scorpia was joining them (not very likely with her full schedule) or Entrapta had a plan to start running unlicensed experiments out of Catra's place (shockingly likely.)

Entrapta shook her head no. She was clearly deep in work mode, arm-length purple pigtails pulled up into a bun on the top of her head that resembled a pigeon's nest.

Catra decided against fighting about it. The two of them could definitely inhale some food but two whole pies was an obvious trick for Entrapta to slide some cash Catra's way without either of them feeling awkward about it. She settled on grabbing one of those baby coke cans that Entrapta always left over from the fridge and handing it to her well-meaning but very ridiculous friend.

"So...you hacked my phone?" Catra guessed.

"That's an underrepresentation of all of the modifications I've made to your device," Entraptra replied. She started typing away again. "...but yes."

"Any particular reason?" It was usually more efficient to approach Entrapta with curiosity rather than anger over something, like, *hacking your fucking phone.*

"I needed a test subject. And you seemed appropriate since this project is to help you woo Adora."

"I'm not '*wooing*' anyone," Catra argued. "I am merely passing messages from one person to another person. Like the post office." That felt like a perfectly reasonable way for her to justify this to

Scorpia or any other person who suddenly decided that Catra was secretly into her nemesis.

Entrapta didnt bother replying. Staring at her and waiting for some type of explanation got old qickly so Catra ended up watching some tv from her laptop, while collapsed in bed. It felt like she hadnt gotten enough sleep in weeks and Entrapta's keystrokes and occasional hmm'was enough background noise for Catra to nap.

That lasted for about a minute probably before someone rang the doorbell and scared her right into being wide awake. That idiot, Sea Hawk, was unfortunately the delivery guy tonight. Entrapta was absolutely no help while Catra wrestled the food out of his hands and simultaneously turned down his attempt to sell her weed, teach her some guitar, and (most depressing of all) hang out until his next delivery. That kid never seemed to have anywhere to be, besides doing donuts in a parking lot somewhere.

Entrapta ate an entire order of mozzarella sticks before she finally spoke again. The daymoons had set and deep down, Catra had honestly kind of forgotten why they were hanging out tonight.

Tossing herself down next to Catra on the bed, Entrapta turned her laptop so they could both see. On the screen, Catra couldnt really understand what she was looking at. ust lines of code it seemed.

"Oh, sorry ,"Entrapta said, probably understanding why Catra was making a face like a toddler who just got tossed a rubik' s cube. She pressed a button and the display switched until Catra was looking at a normal iMessage app. "Here."

"Thanky.ou?"

"Y ou are now Huntara,"Entrapta explained.

Over the last couple of days, Catra had had a strange fleeting thought, imagining her life and her expanded romantic options if she suddenly woke up as Huntara. This job was the toughest one she'd

taken on, so putting herself in Huntara's shoes was helpful. Normal. Only slightly rage-inducing.

"Oh, thank you," Catra amended.

Entrapta slid the laptop onto Catra's thighs. "Instead of routing messages *through* Huntara, you can just send and receive them directly from Adora yourself."

Catra stared at the computer as if it was a ticking bomb. She couldn't touch it. Couldn't risk it sending something mortifying to Adora. This was the first time in years that they had a direct line to each other (assuming one didn't count their cellphones, Adora's house phone, and attending the same small high school together 5 days per week.)

So yes, maybe Catra's pulse quickening was an overreaction but she couldn't think of anything to distract from it. Just images of Past Adora, face full of anger, playing on a loop in her mind.

"No. No no. That's not like *being* the post office. That's opening someone's mail and shoving your own bullshit inside."

"I don't understand why you've become obsessed with this euphemism."

"That's mail fraud," Catra continued, voice raising. "That's a federal crime! Do you want to do federal time?!"

"You're panicking," Entrapta said calmly.

"No, *you* are!" Catra yelled because now she was just a fucking toddler.

She was afraid to hand the laptop back over in case it decided to send Adora an itemized list of Catra's darkest secrets and desires. Entrapta had the technology to do that.

Entrapta threw her a bone and moved the computer back to her own lap. Catra leapt to her feet, jumping over to the other side of the

room, far out of texting range.

"This wasn't what I had in mind when I hired you!"

"Oh, strange," Entrapta said in a neutral voice. "This is definitely what *I* had in mind. Would you prefer another app? I can probably whip up shadow versions of just about any other messaging program too."

"Please don't." Catra wasn't quite sure if she was whispering or yelling now.

"You're morally opposed to this tactic?" Entrapta asked. There was just the teeniest tiniest little glint in her eye.

This was a trick. Or a challenge. Even freaking out, Catra wasn't about to back down.

"I'm just thinking," she lied. "About what to open with. You're right – this is the next logical step in this plan."

Entrapta stared her down a moment longer before shrugging. "Well, start with hi?" She thrust the machine back in Catra's general direction.

"It's late," Catra stalled. The moons had set only about 20 minutes ago. Razz wouldn't even be back from bingo for another 3 hours.

Entrapta stood. She wasn't about to pass up an opportunity to leave somewhere early and lock herself up in her room for the week.

"My parents are still traveling," she explained as she packed up. "If you decide to come, the backdoor's open."

"That's what she said," Catra whispered, moving every time Entrapta shifted so she could maintain her distance from the computer.

"Amusing," Entrapta replied, flatly. She reached for the doorknob and was halfway outside before she tossed over her shoulder. "In case

you change your mind, I've added the program to your phone."

The door slammed before Catra had a chance to lunge after her.

Chapter End Notes

i regret to inform you that this chapter includes the only two mentions of lonnie in this whole fic.

You Know I’m Such a Fool for You

Chapter Notes

> this chapter's pretty gay. i mean, i know that's silly to state cause i'm very gay and catradora are extremely gay and i wrote a catradora story but like. rereading it, i could only think 'this is a pretty gay chapter. so much yearning.'
>
> oh, also just an fyi for formatting: when huntara sends a text, it just says her name. when anyone else pretends to be her , they put her name in quotes and include a little emoj because catra and entrapta are the worst/best.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The weekend should have been jam packed enough for Catra to completely forget about Entrapta’s app. She returned a bunch of cans for Razz, reffed a 6 year-olds’ soccer game with literally no sense of the correct rules, and made a few grocery deliveries. All the while, her phone set in her pocket, weirdly fucking heavy all of a sudden.

Entrapta only texted once to ask if Catra needed further instruction. Scorpia, on the other hand, sent a dozen messages trying to figure out exactly what the two of them were up to and trying to convince them to stop before anyone got hurt.

Catra
Both of those meatheads will be fine
The only victims are people who have to watch their awkward fumbling
So, me

Scorpia
To be fair, I *was* talking about you

Swearing to not speak to Scorpia for at least several days, Catra continued to ignore all of her options. She spent part of one evening writing up some additional Adora facts, which she recited to Huntara way too early on Monday morning before even saying hello.

Huntara was somehow deeply unconcerned that Adora was afraid of figs because she'd become convinced that they were full of dead bug bodies. What kind of monster couldn't even be mildly amused by that?!

Likewise, she didn't care to hear that Adora didn't like when all the different foods on her plate touched. Or that she wanted to be a reporter when she grew up and cover injustices all over the world. (Catra actually had no clue if that was even still true.) For a moment, Catra thought she'd found something the two dumbasses could talk about when Huntara made a slight noise at the mention of Adora's love for the worst singing and dancing competition shows. But as she went on to explain that Adora loved cheering for an underdog, Catra realized that Huntara had only noticed there was one stray hair hanging loose from her long braid.

Huntara cut her off before she could explain that Adora always wore socks to bed and that she never cursed, even though Catra taught her how when they were kids.

"I told you I can't memorize all this," Huntara grumbled.

"Has she at least texted you?" Catra could of course check herself and see but was still pretending that she'd never heard of this new power.

Huntara looked away quickly. "Yeah. She said hey."

"And what did you say in response?"

"Hey."

Catra screeched so loudly in frustration that a group of freshmen scurried down the hall to get away from her.

"Nope, still no mention of Huntara," Scorpia confirmed later at lunch. "I even asked in English. 'Hey, anyone you thinking of taking to homecoming?' But she just sorta got sad and said she'd probably tag along with some friends."

Ignoring how the mention of dances made her fur stand up a little, Catra asked, "You ever heard her mention other girls? Maybe that'll tell us what we're doing wrong."

"I'm not helping," Scorpia reminded her.

"You literally just did."

Scorpia frowned, taking a bite from one of the hard shell tacos she'd smuggled into the computer lab for them. "Well, I'm not anymore. Moving forward. Not being helpful at all. Ever."

Catra nodded and pretended to accept that. She was sure Scorpia could be worn down. Scorpia was a helper like Adora, actually. Maybe that was an angle? Catra could suggest that Adora help Huntara with memorizing that stupid playbook she was always whining about. Field hockey had plays too right?...probably? Maybe it was like a transferable skill or whatever.

Apparently, to Scorpia, not being helpful meant just sitting in silence. Catra had no idea where Entrapta was—she could usually be found in the lab but was unpredictable as hell and wandered off to explore, spy, or just fuck shit up whenever the mood hit her. Without Entrapta babbling about her work or Scorpia going on and on about fuck knows what, the silent treatment only took a few minutes to start seeping into Catra's brain.

Her strategy was trash. The tools she was working with—a walking energy drink and a sentient mountain—were useless. Catra had had *zero* experience with romance personally. As far as she could tell, it

wasnt something the universe planned on gifting to her . Everyone else had embarrassing crushes or met some idiot and called them their girlfriend or wrote messy subtweets about their doomed relationships. Aside from a couple short-lived crushes and that one time she spent a decade feeling weird about a certain annoying former best friend, Catra's love life had been a complete drought.

The thing was that Catra thought of herself as kinda limitless. She'd been handed a shit plate and she'd made it fucking work. No one else in this whole goddamn school had to go through the bullshit she battled and it gave her a certain kind of confidence. There was nothing Catra couldnt do, in her own mind at least.

So she wasnt gonna let this Huntara-Adora love connection thing get to her. She could do this. Entrapta and Scorpia were wrong. Everyone was wrong.

Catra was limitless.

"I dont know what that means," Scorpia said, her voice tearing through the quiet room like a fireworks show . "Oh, are you practicing calculus?"

"Uhyeah?" Catra lied. Scorpia didnt need to know that her internal spiral had suddenly decided to become a group discussion.

Catra was about to just open up next month's assigned reading for English and get a headstart on brainstorming topics for a dozen or so other people's essays, when she heard singing coming down the hall.

Before she had time to flee, as was the customary protocol, Sea Hawk strutted in. Instead of his usual outfits, which made one think of what would happen if a tornado hit a time machine, he was in some horrifying fake fur disaster.

Whoever built the Bright Moon Badger needed to seek intensive psychological treatment cause the thing was clearly inspired by

someone's very specific childhood nightmares of being attacked by feral woodland creatures. 6 feet of bright red (bright *red!* for a *badger*? cheap fabric with a giant gold belly in the center, which was half-hidden by a too-tight black turtleneck with BMH'printed on it in blocky letters. Paws the size of dinner plates with long black plastic claws extending out of them. And Sea Hawk had the fucking nerve to be wearing the costume *without* the head, which was good (because the head was actually pretty cursed with its wild dead eyes and menacing grin full of too many pointy teeth) and somehow worse (since no one expected to see a giant weasel with a dude's sweaty face popping out of it.

Somehow, he managed to find a large canvas bag with a strap long enough to loop over the huge body, wrapping over his shoulder and bulging full of junk at his hip. Behind him, Sea Hawk was pulling some kind of children's wagon with a large blue metal box inside, tipped over onto its back.

"Entrap-oh!" His voice went high and giggly at the end, which just made Catra even more annoyed for some illogical reason. "Scorpia and Catra! Perfect! Good day to you both. W e're raising money for-"

"No," Catra cut him of f. Unless that sentence ended with her own name, she wasn't interested.

"But I love fundraisers!" Scorpia whined. "T eamwork. Coming together for the common good."

Catra shoveled the last of her food into her mouth before standing and grabbing her bag. "I'll leave you two to it then. I've got places to be."

She didn't really , but she'd find some.

Sea Hawk jumped directly into her path. "But this is for a good cause."

"T o keep you out of trouble and off the streets?"

"T o ensure that our beloved hockey team has all of the eqipment they need to propel themselves to victory!" he yelled before thrusting his right fist into the air.

She looked at the metal box behind him again. It was definitely a mailbox, the kind that belonged on a corner and was not to be removed and dragged into a high school. Was this yet another person trying to get Catra wrapped up in their mail fraud schemes?

"I can't be an accomplice to more felonies right now ," she explained.

"I can respect that noble boundary ," Sea Hawk said, as if he'd been told this exact same line already. "I merely wish to of fer you an opportunity to send a candy gram to anyone who has caught your fancy."

"What the fuck is a candy gram?" Catra asked.

Scorpia sqealed, holding her pincers together under her chin. Her head tilted as her eyes filled with a hopeful, lovestruck look.

"A candy gram?" Scorpia repeated. "That's perfect! A sweet message to your sweetheart."

Sea Hawk knew an easy mark when he saw one. He practically leapt across the room and whipped a book-sized paper package out of his bag. He now carried an oversized box of cheap drugstore candy, those bland sugary pink and white hearts, except they were each as big as a cookie. Sea Hawk worked hard to entice them, twirling this giant fucking thing around so that Catra could see the back of the box. The front contained space for a sender name and receiver, with room for a short message on the opposite side.

"I love it!" Scorpia yelled and snatched the stupid candy box up before Sea Hawk could stop her. She reached into her pocket and threw all of her cash into his hands without even counting it. In a flash, she was scribbling a message, a marker having appeared seemingly out of nowhere.

"Who are you even sending that to?" Catra asked. As far as she knew, Scorpia didn't have eyes for anyone in particular. The big goof *loved* love though so maybe she was just gonna send a few out and cast a wide net.

"It's a secret," Scorpia mumbled, focused on trying to fit what seemed like an overly verbose message onto the package. Her cheeks were turning just a hint redder, which was suspicious.

Scorpia had never really kept a secret, not that Catra had remembered. She'd forced her way into Catra's life through her relentless friendship, blabbering a mile a minute about gods knew what constantly. Adora wasn't very happy when her teammate started hanging around more once they got to high school;and she was probably fucking pissed when Scorpia seemed to choose Catra when their friendship imploded. But Scorp was solid, always there for Catra. She had no problem shutting her mouth and not butting in if Scorpia wanted to keep something to herself for once.

Catra stuck around, awkwardly hovering until Scorpia was done with her card. Sea Hawk enthusiastically took the box when it was complete and tossed it into the mailbox.

Without looking.

Hmm.

Catra's brain lit up with the possibilities. Unlike any of the other gossip-hungry dolts in their class, Sea Hawk seemed to have no interest in poking into anyone's love life.

"How much?"

"Wha?.."

Catra huffed at his blank face. "How much for one?"

"Wildcat?!" Scorpia gasped in excitement.

"Dont," Catra warned her . "Bird Brain, how much for the fucking thing?"

"$5," he told her , whipping another one out of his bag.

She'd have to invoice Huntara for this expense, Catra thought as she tried her best to fake the handwriting.

I have a conf ection to ake: I think you're cute,' she scribbled, making the message just barely legible. She couldn't imagine Huntara cared much about penmanship.

"Nothing," Huntara reported.

"How!?" Catra hissed at her.

She made a *pun* for fuck's sake! She'd stooped down to Adora's terrible sense of what constituted comedy and had still gotten jackshit out of it!

Because fate was cruel, Sea Hawk had delivered Adora's candygram in the middle of Art. Catra got to watch first-hand as the dummy's face went from surprise as she read Huntara's name to utter confusion once she took in the message on the back. Glimmer and Bow didn't even look excited, like Catra expected them to. Just kinda disappointed and sympathetic. Adora's eyes had scanned the room, probably looking for any eavesdroppers. Catra made sure to seem busy right before Adora locked in on her. She heard Adora promise her two besties that she'd explain more later .

Catra wasn't about to share any of that currently so she just motioned impatiently for the big lug to answer. Huntara shrugged in return, face shifting into the frustrated frown that was becoming a trademark of all of their interactions.

"She found me between classes and said thanks. It didn't even seem like she wanted to do it cause then she just ran of f before I could

think of what to say back."

Catra didn't bother asking why Huntara didn't follow up in text. She'd seen the thread. For some reason, Huntara had taken Catra's suggestion about bonding over sportsbook plays or whatever to mean that she should send Adora overly detailed and criminally boring messages about specific formations. She'd probably put Adora to sleep or something cause the girl only sent back that' s so cool. time for bed. night.'

"I'm gonna strangle these two dumbasses," Catra mumbled later after she'd caught Entrapta up on the latest non-happenings in this project.

Their Etherian History teacher had called in sick so class had been moved to the gym for Coach Casta to keep an eye on them. No one seemed to give a shit that Catra had *already* had Gym that day so she was forced to join as well. At least Coach didn't expect the surprise additions to her period to do any exercise. Instead, she'd told them all to treat it like a study hour and turned her attention to the other 25 kids half-assing their way through some stretches. Catra had dragged Entrapta under the bleachers they were instructed to sit on so that she could rant about this mess.

And if that meant she was out of sight for Adora and Glimmer, that was just a bonus. Adora had straight up *startled* when she came out of the locker room and saw Catra sitting there nonchalantly cleaning her claws. So embarrassing for her.

Entrapta gave her a look that she couldn't figure out. "Y ou haven't been using the app I made you. That's interesting."

"Why? Why is that interesting?"

"Seems like it would solve this problem." Entrapta' s weird look deepened, making Catra feel like she was a bug pinned under a microscope. "Are you still *planning* to solve this problem?"

"I told you why that wouldn't work."

"I wonder if there's a difference between telling someone something' and 'saying words that unintentionally obscure the truth.' I should research this more," Entrapta mumbled to herself.

Catra didn't fully understand what Entrapta was talking about. But she didn't need to get it to hate it.

Before she could fire back, Entrapta pulled her phone from one of her many pockets.

"They're both here now. Let's use this opportunity for gathering more information," Entrapta suggested.

Huntara was indeed in this class as well. Catra peeked her head out from under the bleachers just enough to get a glimpse of Huntara joining the others in doing laps around the basketball court. Adora was at the front of the group, because of course she was, easily keeping a fast pace. It was a downright injustice how much Adora's sad uniform worked for her. Catra looked like she stole her retired uncle's old sleep clothes in their school-required shorts and t-shirt. Adora had the nerve to look like a godsdamn catalog model/fitness influencer, blonde ponytail bobbing around, cheeks flushed with exertion, ugly gray and red outfit managing to flatter her slight curves and highlight her muscles.

It was a welcome sight when Catra tore her eyes away to find Huntara, a person whose presence had the same effect as being dunked in a pool of ice water. Though she was an athlete too, Huntara was obviously built more for power than speed. She jogged towards the back of the pack, looking completely nonchalant.

Catra sighed. "Why isn't she trying to talk to Adora? This should be easy. Bond over drills or something."

"I think lesbians and power tools is just a stereotype."

"I meant sports drills!"

"What are sports dri-"

"Shush!"

For the rest of the period, Catra focused on everything Huntara did. And only Huntara. She made a pact with herself to not look at anyone else. This was important recon for their project and getting distracted was not an option.

Huntara was a dull subject, though, so it was fine to let her eyes wander to Adora occasionally.

They had been forced to play dodgeball. Adora was fucking *lethal* at dodgeball. She never missed an opportunity to get someone out and she somehow had a strategy that let her work from end to end of the court, picking off classmates as she went. And she found the whole thing so funny, her goofy laugh filling up the whole gym.

Ugh.

After that class headed into the locker room and Catra's own group was allowed to leave early, she and Entrapta stayed behind. The latter had apparently been taking notes on the match and had a lot of statistics that she felt the need to share with Catra immediately.

In the quiet gym, it wasn't hard to notice the squeak of sneakers on the court. One lone set of footsteps moving slowly (maybe reluctantly) towards the door. Catra glanced out to make sure this person wasn't overhearing Entrapta' s relentless analysis of Adora's defense.

Stumbling back into the room was Adora herself. She was back in her regular clothes, jeans and a white tshirt with a horribly colorful picture of a unicorn. Her eyes were glazed over, head tilted in deep thought. Her feet seemed to be moving automatically towards the door. That wasn't surprising;Adora could probably be in a coma and

her body would get up and sleepwalk to class and practice. Her schedule was down to a T, obsessively organized so not a minute was ever really wasted. Adora used to even schedule fRiEnD tImE 😜 into her daily planner, reminding Catra that 'socialization' was so important, like she'd read it in an article about how to be a normal teenager.

To be fair, she probably had.

Catra watched as Adora almost walked right onto a stray sweater that had been accidentally left on the floor in everyone's rush to run out of the room. She had to fight the urge to call out and warn Adora, imagining watching the dummy trip on it and go stumbling on the slippery gym floor. But as a rule, the two of them no longer looked out for each other, as they had once promised to always do. Through sheer luck, Adora averted the sweater at the last second and that seemed to jolt her into the present. In a flash, she was shaking herself out of it and righting her course.

The rest of the class began to stream out of the locker room then, all pushing past each other to hustle to their next destination. Among them was Huntara who gave about a half-second glance at Adora before they each left the gym and headed in separate directions.

For as much as Catra had trained herself *out* of trying to catalog Adora's every mood, she still knew a potentially serious problem when she saw it. Adora was spiraling in her giant head so something was definitely off. Of course, she couldn't just storm right up to Adora and yell "Tell me what's wrong so I can fix it!" Maybe she could get Scorpia to dig up some dirt. Or Catra could try talking to Bow? Adora always kept her real feelings swallowed deep down into that bottomless pit she called a stomach though, so that was probably a useless tactic.

Huntara could ask. A text checking in on Adora might actually finally help her get a fucking clue.

ust a few words. T otally doable and not weird. No chance of this backfiring in any way.

"The fuck, Driluth?!" Huntara growled.

Before Catra could react, she found her back pressed to the wall of the auditorium. She'd been hovering and expecting an update from DT, not to be gripped and held up by the front of her shirt like she was in a cheesy afterschool special.

"Didn't anyone teach you that conversations begin with 'hello' usually?" she sassed back, faking a cool that didn't quite reach her voice.

Huntara used her free hand to force her phone too close to Catra's face.

Huntara
nice shirt, blondie

Adora
Thanks!
I got it from the mall

Catra fought to not groan out loud. Stars a-fucking-live, Adora was already giving nothing.

"Was this you?" Huntara asked. That phone was practically pressed into Catra's cheek now.

The final bell for the day had rung and most folks had scampered off towards home or extracurriculars. A couple of kids wandered in the direction of the auditorium, took one look at Catra and Huntara, and quickly shuf fled inside without intervening.

There was no way out of this one, it seemed.

"You said you didn't want to memorize a bunch of shit," Catra explained. "So I'm just going around you."

She closed both eyes and waited to be punched. You were supposed to lean into the impact, right? Wait, no. You were supposed to go the same direction as it. Play dead?

"Hmm. Not a bad idea," Huntara said finally. Both the phone and the fist in her shirt disappeared so Catra slowly opened her eyes to find Huntara giving her what was almost a small smile. "My bad. Wouldn't kill you to give a heads up before you pull something like this next time."

She attempted to give what was probably supposed to be a reassuring pat on the arm. Instead Huntara socked Catra right in the bicep.

"Keep it up," Huntara encouraged before jogging off towards the gym.

Catra watched her leave, heart still pounding from the adrenaline of a near-death experience.

"You used the app," Entrapta said out of nowhere, sending Catra back towards cardiac arrest.

She felt her tail fluff out in warning but Entrapta rounded the corner of the building, already looking back down at her iPad.

"Did I choose the most dangerous spot in the world to loiter today?"

"If you were waiting for DT, they snuck in while you were being accosted," Entrapta said. "They wanted me to tell you that they've put out feelers', whatever that means, and had no new information."

"What are you even doing here?"

"Testing a few hypotheses," she said idly. "In particular, I was curious if DT's ability to morph their physiology would be helpful."

Catra blinked slowly. DT had been politely asked to never shapeshift on campus after they got caught writing themself hall passes as Mr. Archer. It hadn't occurred to her to ask them to just pretend to be Huntara and…nope, that was a line even Catra felt weird about crossing.

"I don't think that's a good idea, Trap."

"I thought you might say that." Without another word, Entrapta began to walk away, heading the same direction as Huntara.

"Where you going?" Catra called after her.

"Hockey field."

Catra had several commitments she'd made for after school, like always. Her brain logically knew she needed the money. Her feet sprinted after Entraptra immediately.

After sophomore year, Catra just naturally avoided this part of the school. There wasn't any need for her to be near the field anymore and, honestly, she'd seen more than her fair share of games, practices, scrimmages, Adora doing push-ups, Adora working on dumb trick moves, Adora smiling towards the sideline at Catra, etc. Boring. Absolutely boring.

Scorpia never asked her to attend another game and Catra didn't offer. Everyone seemed to understand that this part of her life was dead to her now. Everyone except Entrapta, of course, who hopped up into the metal stands and took a seat, way up at the top where they could see everything and anyone who looked up there could definitely notice the two of them.

"Could you pick a more covert spot?" Catra hissed as she tried to stay low to the ground while climbing the steps.

"Why? We're not hiding. We're supporting our friend." She then whipped out her tablet again and set about paying zero attention to

what was happening below.

Catra suddenly was faced with a conundrum: What the fuck was she supposed to do with her body? It felt too large, too exposed, too out of place.

In the years since Adora had picked up hockey, Catra had learned where she belonged. In this part of Adora's life, at least. It actually wasn't too far from where Entrapta had chosen to sit – up at the top of the bleachers so she had a bird's eye view of Adora's form and could give notes (heh, notes! It was mostly just 'your stick could use some work' and 'yeah, fuck that girl for cutting you off! Let's slash her tires!'). But that was the rhythm she and Adora had fallen into, the pattern, the steps, the placing. And now Catra was crawling up the stairs like a fucking creep whose bones felt too big and gawky and she was *sure* that if she looked down, Adora would be staring back at her, silently demanding that she get the hell out of Adora's space.

It didn't help that the oversized black and red checkered flannel that Catra wore today over her cut-up jean shorts and the Blackhearts tank top didn't *actually* belong to her and had been leant to her by Adora. That was kinda on Adora though – she never asked for her shit back so Catra never offered. It was just sitting in *Adora's* flannel, on *Adora's* field felt-

"You're being very awkward," Entrapta told her, eyes still glued to her screen. "You just have to sit down. That shouldn't be too hard." When Catra didn't move, Entrapta added, *way too fucking loud,* "Is this about Adora?"

Catra dove onto the bleachers next to Entrapta's feet like a grenade had been thrown and it was up to her to cover it. Flat on the floor, hopefully completely out of sight, she looked up at her friend.

"Can you be cool, bro?!"

One of Entrapta's pigtails floated down and tickled at Catra's ear. "It's likely not helpful for me to point out the irony of your words, is it?"

"Is anyone looking?"

She watched Entrapta actually be kind enough to give a glance around the field. "At us? No. I believe we're very early."

Catra peeked her head up for a second, still trying to be cool. So far, there was only a couple of players on the field, bullshitting around idly. Scorpia wasn't there so Catra's excuse for hanging around was gone. But she had Entrapta and no one would believe that Catra would have brought *Entrapta,* Etheria's least subtle person, to spy on A-anyone.

That was a weird thought.

Anyway. Unfortunately, of the handful of players on the field, one was Mermista, Sea Hawk's...something. T ormentor? Tormentee? Their relationship was pretty confusing all around but she was down on the grass, laying out in the sun and texting. The worst thing about Mermista was that she had a big mouth – if she noticed Catra there, soon everyone would hear about it and Catra would never know peace again. But truly, the very fucking *worst* thing that could happen, soon did.

Right as Catra was breathing a sigh of relief that maybe she could fling herself off the back of these 10-foot tall bleachers and make a run for it, Adora jogged out onto the field.

Catra hated mesh. She could only associate it with the smell of sweat and gym equipment and other gross shit. It really was a shame because she thought she'd actually look pretty hot in a mesh top but no, *certain* jocks had ruined mesh forever. And here Adora came, ruining it all over again by having the nerve to look like someone's damn teenage dream.

She was all but moving in slo-mo, sleeveless non-descript black practice jersey and shorts on, long blonde hair pulled up into a bun. Even from way too many feet away, Adora's skin looked stupid soft

and Catra immediately tried to wedge herself back down into the bench to hide from that knowledge forever.

Just barely , through the cracks, she could make out Adora heading over to the sidelines and plopping herself down sideways, really lez-spreading all over that bench. Towel and water bottle in hand, she said a quick hello to her teammates before pulling her phone out.

"Excellent!" Entrapta said too loudly . "Right on schedule." She glanced down and must have caught Catra's questioning raised eyebrow. "Did you know that statistically people check their phones every 4 minutes?"

Before Catra could ask how that fact was related, her own phone dinged in her pocket. That was strange because 50% of the people who texted her were sitting next to her. And because her phone was always on silent. Catra checked it, already incredibly worried about how much attention Entrapta was paying to the field.

"Huntara" 😈
Cute
I was thinking of expanding my fashion choices
You down for going together sometime?

"What did you do?!" Catra did her best to shout in the quietest whisper possible.

"Testing a hypothesis," Entrapta repeated.

Adora made a face at her phone, completely fucking puzzled. Seriously? Huntara had started bugging her out of nowhere, sending her stupid candy, and Adora still didn't get it?

She chewed on her lip for a moment, head tilting. She seemed to be trying to work through what was happening here. Briefly, Catra began to fill with anticipation that Adora might catch on... or, at least, that's what she was telling herself that weird feeling in her blood was. It was tight, constricting. Just jitters for this coming to an end.

But Adora finally shook her head, almost disbelieving, and released her lip. Without much more thought or care, she typed out a short message. Catra raced to grab her phone.

Adora
Sure!
I mean, football season's starting so youll probably be pretty busy soon
But let's do that whenever youre free

Catra watched as Adora then put her phone away to focus on the super important task of staring off into space. Not exactly the actions of someone who gave a single flying shit about someone's crush on them. That realization made it feel like something in Catra's chest uncoiled, as she relaxed against the bleachers, letting out a slow breath.

"Hmm," Entrapta hummed, like she'd just figured out the same thing. Except when Catra looked up, her friend was staring at her instead of Adora. "Fascinating."

She didnt like the way Entrapta was examining her . That was not what this was supposed to be about. This was just a job, not a chance for Entrapta to unravel the mysteries of Catra's brain.

"Watch it," she warned.

Entrapta's piercing eyes said that she would definitely *not* be watching it. "When you and Adora stopped having contactwhose idea was that?"

"Mine!" Catra replied instinctively . It was very important to her that everyone believed this was her choice. *She* had rejected Adora. Technically, it was *after* Adora had rejected her first but who cared. "It was mutual," Catra decided.

"It was your idea or it was mutually discussed and agreed upon?" Entrapta pressed.

Neither and both, really. "There was a thing that happened and then we didn't talk for a couple days and then suddenly we were yelling at each other and that was the end of it," Catra rushed to say.

Entrapta nodded while Catra caught her breath. "So. You're not sure," Entrapta concluded. She looked back out at Adora and Catra's eyes followed against her will. "Fascinating," Entrapta repeated.

Chapter End Notes

sea hawk isn't the school mascot. he "borrowed" the costume...and the mailbox.

next week preview - catra gets a surprise. also, razz!

You've Got Me Wrapped Around Your Finger

Chapter Notes

> hiii!just an fyi - this is a long chapter . i started having too much fun. (catra, however, is having no fun 😬)
>
> two people commented about the chapter titles and yes, i was listening to 'linger' by the cranberries on a damn loop for most of the time i was writing this fic. though, if you want to throw some extra feels onto this chapter, 'i can break your heart too' by the aces was a big influence for the first half.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra didn't bother sticking around after that as the rest of the team started to stumble out of the locker room and onto the field for practice.

Between Entrapta's weird behavior and whatever embarrassing attention Scorpia was likely to bring to her, Catra thought it was best to just take off and set about all the shit she needed to get done.

"You're distracted," Razz said, swinging a broom near Catra's head as she hovered in the old lady's doorway. "These are raspberries."

"Yeah, I know," Catra replied, shaking the bag at her. She'd had to go to three different grocery stores just to find ones that seemed high-quality enough for Razz's damn pie.

"I asked for blackberries," Razz insisted. That godsforsaken old broom, half-falling apart with straw sticking out all over the place, swung back around towards Catra again.

She shifted out of the way to dodge it, trying to force the berries into Razz's free hand. "You specifically said raspberries!" she argued back.

"Nonsense!" Razz's thick accent of indiscernible origins made the s's sound like 'honshensh,' which Catra had to admit was kind of hilarious and cute. When she wasn't being so deadly with a common household object, Razz was just 4 feet of wrinkles and wirey waist-length white hair. Catra didn't have a nurturing bone in her body, but even she could see that Razz was adorable. She was, however, awful at picking desserts. "Who wants a raspberry pie?"

"Who the hell wants a *blackberry* pie?! It's chocolate or nothing, Razz!"

"You're distracted!" she insisted again. "Always thinking about that girl. Just go send your messages and leave an old lady alone."

This time when the broom came back, Catra was too stunned to move and took a heavy whack right on the head.

"Are you kidding me right now?" Catra asked, but Razz was already closing the front door in her face. "Fine! Then I'm not coming by to help you hide your winnings after bingo tonight."

"Nonshensh!" Razz yelled through the door. "I'll see you at 11. I bet your girl likes raspberries."

Catra returned to her room with a bag full of random berries that she hadn't budgeted for and had no interest in eating. Razz was right – she was distracted. (Razz was also wrong – the old bitty had definitely asked for *raspberries* and not blackberries but even if Catra had her on tape saying it, Razz would wave it off and claim she was framed.)

As Razz had creepily predicted, a quirk that Catra was still getting used to after almost two years of living together, she couldn't quite keep her mind off of what the hell was up with Adora. Something seemed to be bugging Adora and try as she might, Catra couldn't help but feel the urge to figure this out.

Now that she and Entrapta had broken the seal, Catra was feeling slightly less scared shitless about this texting thing. After all, there was a brief period of time, after she'd finally been able to save up and buy a phone, where Catra and Adora texted constantly. She just needed to tap into that and ignore that every single thing about these circumstances was different.

She sighed as she threw herself onto the bed. This was so dumb. Was Catra really about to start regularly and intentionally breaking her silence with Adora? And for what? Cause Adora was being a little weird? She had plenty of friends who could check on her. Just because Catra knew her better than them and knew how convincing Adora could be when she swore everything was okay, didn't mean she had to be the one to intervene.

Now, on the other hand, it was *Adora.*

Catra's brain apparently thought that was reason enough to check on the dummy, just because Catra had cared about Adora since forever or something stupid and naive like that.

"Huntara" 😈
Hey
Were you okay today?

Adora
Oh hey!
Yeah, totally
Totes
Why?

"Huntara" 😈
You just seemed kinda off?
Like I saw you completely spaced out a couple times

Adora
Oh, you noticed that?
Nope, I'm fine

Huntara” 😈
Right. Totes...
Well, if you're not, you can tell me
Or whatever, blondie

Super cool,’ Catra chastised herself. *‘You try to do a casual vibe check and instead you immediately go for asking her spill her guts out? How fucking gay.’*

But that’s what a person looking to date someone would do, right? Or at least, that’s what Catra would want someone to do. Ask about her and learn all the subtle ways to tell how she’s feeling.

She used to know those things about Adora. Which specific lip bite meant she was trying to be coy and which one meant she was actually worried. Dumb shit like that. Dumb shit that Catra had taken for granted and didn't even know anymo-

Adora
Okay, it’s not a big deal
But there is something small going on
Like no reason for anyone to worry!
But I'm kinda screwed
I've got recruiters reaching out to me
But my grades have fallen off a little since sophomore year
And I'm not testing well
And I'm pretty sure I'm gonna crash and burn
That’s all I can think about lately

Adora
Shoot. Sorry!
You didn't ask all that

Catra blinked at the long spiel. Apparently she still had it. With one small poke, Catra could still unravel the mysteries of Adora’s giant head. It wasn't at all surprising that Adora was struggling or that she'd been trying to play it off as not a big deal, probably hiding it from all the people who could help her.

It made Catra so annoyed that she got up and charged into the kitchen to find something to distract her from all of her resentment. All of these people got to be in Adora's life and not a single one was noticing what she was going through.

She found a box of noodles before slamming a pot down on the stove, the loud bang making her feel a little better, though Hordak would probably be sending her a letter complaining about noise again. Catra tried to turn all her attention to starting dinner, as if she hadn't made this particular meal a dozen times a month for most of her life.

When she finally ran out of prep tasks, which consisted of two whole things, she had no excuse for leaving Adora hanging.

"Huntara" 😈
Nah, it's cool
I can relate
You seem real smart tho
Maybe just a strong study buddy will give you that extra edge?

Adora
Yeah, I guess
I lost my study buddy
Bow tries but he doesnt explain things the way she did

"Huntara" 😈
That sucks
Any way you can get her back?

Adora
Oh no, I dont think she' s ever gonna speak to me again
Things went REALLY bad between us
She made it clear that she's done with me
Anyway, sorry
We can talk about something fun

And because Catra didn't consider herself a total creep, she agreed that they should switch over to another topic that *wasn't* what she was pretty sure was becoming a discussion about her and Adora's flaming trash bag of a friendship.

Too bad, her fingers didn't agree with her.

"Huntara" 😈
I'm fine chatting about whatever
You sure she was just a buddy?

Adora
What makes you ask that?

"Uhhhhhh," Catra groaned aloud as if Adora was there in the room with her, catching her in her own web of bullshit. She couldn't exactly write back the truth (which mostly amounted to how incredibly gay you were for each other. Always together, always holding hands or hugging). so she panicked until an easy lie slipped out.

"Huntara" 😈
Just that kind of break up' sounds deep
Maybe more than friends?

That torturous fucking cloud with three dots kept popping up and disappearing so many times that Catra started to think Entrapta's app might be buggy. Finally, after way too many minutes and an embarrassing number of times that Catra held her breath, Adora wrote back.

Adora
She doesn't want that
Anyway, what are you up to tonight?

It took a moment for Catra to realize she'd been pressing her claws into the palms of her hands in anticipation. She took a slow breath out, extending her fingers and trying to stay cool.

Less Catra, more Huntara. Any unresolved crap with Adora would just have to wait until the planet burned out or something. There was no time to get into that. Money had to be made.

She had no idea what someone like Huntara did in her free time. Ate bolts? Got chased by pitchfork-carrying townspeople? Who knows?

"Huntara" 😈
Making myself some dinner
What about you?

Adora
That's cool!
I'm just hanging out in my room
I'm not much of a cook
What are you making?

"Huntara" 😈
Me either, blondie
It's just mac and cheese from a box
Might add some crumbled goldfish to make it fancy

Catra went back to literally watching water come to a boil before she realized her mistake.

Adora
That's a funny coincidence
That's how someone used to make it for me

Less Catra! *Much much less* Catra! Why couldn't she say a protein shake or a deer's side or something that made sense for Huntara?

Adora
I'll let you get back to that
Thanks for chatting!

Unsure how to close this out, Catra just texted back a peace sign emoji.

She didn't have anything planned for this evening besides helping an old lady hide cash in her cabinets in a few hours so Catra wisely decided to use the free time to panic wildly. Her thoughts were a heartstopping rollercoaster from "what are you doing, you idiot?" to "oh my gods, Adora still thinks about me." There were a few loop-de-loops in the middle, mostly "what if I gave up and tanked this whole thing?" and "what if I just tried to graduate a semester early and run far away from all of this?"

Catra was in the middle of writing (and deleting and writing and deleting) a novel-long text to Scorpia about her dilemma when there was a knock on the door.

She checked the clock – it was almost midnight. It was possible that she'd been so busy obsessing about everything that she'd missed Razz's slow, lumbering footsteps coming up the stairs and the old bitty was coming by to summon Catra. It must have been a bad night;if Razz had won big, she'd be singing and laughing outside Catra's door, yelling at Hordak that she dared him to come try and shut her up.

Dragging herself out of bed, Catra put her half-eaten bowl of mac and cheese on the counter and went to the door.

"You're late," was already out of her mouth before she even got a look at who she was welcoming into her home.

Catra's mouth dropped open at the confused face Adora made.

Adora.

Adora Gray was standing in front of her for the first time in 23 months, looking.terrible. Yes, terrible' is what Catra had decided to go with and she wasn't taking further questions on that. Adora was dressed in sweats and a crimson razorback tank with the school's logo on it, far too little clothes for a chilly autumn night. Catra was cold just looking at her , tugging her flannel tighter and hoping that Adora didnt remember that it was actually hers. But Adora' s eyes

were on Catra's legs instead as she shifted awkwardly in the doorway, an unfortunate reminder that Catra had pulled off her jeans and was now just in a pair of boxers.

"Umhello?" Catra asked. She wasn't sure if she was in shock or if her rage hadn't quite caught up to her because her brain was too busy trying to process what the hell would make Adora show up completely out of the fucking blue. Last time they spoke, Catra had been pretty clear that they were never ever gonna talk again. She thought that was exactly what Adora wanted too.

Adora's blue eyes shot up to Catra's face before she shoved her hands into her pockets. "Hey . Sorry to bother you."

"Are you lost?"

"Can I come in?" Adora asked instead. Her hair was kind of a mess, random strands hanging out of her ponytail, like she'd been tugging at it. Her face wasn't much better , drawn all tight. Anxiety was coming off her in waves.

Catra moved out of the doorway, leaving it open to go sit back down on her bed. If Adora decided to come in, that was on her. Of course, she shuffled in, obnoxious white crocs squeaking on Catra's fake brown checkered linoleum floors. Adora closed the door behind herself and moved to stand in the middle of the room, glancing around the space for the first time.

Catra's eyes darted around to see if there was anything incriminating sitting out for Adora to catch. Her laptop was closed on the island. And it wasn't like she had a weird Adora/Huntara shrine built up in the corner. So she let herself relax on the bed, clearly projecting that she wasn't at all concerned about Adora standing in the middle of her home.

"Nice place," Adora said.

Catra just hummed in response.

"So," Adora continued. "How are you?"

"Living the dream," Catra drawled back.

Adora nodded. She took her hands out to reach for her hair, rethought that halfway there, and shoved them back into her pockets.

"What do you want, Adora?" Catra asked. In the back of her mind, she remembered the last time she'd said that. That awful fight they'd gotten into in the middle of the school's courtyard. All the vicious shit they'd yelled at each other until Catra was screaming at Adora to just get over herself and say what she wanted.

Adora's eyes were glazed over, like she was thinking the same thing. A decade of friendship flushed over one moment of weakness and two idiots who couldn't be honest with themselves, even with everything on the line.

"I don't know," Adora said. With a helpless shrug, she repeated, "I don't know." Her eyes fell to the floor. "I was talking to someone and they said something that reminded me of you."

Without making it obvious, Catra looked back over to the kitchen. Her half-full bowl was still there, along with the other serving that she'd left in the pot for later. Hopefully Adora wasn't smart enough to put that together.

"And?" Catra asked.

Adora chewed on her lip nervously. "I don't know. I just," she trailed off. When she looked up, her eyes were so hopeless and defeated that it took all of Catra's willpower not to rush over and take Adora in her arms.

Those days were long gone. Things weren't the same anymore. Catra couldn't just hug Adora or cuddle in bed with her, hiding

compliments in teases until they both felt better. Adora had made her choice and they both had to live with it now.

"You just?".

"Thought you might want-"Adora stopped and gave Catra a long look that she didn't understand. She seemed to shake it off before recovering. "I just thought I should see you,"Adora finished instead.

"Should?" Catra repeated.

Adora must have missed the annoyed tone in her voice because she pushed right past that. "I was thinking about all the things we used to do together."

"It's Friday night,"Catra pointed out, not wanting to be forced into this trip down memory lane. "Shouldn't you be at a party or whatever popular people do?"

Adora scoffed. "I'm not popular."

"You're captain of the field hockey team. Everyone likes you."

"Not everyone,"Adora muttered. Something in her voice felt like a knife.

Catra chose not to respond so they watched each other in silence for a long moment.

"Could I have some water?"Adora asked finally. Apparently she was planning on staying for a while, which didn't really work with Catra's plan of trying to ignore her existence.

But Catra wasn't a total terror, so she dutifully went into the kitchen, grabbing the bowl on the way and trying to hide it in the sink. Catra got down one of the few cups she owned and filled it from the tap. She didn't bother handing it to Adora, instead leaving it on the island for the dummy to get on her own.

Then a thought hit. "You hungry? I got some raspberries."

Adora seemed surprised. "Oh. Yeah, sure."

Catra pulled the fruit from the fridge and tossed it over. She didn't watch as Adora immediately dug into the bag, the sound of plastic seeming loud in the quiet room. The dummy started munching away quickly and Catra had to ignore how familiar it was, to be sitting there while Adora gorged herself with abandon.

Except, it wasn't cute anymore, like Catra used to think. And she wasn't about to look up and let herself be convinced otherwise.

With what sounded like a mouthful of berries, Adora told her, "These are sooo good. Raspberries are my favorite."

"That's dumb. Everyone knows strawberries are the best."

"They're too sweet," Adora argued. "I like how raspberries are a little tart. They're underappreciated."

Catra rolled her eyes. Adora always had the dumbest hot takes.

"You want some?" Adora asked, though Catra was sure there were practically none left already.

She shook her head. "All yours."

"You remember that ice cream place on South Street? They had a mint sweet cream flavor once and I mixed it with their raspberry sorbet. The *best!*"

"Hmm," Catra mumbled. "I do love mint."

"I know!" Adora said. Her voice was all bubbly and happy now. "I thought about you. I took a picture to show you... someday."

Catra looked up to find her smiling and holding the last handful of berries. As their eyes met, Catra chose to focus on how weirdly

normal Adora seemed, like they interacted all the time, and not the rush of excitement that shot through her own body.

Adora thought of her? Adora took a photo in the hopes that she'd be able to share it one day?

"Remember how you used to always convince me that we should eat mint m&ms right before bedtime instead of brushing our teeth?" Adora said, laughing a little at the memory.

Catra shrugged. That was one of her better lifehacks. "It smells the same as toothpaste."

"It was a terrible idea."

"It was a brilliant idea!" Catra argued. She could feel the corners of her mouth ticking up into a devious grin. "Your mom never figured it out."

"Until I had a mouth full of cavities!" Adora descended into giggles. "She watched us like a hawk after that."

Catra waited until Adora regained her composure, patiently smiling back. "How is she?" One of the worst parts of being cast out of Adora's life was losing her connection to the Grays, the closest thing Catra had ever had to loving parental figures. Marlena remembered Catra's birthday more often than her own former guardian did.

"The same," Adora said with a shrug. "She still asks about you like once a week. She, uh, really wants to know where you're going next fall."

"Other side of the globe as soon as I get my diploma," Catra answered automatically. She'd never really lied to Adora before, not to her face. It was shocking how quickly it came out, like Catra wasn't still just gonna be a 6-hour drive away as they'd always planned growing up.

Adora’s smile was gone suddenly. “Really?”

“There’ s nothing here for me,” Catra said quietly .

“So that’ s it? You’re just gonna run away?” Adora's tone held a surprising amount of barely restrained anger.

Catra forced herself to give a cold, empty laugh. “Running away implies I’m leaving something.”

With a wavering voice, Adora started to say, “What about m-” but was cut off by the glare Catra shot at her. “Uh, Entrapta? Scorpia?”

“W e'll K T or whatever .”

“Catra. What about all the plans you had? All the stuf f we were gonna do the last summer before college. The roadtrip. School! Y ou can't just-”

“I can do whatever the hell I want. Y ou don't get to decide anymore, Adora.”

Her eyes were frantic now, hands finally dropping the empty bag to twine into her hair. “W e had plans.”

“You had plans,” Catra corrected. *“I* was supposed to just follow you around while you lived your dream. Go to *your* top school, move to *your* favorite city, tag alone while *you* traveled the world.”

“W ell, what do *you* want, Catra?” Adora yelled in frustration.

For a second, everything in the room went still. All the background noise – street sounds, the whirring of the fridge, Hordak’ s creepy tv shows – quieted. Catra was pretty sure her own breathing stopped.

The fucking nerve of Adora. To stand there and demand an answer that she herself refused to give two years before.

"It's too la-" Catra began, forcing herself to cut whatever this was off at the knees. She was interrupted by her front door opening suddenly.

Adora shrieked at the surprise intrusion, jumping out of the way as Razz barreled in. She didn't bother acknowledging that there was anyone else in the apartment, which seemed to rattle Adora more. Her eyes looked to Catra for help as Razz headed straight for the mostly-empty cupboards.

"Sugar," Razz muttered quietly to herself. She closed one cabinet and went to another. "Sugar. No, not here. Sugar?" she sang.

"Razz, never—not once—have I ever had sugar here. You know that," Catra said.

"Nonshensh!" Razz went to search in the cabinets above the fridge where Catra literally never put anything. Funny how the old broad was able to reach heights here that she claimed to need Catra's help with in her own kitchen.

Somehow, through magic or evil wizardry, Razz pulled a small box of plain white sugar from the cupboard. "Ah hah!"

"The hell?" Catra asked before an equally important question came to mind. "What do you need sugar for at midnight?"

Razz turned to the two of them but rather than answering, she seemed to notice Adora for the first time. She pushed her giant coke bottle glasses up from the edge of her nose and blinked silently several times.

Adora didn't quite seem to know what to do with her body. She tried to shrink smaller, lowering her shoulders and head like she could hide in the mostly-empty room. Razz shuffled closer a few steps, Adora backing up to maintain their distance. Catra couldn't help snickering quietly as Adora, a person who regularly body-checked people at full speed, looked frightened by a tiny old woman who was

mostly a mountain of hair and the world's largest housecoat. Razz did have a bit of a reputation around town as being a kooky loose canon though, so maybe Adora's reaction was sorta justified.

The dummy was even more afraid when Razz addressed her for the first time, "Mara, dearie, I'm so glad you're here!"

Adora frowned and looked to Catra for answers. Just because she knew Razz didn't mean she understood what planet the woman was ever on.

"My name's actually Adora."

"Mara," Razz repeated, to Catra's amusement. "It's been ages. You shouldn't stay away for so long."

And even though Adora had never once met this strange woman before, Catra watched as she crumbled under Razz's scolding. Adora lowered her guard a bit and gave Razz a genuinely remorseful smile.

"You're right. I'm sorry about that."

Razz reached over to gently pat Adora on the hand, which was very rude considering the amount of time she spent swinging a broom at Catra, who'd done nothing but help her out.

"Good," Razz told her. "You have to come around more often."

Adora's eyes lofted back over to Catra. "Is that is.that what *you* want?"

In a flash, Razz jumped back into the kitchen, looking through everything again. Adora and Catra remained locked in on each other, both tense and still.

It didn't really seem to matter what Catra wanted. She never got it anyway. And there was no guarantee that if she asked, Adora would bother staying. They were both heading in opposite directions in their

life. Trying to force a friendship right now would only make it hurt worse in the long run.

"Do whatever you want, Adora," Catra finally said. "I'm not your mom or your coach or anything."

Adora's face fell, hurt rolling over it quickly. She couldn't even stand to maintain eye contact anymore as she suddenly became very interested in examining the cheap linoleum.

"She needs you here, Mara," Razz called over to them, being the absolute worst. "Lookee and I have been trying to look after Cyra but we need your help. So difficult, this one."

"That's true," Adora muttered. She sounded far away. "Sorry. I have to go."

"Go after her," Razz ordered, when Adora bailed so quickly she nearly left a croc behind. "You're letting her slip away again."

"You barged into my room to steal groceries and now you're telling me what to do? Did you have too much hooch at bingo?"

Razz only laughed in response. "Bingo!"

"Are you gonna go drunk bake?"

"Of course not! You ate all the raspberries I asked for." Razz now somehow had a bowl of mac and cheese in her free hand. "Did she like them?"

"They're her favorite," Catra said, fully lying down now. "I'll come help you tomorrow. It's late."

Catra felt exhausted. There was a time when being with Adora made the days easier and Catra thought they were going to live forever; now, she was just drained and miserable and something under her fur felt all wrong.

For once, Razz left without a word. She quietly shut the door behind herself and her footsteps shuffled away until Catra couldn't pick them up anymore.

A part of Catra just wanted to pick up whatever she'd been doing before Adora blew into her life again and toppled everything without even trying. Catra looked at the epic text she'd been drafting for Scorpia, ranting that she needed to get out of this situation ASAP.

Scorpia
Wildcat, not that I'm complaining or anything
But you okay over there?
The bubbles are starting to give me an anxiety attack
Are you in trouble?
Are we in a fight?
Oh my gods, what did I do?
I didn't mean it, I swear

Catra
Cool your tits, Scorp
You're fine
I just accidentally left my phone unlocked in my pocket

Scorpia
Ah, okay!
Wanna chat?
Or watch some tv together?

Catra
Nah, thanks
Gotta get up early tomorrow

She shut off the light and closed her eyes, trying to will herself to sleep. Except all Catra could see in her mind was Adora.

For the next few days, Catra was a ghost. No matter where anyone looked, they couldn't seem to find her . She had an overwhelming

number of messages from Entrapta and Scorpia asking where she'd disappeared to. As long as she kept handing out papers and making some cash, she could keep this up until graduation probably. No one forcing her to talk about her feelings or that nagging voice in the back of her head that was suspiciously starting to feel a little like guilt. Guilt over ending things with Adora. Guilt over helping Huntara. But if Catra hustled enough, she could push all that down.

The only issue was Huntara herself. Not that Catra was expecting her to suddenly become a different person overnight but apparently the only phrase the big dope knew how to write was hey'. Which in turn received what Catra felt was Adora putting as much confusion and dubiousness as possible into her replied hey'. Several fucking *days* of hey' with just the occasional 'wut u up 2?' and some boring fucking accounts of school and sports sprinkled in.

Un-fucking-believable.

After that last text conversation with Adora, where Catra had basically set up so very many things for them to talk about, all Huntara had to do was keep this up and—well, whatever happened next. Ask Adora out? Honestly, Catra wasn't trying to consider what the next step was for this bizarre courting ritual. If she wasn't being paid for it, then it wasn't her business.

And Catra *really* needed to focus on business. Netossa was kind've a half-decent guidance counselor, Catra had to admit (when Netty wasn't trying to therapatize her) and she'd gotten fee waivers for all of Catra's college applications. Most everything would be ready to be turned in soon but now that this was becoming a real dream, Catra was even more concerned about paying for everything. It didn't feel right asking Razz to help out. Catra was pretty sure her grades and her life situation would get her plenty of scholarships but just in case, it would be nice to have a bit more money to fall back on.

Especially 'cause some of the cities she wanted to move to were pretty expensive. Eternia was one of the priciest places to live in the country. When she and Adora used to talk about it a couple years

ago – the things they'd see, the fun shit they'd do – they always imagined sharing a dorm and then an apartment. Now that Catra was potentially going alone, she'd need a bit more dough.

For the record, Catra was still *absolutely not* applying to Eternia University. It was bad enough that Adora wanted to go there, just cause it was a fancy place with a good hockey team. No, Catra was continuing her plan to apply to smaller liberal arts schools that felt more her vibe. One just *happened* to be in Eternia. And since technically *Catra* was the one to bring it up first all those years ago, Adora was not legally allowed to claim she had thought of moving to Eternia all on her own.

So it was only with self-preservation in mind that she finally gave up and hunted down Entrapta for some additional help.

"Texting's off the table," Catra announced as soon as she found her. She'd given it an honest try and all she'd ended up with was Adora Gray on her doorstep. Obviously, texting was too dangerous to risk ever attempting again; Catra had even gone so far as to see if she could get the messaging feature removed from her *own* phone, just in case.

Entrapta looked up from where she had sprawled books, assorted loose papers, and a couple different laptops across two long tables in the library, unconcerned if anyone else might want to use their study hall period to, you know, actually study.

"Yes, I thought you might say that," Entrapta replied. "The messages you exchanged with Adora were-"

Catra cut her off with, "Don't say fascinating."

Entrapta paused. "...insightful."

Catra didn't like that much more but it wasn't worth fighting about. She'd done enough fighting recently.

"Dont worry ," Entrapta assured her . "I have another idea."

But Catra *was* worried. Very very worried. Especially once Entrapta swiped her arm across the table, depositing everything into her bag, without seeming to care that her eqipment was fragile. And even more so when Entrapta managed to summon Kyle from thin air , shove something unseen into his hand, and dart away from him without enough instructions.

Never once had Catra even seen Kyle and Entrapta speak to each other. Now he was such an intricate part of her plan? It occurred to Catra then and there that she would never fully know everything about Entrapta. It's what Catra had always wanted for herself – to come off as an unknowable bitch who everyone was intimidated by – but Entrapta had actually mastered the art without even trying.

And she was close to learning every single damn thing about Catra. She could only imagine that Entrapta had added the messages she exchanged with Adora to a growing timeline of everything that had gone wrong in Catra's life, piecing it together like an ugly funky quilt.

"Keep up!" Entrapta yelled back at her .

Catra scrambled to catch up as Entrapta marched right out into the hall and then through a side door. Catra kept an ear out for any teachers or admins who might have caught them sneaking out the building, but of course, Entrapta had probably timed the whole thing like it was a movie heist and she was slipping through security during their shift changes.

It was impossible to anticipate where they were heading as they stepped out into the back courtyard. There wasnt much happening out there. The last lunch period was over so it was mostly empty. DT was probably in class, which meant the auditorium was an unlikely destination. That just left the parking lot and the rear entrance to the cafeteria. And Catra was *absolutely* not going into the cafeteria, since they'd only gotten about a million reminders that Glimmer was decorating the room for fall and looking for volunteers. Unfortunately

though, as far as Catra knew, Entrapta didnt have a car . She wouldnt put it past her friend to know how to hotwire one so maybe there was hope.

Catra dodged another brush with being an accomplice and/or state's witness when Entrapta turned and went right around the corner of the building. Not even trying to hide, Entrapta damn near skipped right up to the huge windows that looked into the lunchroom.

Contrary to what Adora used to tease her about, Catra was *not* short. She just wasnt an unnecessary couple of inches taller , like some idiots. Besides the two high-set ponytails on the top of her head, Entrapta was even shorter than Catra so the both of them had little chance of actually seeing into the cafeteria without a step stool or calves of steel. Entrapta wasnt about to let shit like that stop her . She stopped next to a tiny bush growing right up alongside the building and shoved her heavy boots onto a thin branch.

Catra opened her mouth to warn that this was a terrible idea, definitely doomed to fail, when Entrapta, face smushed up against the window already, loudly said, "Perfect. We're just in time."

"For-?" Catra started, but got cut of f again by Entrapta pulling a pair of black wireless headphones out of her bag without looking and shoving them towards Catra's hands.

"Put these on and get up here."

With a sigh, Catra gave in. They were fancy headphones, thankfully. The wide plushy kind that fit over her ears comfortably and actually managed to block out the cacophony of sounds that she was used to experiencing constantly, with her annoying strong hearing.

What she was completely opposed to doing, however, was adding any additional weight to this pathetic little shrub that Entrapta was soon gonna break. The last thing Catra needed was falling on her ass and then getting caught by someone. Insead, she stretched as far as she could, extending up on her tiptoes. She leaned onto the

brick window ledge just to get a final boost that let her peep into the lunchroom.

Catra's eyes scanned around quickly, still trying to figure out what the fuck they were up to. The decorating was in full swing. Glimmer was directing a set of goons as total chaos loomed around her. Bow teetered on a ladder, taping cardboard cut-outs of apples and pumpkins onto the top edges of the wall while Sea Hawk served as the least trustworthy spotter Catra had ever seen. Scorpia and a few other field hockey players rushed around delivering decorations from the huge explosion of junk at the center of the room to wherever Glimmer barked out at them. Mermista, on the other hand, sat at a table, the only one that hadn't been folded up and pushed out of the way into a far corner, with her feet resting on top as she occasionally mumbled directions to a couple underclassmen who were opening boxes of tacky orange and brown plastic garlands.

The target became a little clearer when someone suddenly rushed through the front doors. Catra tracked the movement and there was Kyle again, still carrying something in his hands. He'd covered it in his palms like Entrapta had told him to guard it with his life. His steps took him right up to Huntara, who Catra hadn't even noticed before. She must have just thought this volunteer gig was a good excuse to get out of class cause Huntara was in the only occupied corner, busy doing not a godsdamn thing. Her shoulder leaned against the wall, one hand shoved into her letterman pocket and the other quickly scrolling through her phone.

She didn't even look up when Kyle approached her. Though she did try to shoo him away after he tried pressing whatever he was holding into her purple paw.

With the headphones on, Catra couldn't make out a damn word they were saying but Huntara's annoyance was clear. Catra was curious to find out who Kyle was more terrified of disobeying, Entrapta or the big lug who was getting increasingly pissed off about being interrupted wasting time.

He said something that must have been very convincing cause Huntara didn't deck him when he shoved the tiny package into her other jacket pocket before running off quickly.

"Why do people always fight when you're trying to make their lives easier?" Entrapta wondered. Catra could just barely hear it, like she was underwater.

"Because you don't bother giving them a *choice,*" Catra told her. "Maybe if you tried *asking-*"

"Uh, hello?" Catra heard in the headphones suddenly. "What the hell is this?"

Her eyes shot back to the cafeteria, where Huntara was poking at an airpod in her left ear. She looked to Entrapta for help. "Adora" is all she mouthed back.

"Right." Catra drew out, still scrambling to figure out how they jumped from "no texting" to "phone call buds" in a blink. "What up?"

Entrapta poked her in the arm and started pointing into the window to a spot Catra had overlooked somehow. Adora was sitting on the floor, near the center of the room, concentrating too hard on sorting through a giant ball of decorations that had probably been lazily thrown into a janitor's closet for the past year. Catra was pretty sure the spider webs on it weren't just for show.

"You should go talk to Adora," she instructed, which was fucking silly cause Catra herself would rather hide in a well than say another word to Adora. Last week's disaster had just reiterated their need to stay away from each other.

Maybe if she'd been prepared for a showdown with Adora, it would have gone differently. Tragically still probably, but Catra would've… well, she wasn't really sure what the hell kind of outcome she would've even wanted.

It wasnt until she felt Entrapta poking at her arm more forcefully that Catra realized she'd just been staring at Adora, watching while the idiot furrowed her brow in a deep v, determined not to be outsmarted by a ball of twine or whatever.

"Yeah, yeah, I get it," Catra said to Entrapta, waving her off. She'd seen these movies before, Catra just needed to formulate a quick plan. She tried to sound more confident as she turned her attention back to Huntara. "I'm like the little angel on your shoulder or something. Go up to Adora and say hey. Ill take it from there but you have to repeat *exactly* what I say."

Huntara cussed a few times under her breath but Catra watched as she slowly stood up straight and crossed the room to where Adora had appointed herself queen of fixing the dumbest problem.

"Hey, Blondie."

Adora glanced up in surprise and Catra saw a whole nother look sprint across her face—worry or something—but she personally was a little busy not fucking believing Huntara's approach.

"Fucking hell!" Catra hissed. "Call her by her *name*, you condescending asshole!"

"What did you just call me?" Huntara asked in a way that probably could have taken a couple years off of Catra's life.

Adora's confusion only grew. Catra could just barely hear her reply, "What? I didnt say anything." Apparently thinking they were done talking, Adora went back to concentrating on her task.

That left Huntara dangling there awkwardly, unsure how to continue.

Catra was beyond exhausted by these two and this experiment had just barely started. "Stars, do you know how a conversation works?"

The headphones rumbled as Huntara growled at her.

"Fine," Catra sighed. Huntara had probably literally been raised by wolves so this wasn't totally her fault. "Say you're sorry and that you're just distracted."

Huntara wrenched her hands a bit before shoving them back into her pockets. "My bad, Blon-uh, *Adora.* Just a little distracted. Um"…

"How's it going?" Catra suggested. She listened as Huntara repeated that.

For just a second, a look of discomfort flashed on Adora's face. She recovered almost immediately and threw half a distracted smile Huntara's way. "Good. Gravy. Yep."

"Gravy? What a nerd. Thankfully Catra remembered not to say that out loud because she was pretty sure that Huntara would just repeat it word for word, forgetting to filter it through her brain first.

"I thought about you the other day," Catra said. "There's a new season of Etheria's Best Dance Crew. I, uh" she struggled for a lie. "Heard you liked that show."

Huntara recited that exactly, but Catra noticed she looked around self-consciously, like she was too cool to have anyone overhear her talking about dancing.

Adora unabashedly lit up though, finally giving Huntara her undivided attention. The dummy was so predictable.

"Oh! Do you watch it?" She seemed only a little disbelieving, which was fair. But Catra had to establish *some* godsdamn thing they had in common to make it feel like Huntara and Adora's chance of moving past distant acquaintances was real.

"I catch an episode from time to time," Catra replied, pretending like she still didn't keep up with it religiously. Er, uh, that *Huntara* didn't.

"The judges are so harsh this year ," Adora whined. "Like, it' s not even fair."

Catra nodded, forgetting Adora couldn't see her . "Y eah, Flutterina had *one* good dance song like 10 years ago and suddenly she thinks she fucking *invented* dancing?! She had the fucking nerve to call someone sloppy last week when she barely *moved* when she performed live."

Adora nodded vigorously, clearly on a roll now. "My Gods! Have you seen the Star Sisters? Don't you love them? They *have* to win this season – they're even more talented than Peekablue from a couple years ago," she blurted out in one long breath.

Her eyes were absolutely wild with glee and passion and Huntara took a step back in concern.

"Bullshit!" Catra yelled. "Peekablue was amazing! He was like 6-feet tall and he backflipped in *heels!*" It was basically homophobic for anyone to not think that was the most majestic and athletic thing they'd ever seen.

"Uh, I don't watch every episode," she heard Huntara say instead.

Catra grumbled back, suddenly remembering that Huntara was even there, "Hey , that's not-"

"Y ou're kinda obsessed with it, huh?" Huntara asked. "This show and dancing and stuff?" She sounded grossed out, which was fucking absurd. Catra had only talked about Adora's interests for the past few weeks and- *oh.* Huntara had literally not listened to a fucking word Catra said, had she? Really, Adora just appreciated hard work more than anything, especially if it was related to something she had no hope of mastering, like following choreography without looking like a baby deer. Catra was sure that she had explained that to Huntara more than once.

Catra watched as Adora deflated slightly, returning to the decorations.

"Not *obsessed,"* Adora replied, sounding embarrassed and a little defensive.

Catra frowned. She didn't know if she was just out of the loop or if Adora was lying. Something about the last option made her angry. It pissed her off that Adora would try pretending just to impress *Huntara.* They'd watched that show together for years – Adora claiming that she was just into the athleticism and Catra claiming that she was just humoring Adora. They'd even followed all the awful spinoffs and now Adora was acting like she was too cool for it to show off for some idiot?

"I mean, the shows are silly ," Adora said. With a more confident voice, she added, "But I like them. They're really cool. What' s your favorite show?"

Huntara almost coughed, before grunting. She spent a few too many seconds thinking before she came up with, "Football. Oh! And that show where they make knives."

Catra did not appreciate getting derailed like this. She listened in tense silence, only sorta thinking she'd probably actually look that up later. She could get into knives.

Adora sounded much less interested than Catra when she responded, "That' s cool. What, hm, what do you like about knives?" Her words tilted up at the end, like Adora was really grasping awkwardly for some way to keep this conversation alive.

There was another thick-ass pause where all Catra could hear was Huntara breathing.

"People making shit with their hands," Catra suggested. "Uh. The history? Shit, you can even say the metal is beautiful. Anything!"

"They're cool," Huntara finally said and Catra decided that she hated that word. It revealed a total of *absolutely nothing* about Huntara. Catra wasn't expecting her to bare her soul but she had to give *something*.

"Oh, for fuck's sa-" Catra was cut off by the line suddenly going dead.

"She's gone rogue," Entrapta said. Catra glanced over at her for the first time, having honestly forgotten that she wasn't alone with Huntara and Adora. Entrapta was wearing a pair of headphones identical to the ones Catra had on and, no doubt, somehow connected so that she could hear every word of that conversation. She had her iPad out again, furiously pushing buttons, probably in an attempt to reconnect to Huntara.

They both lifted themselves impossibly further up onto their tiptoes to peer more closely through the window. Adora was still half-untangling ugly strings of fake falling leaves while Huntara leant down towards her. She didn't even bother to sit so she was closer or, gods forbid, offer to help. Adora had returned to committing about a quarter of her attention to this conversation.

Entrapta pushed with all of her weight and managed to move the giant, heavy glass windows about one inch. That small crack was all Catra needed though. She tossed the headphones off and pressed herself closer so she could pick up as much as possible.

"So there's, like, a bowie a dagger uh, a tanto," Huntara listed off, pausing repeatedly to stare at the ceiling and think.

"Is she just naming *knives?*"

"I believe being nervous and rambling in the presence of an attractive person is normal," Entrapta pointed out. "This feels like… *not* that," she finished, sounding like the confusion had made her just up and forget all of the technical words she usually used to describe things.

"Anyway." Huntara trailed of f awkwardly.

"I should probably finish." Adora stopped to wave in the general direction of all the crap in front of her.

Huntara nodded unsurely. She looked like she didn't quite know where to go next but she ended up being saved by the first bell going off.

"What the hell are we supposed to do with this?" Catra asked as she led Entrapta back into the building, towards their next class, dodging people streaming out into the hall. What Huntara obviously needed was to be carried through this whole thing like a little puppet but she was infuriatingly stubborn. If she didnt listen, couldnt take direction, and wouldnt memorize a damn thing, how was Catra supposed to succeed in helping her?

Adora wasn't much better. Besides the brief enthusiasm she'd shown in sharing about her school panic, she seemed to find Huntara about as interesting as a trip to the dentist. Catra had been wracking her brain and she couldnt figure out what had changed to make Adora so engaged that day but completely unattached to Huntara in person.

"It' s almost as if no one wants this relationship to come to fruition," Entrapta said, slightly distracted. Her eyes looked far away in thought.

"Are you saying it's a conspiracy? Cause I'm definitely starting to think it's a conspiracy."

"I don't think two emotionally-immature teenagers with communication issues counts as a conspiracy," Entrapta argued.

Up ahead, Catra could see the purple half of the doofus duo hovering in front of the cafeteria doors as if she was actually lost after that conversation petered into a total fail.

"Speak of the devil," Catra said. "Let's go debrief."

"Oh. You were thinking of Huntara?" Entrapta asked. "Right. Yes, let's do that."

Catra narrowed her eyes, wondering what secret meaning Entrapta was trying to imply now. Since Huntara towered at least a head over most of the student body, she spotted Catra and Entrapta coming towards her and began a quick pace to meet them halfway.

"What the fuck was that?" Catra hissed. Huntara only responded by chucking an airpod case at her head.

"Perhaps you could try positive reinforcement," Entrapta suggested, as she caught the headphones. "That was only sorta bad," she told Huntara.

The big dope bared her teeth. "Fuck of f."

"Agreed!" Entrapta sang back. She bounced away before Catra could stop her.

It would have been nice to have a witness maybe cause everyone else in the hall ran by, unconcerned as Huntara leaned close into Catra's space.

"What was all that bullshit you tried to feed me?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "Oh, excuse the fuck out of me for trying to find something you two have in common."

"*You* have it in common!" Huntara shot back. While it was possibly true, Catra was offended at the idea of sharing anything with Adora nonetheless.

"Adora's a normal, happy dumb teenager. She likes awful tv shows and worse music. It won't kill you to fake being into the same things."

"You did all this research on her. Why don't you do some on me? Find something I can actually talk to her about?"

"Ew, gross." Catra gagged dramatically. "Can I just quit instead?"

Huntara's right hand balled into a fist, confirming for Catra that it was more likely that she'd be taking a punch than it was that Huntara would be taking Adora out.

Just when Catra was sure Huntara would give in to what she's wanted all along and finally clock her, a kind (and only sorta stressed) voice interrupted with, "Everything okay here?"

Since Catra definitely didn't need saving, she and Huntara both turned to this good samaritan with deadly glares.

And there was Bow, his bright smile tightening as he tried to pretend that he hadn't walked into something way out of his depth.

"We're good, Arrow," Catra said.

His eyes floated back towards Huntara, all but signaling that Catra should probably use the distraction to run off and save herself. She stood her ground so Bow took a step closer, about to disagree.

Someone else beat him to it. "The bell's gonna ring soon. We should all go so we won't be late."

Catra peeked just over his shoulder to find Adora hovering behind him, Glimmer at her side. While Glimmer was practically frothing at the mouth for a fight, Adora's face had a faint look of smugness. Catra couldn't imagine what she had to be proud of after that embarassing knife convo.

Under Adora's curious eyes, Huntara backed off immediately.

"No problems here. Just giving the kitten some advice for her health," Huntara said smoothly, before strutting away like she didn't have a care in the world. Her voice was all deep and throaty and she

moved like she owned the whole hallway;for a second, Catra hated to admit, she kinda got why people found Huntara hot.

And then Catra was overcome with rage –where was this confident swagger 5 minutes ago when Huntara was crashing and eating shit?

She started to turn back to chase after Huntara, belly full of indignant fire, when a soft voice called out to her.

"Hey , Catra," Adora said.

Catra froze. She wasn't sure if the other night was a fluke. They'd gone back to complete radio silence since then. There was no reason to expect that suddenly Adora would just jump back into her life as if nothing had changed.

But Adora wore that same nervous look she always had when she was anxious about how Catra would react to something. It was hopeful and familiar and Catra was so struck by all the memories it drug up –childish schemes and hockey tricks and just one more episode pleeeeaaasse' –that she was worried her voice might shake when she opened her mouth.

"Hey , Adora," she replied, just as softly .

The smile Adora threw her way was so gentle it almost hurt. It reached all the way up to her eyes, her baby blues going all doe-like. She held on way too long, staring at Catra well beyond a normal amount of time.

And Catra just stood there, like a total dummy , vaguely aware that her tail was practically vibrating up in the air, where literally anyone could see it. Ugh. After their last talk, Adora had weaseled her way back into Catra's brain. It started as a small leak, just a little dribble bugging her with its continuous noise, and now it was opening some kind of flood gate. Catra was sure she didn't know a fucking thing about how dams worked or whatever but the rush of weird emotions she was experiencing felt like entirely too much. She needed a quick

distraction before she embarrassed herself in front of half of the school.

Unfortunately, Glimmer was quiet for once (though her *face* was loud as fuck - smiling like she knew something no one else did.) Bow was still hovering like he wasn't sure if he was even supposed to be watching this right now.

"Uhhhh, okay , bye!" Catra shouted way louder than necessary and turned and bolted towards her next class. Maybe she'd just hide under a desk or toss herself in a locker, somewhere safe where she could get the hell away from any and all thoughts of Adora Gray.

Chapter End Notes

italicized adora count in this chapter: 2, i think

next week? bad art and an awkward lunch

But I'm in So Deep

Chapter Notes

goddess bless the person who is 10 minutes late to meeting with me, allowing me to post this now.

hi hello what up. today's chapter gets kinda...soft. we were due for some softness, no? hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

At this point, Catra was sure that they'd tried just about everything to spark some kind of connection between Huntara and Adora. Short of putting peanut butter in Huntara's mouth while Catra stood behind her and faked her voice, there weren't many options left.

(Catra had, in fact, tossed this idea out there just to see what Scorpia and Entrapta thought. Scorpia spent maybe 30 minutes on the phone explaining why this was 'offensive' or whatever.)

Though Scorpia *had* given them another idea by hitting Catra up and holding her emotionally hostage on that phone call. It took some convincing, since Huntara was apparently morally opposed to phone calls, but she'd rang Adora up one night. Catra had tried to text Huntara conversation starters, just a few occasional prompts to keep things flowing along.

It seemed polite to put some distance between herself and Adora, so Catra refused to actually listen in. And that part – the distance, the *making a good fucking decision* part – had absolutely nothing to do with the fact that Adora had suddenly taken to casually nodding or smiling at Catra whenever she saw her in the halls or in class.

Without the audio though, Huntara – and this was *self-reported,* which showed a concerning lack of shame – just kept blurting shit out in the middle of Adora's sentences. (Catra had the sneaking

feeling that while she had abstained, Entrapta had definitely listened in, based on the stank look she had on her face when Catra FaceTimed her afterward. A look that really said she'd seen some *shit.)*

Yeah, that went about as well as two idiots trying to light a match in a windstorm. According to Huntara, the conversation with Adora was another strikeout. Yet one more stilted as all hell, awkward mess.

There was something missing, Catra was sure of it. A whole lifetime spent with Adora and she still couldn't figure out what was lacking. What was that special something that would get Adora to realize she was crushing hard on Huntara and vice versa.

She was once again drifting off in class, trying to reexamine a decade's worth of memories to find some clue on what Adora even liked about girls. One main issue – Adora had never really shown much of an interest in dating or crushes. She was always too busy with hockey and school and her family and spending time with Catra. So this detailed investigation into Catra's mind palace soon just devolved into random thoughts of spending time with Adora, interspersed with moments of panicked realization of how badly she was gonna fail this challenge.

Whatever, it was Art. All Catra had to do was show up and coast her way to an A so it didn't matter if she was circling and circling the same stupid questions: What did she have to make Huntara into to get Adora's attention? How to help Adora with all of her anxieties without actually doing anything and especially without *anyone knowing* if Catra chose to go ahead, ignore all of her self-preservation skills, and fucking do something? How she was gonna handle possibly running into Adora out in a big unknown city out in Eternia when Catra could barely handle her here in her own turf? Why was Adora suddenly deciding to be all friendly to Catra when she should be throwing that energy Huntara's way? *What the hell was wrong with Catra that she was still thinking about Adora this much?*

Catra would have been perfectly fine to whittle away the period spiraling wildly and maybe painting another still life of a fruit bowl had Spinnerella not cruelly decided to announce, "Okay , today we're sketching portraits. Everyone pair up."

A combination of ice water and the ghost pepper hot sauce felt like it roiled in Catra's stomach. She didn't do pair work. It was never for her. Kids usually didn't want to even try to bother with her since she'd rightfully earned a reputation as being impossible. Everyone moved too slow or didn't take their part seriously or wanted to try to get gossip out of her. The best case scenario was that the room had an odd number and Catra could just be left alone.

Unfortunately, that was quickly proven to not be true. Literally every other group in the class just turned to the idiot sitting next to them at their shared desks. And only two people were so selfish as to cordon off a whole table for themselves: Catra. And Adora.

Glimmer was the first to make a move. It was not subtle, which for a person dressed in some sort of floofy bright purple ruffle nightmare, that was pretty on-brand. While Adora froze, the notes she was writing in her daily planner coming to a complete halt, Glimmer jumped out of her seat. In two long steps, the candy-colored menace had crossed over to fling both Adora's extra chair and her belongings inside into a random corner.

"Glimmer!" Spinnerella yelled, while everyone else watched in confusion. "Do you want to have another conversation with Principal Moon about respecting school property?"

Threatening to make Glimmer go talk to her own father about her behavior was either very effective or completely useless cause she barely shrugged at their teacher. She turned to glare at everyone in the room, all but smashing a bottle against a table and daring someone to approach Adora. On her way back to her own seat, Glimmer made some very exaggerated wide-eyed look towards Bow, who took that as his cue to pull a still-frozen Adora from her chair and push her towards the back of the room.

Fucking stars, it was awkward. Bow and Glimmer rushed to sit down and now the whole class was watching Adora stand in the middle of the room like she'd been dropped on an alien planet and had no clue what to do next. Her eyes quickly scanned each desk, looking helplessly for somewhere to park herself.

Catra was pretty sure that behind Adora, Glimmer was pushing the blonde's chair away so returning wasn't an option anymore.

Thankfully, Spinnerella had some decency. "Adora, perfect. Looks like you're with Catra."

Their eyes met. Catra quickly raised her hand.

"No," Spinnerella answered automatically. She didn't know what Catra was going to ask for – *Catra* didn't know what the hell she was gonna say next anyway – but Spinnerella was resolute in her decision. "Now, Adora, please take your seat so we can begin."

Catra reluctantly cleaned the space off as Adora walked over slowly, almost as if she was approaching someone in the throes of a panic attack who was likely to lash out at her at any moment. She ignored how accurate that felt to instead focus on scooping all of her pens and random crap that had fallen out of her backpack back into place. Adora was tidyish. Catra wasn't a jerk; she could be accommodating.

Adora sat down gently, clearly trying to ignore that everyone was still watching them both. As far as anyone knew, the last words they'd really spoken to each other had been awful shit. *Life-end friendship ending* shit.

"Sup," Catra offered quietly, attempting to keep her voice calm.

Adora waved in response and tried to smile. It was hollow, didn't quite reach the rest of her face. She was anxious, just like that night in Catra's house.

Spinnerella watched them for a second longer until she seemed to be happy that everyone was settled. Clearing her throat to get attention back on her, their teacher began explaining the assignment for the day. She went around the room, passing out thick high-quality paper and some nice mechanical pencils, while instructing them on shadows and shading and other shit Catra couldn't listen to.

All she could hear was Adora's shallow, nervous breathing next to her.

"So," Adora started, sounding unsure. "You want me to sketch you first?"

"Ew, you want a creepy drawing of my face?" Catra made sure to try to keep her voice light. She felt a little bad about how their last convo had gone. No need to pour salt on it.

Adora scoffed softly. "Fine! You can have a creepy picture of me then. Something to take with you when you move."

Catra turned and fully faced her finally. There was nothing rude or angry in Adora's demeanor, maybe just a little sadness.

"Smart. That'll make it easy to put a hex on you," Catra joked.

Adora gave a gentle chuckle that felt genuine. She shook her head a little, the way she used to when Catra was coming up with some sneakily brilliant plan that Adora would eventually reluctantly submit to and then be fully on board with. Like when they were 9 and Catra decided they should steal a shopping cart from the grocery store and ride it down that hill in the park near their houses. They didn't make it out of the parking lot before being caught but Adora put up a valiant effort at trying to talk the greasy teen bagger into why they really needed this cart to help their sick grandmother.

The dummy's eyes shined mischievously. That used to be one of Catra's favorite moments, waiting with baited breath for whatever shit they were about to get into.

"Maybe we should each do one at the same time," Adora suggested. She was already bouncing a little in her seat in excitement.

"That's a terrible idea." It was. How the hell were you supposed to be paying attention to what you were drawing if you were trying to sit still enough for the other person to draw? How were you supposed to get a clear image if the other idiot kept moving? This was doomed to fail.

Catra opened her mouth to say that but Adora was already turning her chair so they were fully face-to-face. They were too close. Like, *way* too close, just a few inches apart so that when Catra moved, their knees were practically touching.

"1, 2, 3, go!" Adora yelled.

Overthinking the bizarreness of them having to share the same airspace would have to wait because Catra wasn't about to be beaten. Now, she wasn't *totally* sure how this was a competition but it obviously was. And Catra wasn't about to fucking lose anything to Adora Gray.

They both started furiously sketching, which Catra was right about – it was horrible. Absolutely terrible. Her eyes kept jumping back and forth between the paper and Adora's face, even though it was consistently turned towards her own work. Pretty early on, Catra decided it would probably be easiest just to draw Adora like that – head tilted down, face screwed up in concentration, tongue peeking out of the side of her mouth as she tried to focus.

Early in this semester, Spinnerella had taught them the basics of drawing faces. Catra vaguely remembered something about circles and proportions. Taking a quick look at Adora's paper, it was clear that only one of them had paid attention. This picture of Catra was quickly heading somewhere between the world's worst stick figure and one of those awful caricatures from the county fair.

"That's offensive!" she yelled at Adora.

"Quiet, Im concentrating."

Catra made sure to capture Adora's dumb tongue thing and really exaggerate it in revenge.

"You're making me look like a dog!" Adora complained.

"It's an improvement, trust me."

"I think the paint fumes in here damaged the one brain cell they have between them," Catra heard Glimmer say .

"At least they're talking," Bow whispered. "Kinda. After Adora ignored us and rushed over to see her the other night, I thought they'd *definitely* never speak ever again."

Catra's hand almost slipped. She hadnt expected Adora to tell anyone about her strange late-night visit. But of course, her little entourage knew about it and were trying to intervene? Catra wasnt totally sure what they were up to. Maybe for three people who were so used to everyone liking them, they felt compelled to make sure Catra didnt hate them all forever .

Bow shifted around and, in her periphery, Catra saw him straining to look over at their table. "Oh, that's not looking good."

Catra practically slapped her forehead. What was the point of having such a wide range of vision if she couldnt use it to cheat? She angled her head a bit more to the side so it was easier to keep watch on Adora and her work simultaneously.

"Hey , you moved! You're messing up my perfect portrait," Adora whined.

"It's not a race, Princess," Catra told her , trying to sound as condescending as possible. "Maybe try putting a little skill and finesse into it."

For a moment, Adora's hand paused. Catra didn't think much of it until she realized her slip.

Ugh. She shouldn't be joking around like they were friends. This was bound to happen—some dumb detail of the past sneaking in and making Adora think Catra actually still cared or something.

For Adora's 11th birthday, she'd spent weeks trying to convince her parents that she should have a ninja-themed birthday, complete with throwing stars and katanas and a million other ways for a bunch of kids to lose an eye. She couldn't have possibly been more clear that this was the only option she was interested in. Marlena, horrified and concerned, had instead asked Catra for her thoughts on a backup plan.

Princess theme,' Catra had joked when Adora was washing up for dinner and she was alone with the Grays, helping to set the table. She didn't think about it again until two weeks later when they walked into the Grays' den to find a bubblegum pink explosion. By that point, they were way too old for fairytales and most of the other kids there were even embarrassed for Adora. Instead of getting pissed, Adora had terrorized Catra all day, trying to get her to wear every ugly piece of princess paraphenalia that Marlena bought, because of course she got two of everything to make sure Catra didn't feel left out. Princess Adora and her bestest friend, Princess Catra. Thankfully, the nickname only stuck for *one* of them.

Finally, Adora laughed quietly to herself. "You little brat. Just for that, I'm drawing a little crown for you." She kept scribbling away. "I bet Glim's got some glitter over there on her station to decorate this."

"Hope you enjoy your F," Catra sang.

Five minutes before the bell, Spinnerella asked everyone to start winding down and cleaning up after themselves. Adora didn't stop so neither did Catra. They just kept on, drawing as if they were locked in Etheria's pettiest game of Pictionary. Catra had to admit that her piece was coming out pretty okay. She sure as shit didn't know how

to draw hair but she'd done an excellent job of capturing Adora's face – those big oval eyes, her thick brows, her stupid strong jaw and pointy chin. Most importantly, her completely idiotic *essence*.

The bell rang just as Catra was beginning to think that maybe she'd done *too* good of a job and anyone taking even a passing glance at this could tell that she'd spent a considerable amount of her life just *staring* at Adora.

Thankfully, Glimmer was an inconsiderate hellraiser. She popped over suddenly, throwing Adora's discarded backpack on the table with a thud loud enough to break whatever alternate universe they'd fallen into over the past hour.

"Move your butts, losers," she said. "I can't be late to Chem. All my teachers have been conspiring against me lately."

"Is calling out how someone's an entitled asshole a conspiracy?" Catra wondered aloud as she continued to put the finishing touches on her piece. "Or just accountability?"

Glimmer leaned down closer to Catra, trying (and failing) to intimidate her probably. "You really want to open the door to talking about accountability? You? Really?"

"Okay, all done!" Adora announced nervously, interrupting them. On the table, she swung the piece around so that Catra could see it fully.

"I was wrong," Catra admitted. "It's actually an F-."

"What?!" Adora shrieked as Glimmer made a loud *oof!*

Adora's rendering of Catra was a blob. Just a… *pol* almost, of cat, all mane and fangs and huge saucers where her eyes should be. She had no forehead because the "crown" ended up looking like an off-center Halloween mask shoved on her face. Her giant mouth eclipsed her chin. The only thing that was remotely accurate was the detail that Adora had put into the placement of Catra's freckles.

At this point, Catra wasnt sure if she should actually be of fended. But hidden behind Adora’s triumphant smirk was jst a hint of fear in her eyes. Hesitation.

“I’m keeping it,” Catra rushed to say .

Adora’s face lit up immediately, before Catra could regret putting herself out there like that.

“Really?” Adora bit her lip in an attempt to hide how pleased she was. “Y ou dont have to jst say that.”

Deeply aware of Glimmer’s presence nearby, Catra wasnt about to share how serious she was about this. Instead, she slid the paper closer to herself.

“Get out of my classroom please,” Spinnerella sang sweetly , a reminder that Catra should probably check to see if they were expected to turn these in or something before she robbed Adora of her grade for the day.

Adora was already rushing to stand and toss her backpack on. Her eyes kept glancing over at Catra's portrait, as if she was waiting for a reveal even though the damn thing was sitting right out in the open for everyone to see. Clearly Adora wanted to have it *presented* to her.

“Uh, can I see yours?” Adora asked.

Catra wasn't usually showy. Adora had often been the only person who could bring that out of her. Was the only person who could make it feel safe enough for that to happen. Adora didn't jdge. It had been so long since she'd had Adora's always-affirming positivity around and some part of Catra wanted to experience it for jst a brief moment.

Also, real talk, Catra's drawing jst looked so much better in comparison. She had no artistic talent but Adora's really was jst

hilariously ridiculous.

"Sure," Catra replied. Her voice did an excellent job remaining very neutral about this.

Feeling like she was ready to have her masterpiece hung in a gallery now, Catra twirled her drawing towards Adora. It wasn't perfect obviously. They'd had a very short amount of time to work on this. This was not within her skillset. Her subject wouldn't stop fidgeting like a toddler drunk on energy drinks.

Yet, Catra felt like maybe she'd captured Adora's image well. (And yes, she was still worried about *too well'* cause it looked more like a vomit of too many feelings than a supposedly simple class assignment.)

Adora and Glimmer both leaned over from opposite sides of the table. Bow even popped up next to Glimmer and Catra could have sworn that he was halfway out the door until she'd agreed to share her work.

Their faces were unreadable for a very agonizing couple of seconds. Glimmer, who'd never hidden an emotion ever, was particularly blank. Catra didn't know what to make of that at all. She got even more worried when Glimmer slid the two drawings together so that they were basically facing each other.

The idea of these two in a room together having a faceoff – this angelic idiot and this crowned princess pillow-shaped cat made Catra laugh out loud.

"It looks like a really badly stitched together meme!" She couldn't stop giggling. These images were cursed and absolutely had to be destroyed.

Ugh, Scorpia would think it was so precious.

"This is actually disgustingly cute," Glimmer said. She was still keeping up a whole mysterious vibe and Catra couldn't get a feel for how she even meant that sentence. "You should frame them."

Bow was much less closed off when he repeated, "Disgustingly cute." He was making big wet doe eyes at them. Both sets of them. Real-life Adora and Catra *and* their drawn figures.

Catra looked at the two pictures. They were objectively terrible – frantic shaky messes. On Adora's, you could barely even tell that someone attempted to draw a person. Her own was just an amateur-level face and ponytail floating in space.

She forced herself to look at Adora for her reaction. To her surprise, the dummy was staring back at her already. Her cheeks were bright red and Catra bet that if someone offered to pay Adora $1,000 right now to wipe the deeply pleased grin off her face, she still wouldn't be able to.

Adora was looking at Catra like she hadn't seen her in decades. It made something wild and silly bubble up in her own throat. Catra moved quickly to begin gathering her stuff up just to have something else to distract her from that feeling.

"I love it," Adora whispered. "Can I take a picture?"

Catra dipped her head as she put maybe too much attention into making sure she hadn't dropped a pen or anything on the floor. "It's yours, dummy."

She couldn't see Bow's face but the quiet "eep!" he made was enough to imagine his saccharine grin. Catra was reminded of the way he squealed with glee when their 5th grade class visited the zoo and he saw a baby panda.

Adora's hands reached quickly for the drawing before she pulled back. "Spinnerella, are we allowed to keep these?"

I cant start my free period until you all leave and I can lock the door," was the only answer they got back, as their teacher had turned her back and begun to clean up around the room.

Catra took that as a yes, safely placing the portrait Adora had done into the back of her history textbook. Adora watched her and then did the same.

"Okay , Catra and Bow have Calc next," Glimmer announced. "Let' s go."

She wanted to ask why Glimmer knew her class schedule – especially since she and Bow sat on opposite ends of the room and never interacted – but there was a strong grip on her right arm and Catra was being dragged out of the room immediately before she could say anything.

It was a bit too much to take in. The whole walk, Glimmer talked about random happenings around school, like she and Catra were friends and this was something they did everyday. Bow and Adora trailed behind, joining in on the conversation. Adora' s eyes kept getting glued to Glimmer's sweaty palm on Catra's arm and that was fucking weird. For her part, Catra could barely keep up with what was going on. She didnt socialize with any of the people they were talking about. She didnt know what had gone down at the latest party. She had nothing to contribute.

Glimmer didnt care as she chatted on and on nonstop. They arrived at class right as the last bell rang.

Glimmer used her grip to push Catra inside and shouted, "See you later," before she grabbed Adora next and they booked it down the hall.

The next day, Glimmer appeared out of thin air as Catra was leaving Lit. She hadn't seen Scorpia or Entrapta for a while so the plan was to head towards the lab and hope at least one of them was there.

Glimmer nixxed that as she popped up in the hall and, once again, grabbed Catra by the arm.

"Finally!" Even though they were attached, Glimmer was a blur of fuschia as she charged down the corridor. The crowd parted to duck out of her way.

"Finally? The bell rung literally 2 seconds ago. W ait! Where are we going?" Catra tried to pull back but Glimmer had some kind of inhuman strength.

"Y ou have lunch now," Glimmer said.

"Y eah, *I* have lunch, which *I* was going to spend studying quietly ."

"Liar ."

Glimmer said nothing else as she led Catra out the back doors and towards the picnic tables on the rear lawn. It was empty, already abandoned by the kids from the earlier lunch hour. Since Catra was not part of the Best Friends Squad', the dumb name she'd heard Bow give the three-person crew, she'd never eaten here. They seemed to have called dibs on this spot and, strangely, everyone silently agreed to go along with that.

It was a clear autumn day. The temperature was fine. Reasonable enough that Catra wouldn't be cold in just her black tights and this 90s tshirt she'd found in the thrift store with with a screen printing of Aaliyah on it. So she couldn't use that as an excuse. There were no signs of rain in the light clouds above. It wasn't even that sunny .

"I haven't done my Calc homework yet," Catra lied.

"Then bust it out," Glimmer dared her .

Catra tried to think of another tactic. "Scorpia-"

"Look who decided to join us today!" Glimmer suddenly yelled across the courtyard.

Catra turned to see Scorpia and Perfuma walking together in their direction. Perfuma was an oddball. Some kind of woo woo feelings-obsessed blonde witch who Catra always tried to steer clear of. They'd been in the same 8th grade class but had only briefly crossed paths since high school started. Her questions were always a little *too* leading, while she kept that fake easy-going smile plastered to her face. Catra didn't know what drugs Perfuma was on to always maintain her weird calm, but they seemed like something she didn't want to mess around with.

Scorpia hadn't once mentioned being friends with Perfuma. So it was strange to see them hanging out together.

An embarrassed, caught stealing sort of look overtook Scorpia's face. "Wildcat?!" she blurted out, sounding all flustered.

Catra wasn't about to do anything to bring more attention to herself so she just waved with very little enthusiasm.

From somewhere behind Scorpia, she heard, "Wildcat?" mumbled quietly .

A blonde head jumped up, Adora's dumb face leaping up over Scorpia's huge shoulder.

"Catra?!" Adora practically pushed Scorpia and Perfuma out of the way as she ran over. She paused as she got close and frowned. "You don't have food." More frantically , she suggested, "I'll go get you food!"

"I'm fi-," Catra started but Adora was already gone, broken out into a full jog. She turned to Glimmer with a sneer . "Why did you do that?"

Glimmer shrugged like she didn't know what Catra was talking about, but her eyes were too mischievous to be convincing. "Do what? You're the one who didn't grab lunch before sitting down."

As if Catra had any say in that.

Scorpia and Perfuma took the seat across from them.

"Wildcat, Im so happy you decided to join us today!" Scorpia basically shouted.

Catra was sure that everyone nearby turned to gawk at the unbelievable idea of her trying to make friends or hang out with people. She crouched down slightly in an attempt to hide from prying eyes.

"Glimmer made me," Catra spat.

"Oh, fun!" Scorpia cheered, not realizing that actually Glimmer 's power was completely unchecked and this was a threat to everyone.

Scorpia reached into her backpack and pulled out a brown bag lunch, while Perfuma quietly plucked what looked like a bamboo box out of that giant multi-colored crocheted knapsack thing that she always had over her shoulder. Even Glimmer was opening up a tupperware container of some homecooked noodles that smelled delicious, like those cold sesame ones that Razz liked to have.

Adora hadnt even waited to confirm that Catra didnt bring her lunch from home. Maybe it was just a good guess. Catra wasnt exactly a great chef and Razz probably didnt seem like someone who would remember to make Catra a brown bag everyday. Or, she thought, maybe Adora had been paying a lot more attention to her than shed ever really thought.

Bow and Adora approached the table, both carrying trays from the cafeteria. Catra watched the boy's eyes widen in surprise when he saw her but he quickly put on an easy smile.

"This is great," he whispered, trying to maintain his grin.

Catra thought Adora hadnt even heard him until she hissed, "Shhhh."

Adora was struggling to balance the two trays she'd grabbed and Bow wasn't bothering to help at all. He gave Glimmer a quick kiss on the cheek before sitting down across from her, on Scorpia's left.

That meant only one space remained at the table. Adora didn't even hesitate as she stepped over the bench on Catra's unoccupied side and gently dropped the two trays, a burger, fries, water bottle, and apple slices on each. Catra didn't quite understand why the school district tried to convince itself that the addition of this pathetic apple rounded out a meal but she'd just let Adora eat hers.

She looked at the food and then up at Adora. "You only brought enough for yourself?" Catra asked.

Adora opened her mouth, clearly ready to fight. Then her brain seemed to catch up to the sly smirk on Catra's face and she stopped.

"Ha ha," Adora sarcastically laughed. She emptied her pockets onto the table, putting three cartons of milk, two bags of chips, and a small bag of cafetoria sugar cookies down. She pointed lazily at the bounty as she took her seat. "I'll just have whatever you don't finish."

"Thanks," Catra mumbled quietly , before digging in. Cafeteria food was trash but it was a nice gesture. Plus, she'd maybe accidentally forgotten to have breakfast again that morning.

Lunch was shockingly wholesome. Everyone easily joked around with each other about nothing and everything. Scorpia even joined in, which Catra figured made sense. Scorpia was actually friends with just about anyone. She could carry on a conversation with a tree so it wasn't as strange that she remembered all sorts of personal details about everyone at the table and asked thoughtful questions about all of them.

Unsurprisingly, Catra felt like the odd person out. She wasn't used to this much socializing anymore. She chose to spend much of the period in silence, just observing the others but pretending not to.

Glimmer must've chilled out a lot in the last few years – little digs that would have set her off before just made her *slightly* annoyed. Bow played peacekeeper, even when it didn't seem really necessary. As Catra expected, Perfuma seemed to always know more than she was giving away. She kept staring at Scorpia like she was waiting for something to happen. Scorpia was nervous and slightly tense in a way that Catra had never noticed before. Her shoulders were up high and she talked too much, not just chatty like usual, but almost like she was trying to anxiously fill space.

Catra couldn't pay much attention to Adora. She was too aware of how close they were sitting and how much Adora was watching her out of the corner of her eye to actually notice anything Adora was saying to her friends.

When the bell rang, it was both too soon and not really quick enough. Catra wanted to fade into the background somewhere for a good long while. But a big part of her felt reluctant to do that. Sitting at this table surrounded by what was definitely too many people was tiring and made Catra feel exposed. Adora was there, though. And so it was safe and scary and kinda fun and kinda terrible.

Honestly, Catra didn't really know what the fuck she was feeling.

Glimmer and Adora must have sensed that because they took it upon themselves to take care of everything. Adora grabbed Catra's empty tray and all of her trash and dashed off to dispose of it. Once again overstepping, Glimmer linked her arm through Catra's as everyone said goodbye and parted ways. At least she wasn't getting dragged around anymore, but following Glimmer's quick pace didn't seem very *optional.*

Bow and Adora fell into step behind them again. Catra didn't ask where they were going. She honestly trusted that Glimmer would just deposit her at her next class like last time.

"Catra," Glimmer began with a smirk. Her eyes seemed casually open, too familiar really. "What do you think about Scorpia and

Perfuma?”

Up until 45 minutes ago, she'd never thought of them in the same sentence. So Catra played dumb. “Like what?”

Glimmer was not pleased. “T ogether.”

“T ogether how?”

“Catra!” she yelled as she bared her teeth.

Behind them, Adora and Bow giggled quietly .

“Like, doing a crossword puzzle? In a footrace? What are we workin’ with here, Sparkles?”

“Ugh, I forgot you're the worst!” Glimmer whined. She glanced back for support.

Catra shot a quick look over her shoulder . Bow seemed happy. Adora, not so much. She was laser-focused on where Catra and Glimmer’s bodies connected.

Glimmer turned back around and shot Catra a look that she didnt understand. Like they both understood a secret, except Catra was definitely not in on the joke.

“Anyway , do you think they'd make a cute couple?” Glimmer asked.

With a shrug, Catra replied, “Sure.” How was she supposed to be the judge of that? She didnt realize this was an option that anyone was considering.

“So Scorpia really likes her?” Glimmer continued.

“How am I supposed to know?”

“Y ou're her best friend,” Bow answered.

Catra thought about her friendship with Scorpia and Entrapta. Dating had never really been a topic of discussion for them. Not until Huntara entered the picture, at least. "We dont talk about stuff like that. And if we did, Id never tell you three dorks. You cant keep a secret."

"Youd be surprised," Glimmer teased.

When Adora cleared her throat very loudly and dramatically, Bow giggled again.

Catra didnt appreciate seeing the evidence of all the inside jokes they must have created over the last 2 years.

"You really dont know anything about this, do you?" Glimmer said, more to herself really. "That's so weird. Youre sooo oblivious."

Catra felt the tip of her tail twitch behind her.

Bow rushed in to correct, "Glimmer's just kidding. Whatever you and Scorpia talk about is your business. Good job respecting her boundaries."

Catra rolled her eyes at how hard he was trying.

"Fine," Glimmer groaned. "Ill give you the rundown and then if you find anything out, you can let me know." Catra neither wanted nor agreed to this exchange. "Scorpia sent Perfuma a candygram a couple weeks after literally like 3 years of them being *super* cute and awkward around each other."

"Sooo cute," Bow confirmed.

Huh. So *that's* who Scorpia was secretly crushing on? Gods, maybe Catra *was* oblivious. She hadnt picked up any of that at all.

"Neither of them seems to be doing anything about it though, and it's *killing* me," Glimmer whined.

"I got nothing for ya, Sparkles."

Glimmer narrowed her eyes. "What about you?" she asked, pushing herself somehow impossibly even further into Catra's personal space as they walked. "You send a candygram to anyone?"

Catra nearly stumbled over her own feet as Bow and Adora made matching dramatic shocked gasps. Glimmer tightened her hold to help keep Catra upright. It was written all over her suspicious little face – Glimmer *knew*.

Finding her bearings quickly, Catra mulled that over briefly. There was definitely no way Glimmer could know. Even if Sea Hawk had to sort through the stupid boxes, he hadn't watched Catra write the message. Her name was nowhere on it. Glimmer was just fucking with her.

"Does that mean the one I sent to you got lost?" Catra asked. She slipped her arm out of Glimmer's hold and wrapped it around the girl's shoulders instead.

"I'm taken, Driluth," Glimmer responded but her free arm reached around Catra's waist.

Adora huffed behind them. She only got louder when Glimmer paused to let Catra head down the east hall towards her next class and Glimmer insisted on leaving her with a loud, disgusting kiss on the cheek.

Entrapta needed a test subject. Catra wasn't really sure what the test was for exactly and she'd been even overwhelmed just by the instructions.

"Walk towards the library," Entrapta had explained, handing Catra a tablet. "When you hear a ping, make a note of where you are, and then come back."

It seemed easy enough but once Catra started heading down the hallway, she got self-conscious. Was she doing this correctly? She hadn't asked how fast or slow. Suddenly, she was overthinking her own walking pace, trying to force herself to be normal and do something that she did everyday without even noticing it.

The halls were empty with everyone either already gone home for the day or off in their afterschool activities. It was the perfect environment to become unnecessarily aware that Catra's pace was super weird and too fast and was her stride kinda of-

With a loud, "Oof," she collided with a wall.

Catra took a step back and realized, nope, not a wall. She glanced up and was staring directly into Huntara's angry face.

Rationally, Catra knew that Huntara was probably pissed because an idiot had just slammed right into her. Irrationally, Catra was maybe kinda worried that Huntara knew she was starting to spend time with Adora again. It was possible to write it off as research or something. Maybe Huntara would buy that, which was good cause *Catra* was kinda struggling to buy that herself.

"Move," was all Huntara said before she literally *picked Catra up* shifted her a few inches to the right, and deposited her back on her feet, as if she was a teacup that was in the wrong place.

Catra didn't even know how to respond to such an absurd way of problem solving. It ended up not mattering anyway – apparently their interaction was over so Huntara continued down the hall on her way. In the back of her mind, Catra wondered if this was all fucking up Entrapta's experiment.

"Oh," Huntara said suddenly, sounding surprised with herself. She took a quick look around before jogging briskly back to Catra.

For the first time, Catra noticed that Huntara was wearing her practice uniform, pads and all. That would probably just make it

easier for Huntara to flatten her.

"I heard there's gonna be a party coming up in a few days," Huntara said.

Catra was perplexed. People didn't usually try to keep her up-to-date on all the supposedly 'cool' things they were doing without her.

"And?"

"And," Huntara repeated impatiently, "can you try to find out if Adora's going?"

The tablet made some kind of annoyed alarm sound. Catra was probably standing still for too long. And also, probably being recorded by Entrapta.

So she lied, "Sure." She wasn't about to go and actually gather any intel about Adora to give away.

"Good." Huntara pushed at her hair in that nervous way. "I think I'm gonna make a move there."

She said it as a statement but her face showed that it was a question of some type. She was waiting for Catra's opinion or her blessing or something stupid.

"Sure," Catra said again, shrugging.

"Cool," Huntara mumbled. Then she turned and jogged away again.

This project had an end date in sight. Just a few more days then Huntara would finally just tell Adora how she felt.

Catra turned that over and over in her head as she began to head towards the library again. This time, she didn't think about how fast she was going or any bullshit about her stride. She thought only about how pretty soon, this week would feel like some kind of fever dream that had never even happened. There'd be a fleeting memory

of a couple of too-short days where she and Adora felt themselves pushed into each other’s orbit one last time. One last time before they drifted away from each other forever.

Chapter End Notes

next chapter - really just adds to catra's theory that the universe is conspiring "against" her (aka trying to give her what she clearly wants.)

I Thought the World of You

Chapter Notes

hi!today , the conspiracy continues. (in catra's mind, at least 😳😳). this chapter is the longest so get some water and maybe a snack

shout-out to @catrasyelloweye on twitter , who made a C'ĦRAno de bergerac joke so good that i had to immediately change catra's entire name (https://twitter.com/catrasyelloweye/status/1562091917269258240)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After a confusing last couple of days in Glimmer's very draining presence, Catra was appreciating her nice, quiet room a lot more. According to Glimmer, her busy season had begun in earnest now that October was closer so it was time to plan out the most boring, unnecessary social activities that Catra had ever heard of. Fundraisers, dances, the senior class trip, homecoming.

At this point, Glimmer had explained homecoming and court and all the other shit that came with it no less than 4 times and Catra still didnt get why she should care. Actually , fuck that. She was completely happy *not* caring. The problem was that Glimmer found that unacceptable.

At lunch, after she explained the whole thing, Glimmer had asked if Catra was interested in being part of the planning committee. Catra had just turned to Scorpia and asked her thoughts on some show that Scorpia was obsessed with so she had something to pretend to listen to.

When Glimmer found her in the hall between classes and tried to invite her to go dress shopping, Catra declined and dashed off.

Now, Glimmer had called Catra on the phone – on the *phone!* – to rant about all the drama with the homecoming court.

This was not real life. This was definitely not *Catra's* life, where Glimmer Moon decided overnight that they were best friends. Catra wasn't even sure how Glimmer had gotten ahold of her number.

"And our idea of making the court less problematic and binary worked, which was good, but now I've got to find sashes that aren't gendered cause everyone decided not to go with 'queen' and 'princess' in solidarity with DT, who just wants to be called 'ruler.' That's not a sash that Party City carries!"

"Just have everyone make their own," Catra suggested. This was the most mindless conversation she'd ever had. "You can even throw a little court-only party where everyone decorates them."

Duh.

"Oh my Gods, that's actually brilliant!" Glimmer screamed so loudly that Catra finally gave up and put the phone on speaker so that she didn't risk rupturing an eardrum.

She left her phone on the counter while she continued her homework. Somehow, Glimmer had called Catra only minutes after she'd gotten home from her errands. It had been an hour of useless noise and Glimmer didn't seem to be slowing down anytime soon.

"Maybe you should raise some money and pay me as a consultant," Catra suggested. She should be compensated for her time. And also for her suffering.

"Helping your classmates make unforgettable memories is its own reward. Oh shit – hold on a second. Bow's calling."

"I'm just gonna hang-" Catra began but the empty sound on the other side told her Glimmer had already put her on hold.

Seconds later, Glimmer's voice was back, already running a mile a minute.

Godsdamnit. She'd *added* Bow to the call?

"Hey , Catra," he sang, like the three of them talked all the time or something. "How' s it going?"

"W ell get to her in a sec," Glimmer interrupted. "Now , listen to this"…

As Glimmer began retelling Bow *word-f or-word* everything she'd told Catra only minutes ago, the situation became dire. Catra started to wonder how her life had led to this moment. She'd been so careful, so wary of nice people and good intentions. Avoidant of friendly smiles and any chance to get to know anyone deeper. Scorpia was an exception, sure, but she had filled Catra's quota of people she'd tolerate.

This Bow and Glimmer situation needed to be solved immediately. Catra couldn't af ford to change her number but she could throw the phone away forever. That would save money and incredibly narrow down the ways that people could contact her. Win-win really.

The two of them carried on with their recap while she considered alternative communication ideas. Maybe she could bring back beepers – was that a thing? Entrapta would probably have some good input. Catra went to text her but was stalled by the most recent message from Entrapta and Scorpia that she had ignored for the last several hours.

Entrapta
Catra, you seem to be spending more time than usual with Adora Gray's friends
Should I adjust our preferred outcome for your job with Huntara?

Scorpia
Oooh, good point
Wildcat, you had a change of heart yet?

Yet? Why was Scorpia acting like it was inevitable for Catra to try to walk this project back? From the beginning, Entrapta had said Catra was going to fail. Fucking hell, was there not a single person in Catra's life who believed in her?

As if summoned by fate, her phone chose that moment to vibrate with another message.

Adora
Have you seen that new queer werewolves show?

Catra's phone shot out of her hand and landed with a loud smack on the floor.

"Why are you interrupting again?" Glimmer yelled. "Did you fall?"

"Ugh, *no!*" Catra yelled back. She was still too anxious to pick her phone up so she had to scream down towards it. "Just keep going."

Once Glimmer's non-stop talking was background noise again, Catra managed to scoop the device up. Shockingly, it had no cracks. Well, no *new* cracks. The piece of shit had kinda been kicked around a lot and already had lots of marks to show for it. This latest development hadn't completely knocked it out of commission thankfully.

She looked at her screen, trying to make sure she hadn't imagined it.

Nope. Adora Gray had texted her. It wasn't even the sort of awkward weird message that Catra expected they'd exchange the first time Adora reached out. It was a completely normal question. A conversation starter.

Catra began to reply without really even thinking about what a terrible idea this was.

But when her keyboard appeared, the window shifted. Catra was able to see the history of the thread.

Huntara
Yeah so that's pretty much what an o line does

Adora
Oh wow
Thanks for explaining
Gonna get ready for bed. Night.

Adora
Have you seen that new queer werewolves show?

Catra managed not to drop her phone this time. Adora had texted *Huntara.* Somehow, miraculously, after the dullest set of messages Catra had ever seen, Adora was still interested in talking to Huntara. She either was a complete idiot or she really had it bad.

"Catra, are you even listening right now?" Glimmer asked.

"No. Why would you ever think that?"

"I need your input on balloons!"

"I have to go," Catra told her . Her brain stumbled for an excuse, but it was hard to think about anything except Adora. "My toilet' s on fire."

"You're a terrible liar ."

"Yeah, probably. Bye."

She hung up quickly so she could begin her staring contest with this message. Huntara might respond. Huntara *should* respond. If they were gonna go out, the two of them should have some experience actually carrying a conversation. An exchange of ideas or tastes, not just a one-sided lecture about dumb shit.

But, and this was a *strong* counterargument: Catra was curious. Curious about the show. Curious about Adora's interests. Curious about Adora and anything vaguely *gay* -related.

"Huntara" 😈
Nope
But you had me at "queer werewolves"

Adora
Lol
Which part
Queer or werewolves

"Huntara" 😈
Either/both?

Adora
It's so bad!
It's the best thing I've ever seen!
They built up all this mythology stolen directly from other shows
And then forgot about it halfway through just to focus on girls kissing

"Huntara" 😈
Okay, judgey
You've never forgotten what you're supposed to be doing just cause you started thinking about kissing a cute girl?

Adora
Well, when you put it that way…
I guess I can relate
😉

"Huntara" 😈
So
Tell me everything

Adora
About the show?
Or the other thing?
😉

The dummy was apparently a big fan of that winking emoj. How fucking annoying that Adora was being almost smooth for once. And it was wasted on Huntara.

That last part didnt seem to matter much to Catra' s body, she noticed, as goosebumps pebbled along her arms, under her fur. Catra swallowed down a suspicious set of nerves and she began to write back.

"Huntara" 😈
Start with the show and well see where things go from there

Catra was late again. This time she could admit that it was absolutely her own fault. Two nights in a row, she'd let herself get convinced to stay up late, texting with Adora about the most random shit. Awful shows with terrible tropes, best music to study to, what kind of dog Adora most resembled. Hell, at one point, they'd had a 20 minute fake argument about whether or not water actually had a taste or if everyone's minds were just playing tricks on them.

It was just like old times. Except the part where Adora thought she was talking to Huntara.

This was so dumb. One day, Adora was gonna walk up to Huntara and say something random like 'You can really taste the *spring,* right?' and Huntara was gonna ruin this whole thing. She definitely wasnt actually following any of these conversations. Catra had confirmed that and Huntara had basically said she thought they were both idiots and didnt get what the hell they were even rambling about half the time so she gave up.

In order to make up for getting only four hours of rest and oversleeping by 30 minutes, Catra was barreling down Route 41 at a speed that was sure to guarantee she collapsed in the hall by the time she made it to school. She usually stuck to side roads since she wasn't actually the best biker and everyone in Bright Moon operated their giant SUVs like they were unfamiliar with the concept of blinkers, lanes, speed limits, and the delicate nature of the human body. But this was an emergency and Catra wasn't exactly thinking clearly, because again, she'd barely slept more than 7 hours in the past 2 days.

She reached the awful curve halfway to school that made it impossible to see who was coming around the bend and jµst prayed that she was far enough on the almost nonexistent shoulder that she wouldn't have to throw herself into all the forest on either edge to avoid a collision.

Instead, Catra heard someone accelerate *behind* her. She couldnt look back, eyes still straining to see if there was anyone speeding towards her. Hopefully, this person would at least wait until the road was straight again before they decided to pass.

When the car got a little closer, it honked, startling Catra so much she almost lost her balance. Asshole.

Catra used her left arm to motion for them to go around. They were nearly in the clear. But nope, the car jµst honked at her again.

The second time her arm went up, it was to flip them off. The bend came to an end and Catra was jµst a straight shot away from school with only a couple more miles to go. The opposite lane was completely empty so she motioned for the car to go ahead around her again.

This time, it actually bothered to comply. It pulled by, a sorta-reasonable-sized mini SUV but bright gold. How tacky. It didnt speed up though when it was side-by-side with Catra. When she heard the window roll down, she kept her eyes glued forward,

preparing for whatever annoying bullshit they were gonna yell, her idiot classmates usually looking for an opportunity to get some kind of dig in.

She was not prepared for a loud familiar voice to yell, "W ear a helmet!" while an even more familiar voice tried to whisper , "Oh my Gods, Dad!Stop it!Sorry , Catra!Good morning!"

The window rolled back up just as Catra glanced over to see Adora sitting in the passenger seat, face bright red. She was trying to hide slightly so it was very obvious to see Randor next to her, chiseled bearded face smiling and winking at her.

As they sped off, easing back into their lane, Catra appreciated that at least she wasnt the only one who was late because of their sleep-defiant chats.

Bike locked and assignments distributed, Catra was about to speed to class when she remembered that she actually needed her history book today and, unfortunately, it was somewhere in her mess of a locker. She'd almost hunted it down when DT slid into her peripheral vision.

"My liege," Catra greeted them with.

Their face widened into a huge smile, all of their *many* sharp, pearly white teeth on display.

"Y ou heard?" they asked, sounding extremely pleased with themself. "Isnt it just *perf ect,* darling? Ive always thought of myself as royalty ."

Catra imagined it wasnt their popularity that pushed the homecoming votes in their favor. DT knew everyone's secrets. It probably wasnt hard for them to swing the count their way .

"So, moving beyond my big news, let' s get to yours, Kiten."

"What' s that?"

Done exchanging books, Catra zipped her backpack closed and shut her locker. Unfortunately, that meant she had to actually turn towards DT, who looked like they could read every single lie on her face.

"Dont play dumb. It' s too beneath you."

Catra scoffed. "Nothing' s too beneath me."

DT leaned in closer to drop their voice slightly. "The rumor mill hasnt had a *peep* to say about Huntara and Adora lately. Not since everyone started whispering *plenty* about you and everyone's favorite team captain."

Catra looked around nervously to make sure no one was paying attention as they rushed by on their way to class.

"There is no 'me and Adora', okay?" she hissed quietly.

DT was unconvinced. "I heard you two might make the ballot for Cutest Couple in the yearbook."

Oh Gods, that would be embarrassing. An image of the two of them captured on paper for all eternity.

Catra wondered what they would wear and how they'd pose with each other. Side by side or that cheesy pr-

Nope. This was not only a bad exercise for Catra's heart, this was potentially harmful for her *health.* She reached out and grabbed DT by the collar of the long black lace frock thing they were wearing today.

"You have to squash that. *Now*. You're gonna get me killed. If I fuck this up, Huntara's gonna eat my face."

DT gently pried Catra's hand off before smoothing their clothes down. Their face didn't move but she noticed their eyes narrow slightly. Catra took a step back, holding her hands up briefly to show she was backing off.

Catra thought the conversation was over when DT turned and began walking away.

"Well, not if your big strong hockey player girlfriend is there to protect you," DT teased over their shoulder way too loudly .

Catra rushed to follow them and close to the distance so no one else could overhear. "I don't need anyone to protect me. Especially not Adora."

"Protect you from what?" she heard from behind her .

Catra turned to find Adora following her down the hall. Two years with no contact and suddenly she was everywhere.

There were slight bags under her eyes, darkening her pale skin. Other than that, Adora looked fresh as daisy. Upbeat. Energized. Wearing an outfit that should be banned from school if Catra had any say in it. It was an unnecessarily snug gray worn-in v-neck tshirt that was too tight aroundwell, everywhere.

For the first time, Catra regretted not going to a school that instituted a dress code.

She tore her eyes away from Adora to frown at the blonde's smiling face. "If you'd been eavesdropping more effectively. You'd know that I just said I don't need protecting."

Adora shifted her heavy backpack to just her right arm and Catra did a great job of refusing to look anywhere except her eyes.

"Of course you don't," Adora said. "You're the one who taught me that anything can be used as a weapon."

"Roll of quarters in a tube sock really changes someone's tone," Catra drawled lazily. Octavia had learned that in 5th grade when she decided to make fun of Adora's sudden growth spurt. Catra's ingenuity shut that shit down quick.

"But if you *did* need protection." Adora took a couple steps closer until Catra could smell her floral shampoo. She leaned her elbow against a locker, propping her head on it. Her silly confident grin was nearly as big as the bicep she flexed. "I'd be up for the task."

Catra opened her mouth, hopefully to do something besides let her drool freely escape. She wasn't really sure, since her brain was only maybe at about 1/10th of its typical functioning power. Adora wasn't moving, just stuck in this pose and Catra had no sense of how long they had before the bell would ring or a natural disaster would save her from devolving into a total disaster herself.

Next to Catra, DT made a little hum. It was quiet enough that Adora didn't seem to notice. For Catra, though, they might as well have been on a bullhorn yelling, told ya so!

She cut her eyes towards them, but DT was smart enough to scamper off without another word. They were always good at that, faking when they had decided they were done with someone rather than the other way around. Catra wasn't even sure they'd gotten quite what they wanted. Or , really, even *what* they wanted. Probably just to gloat or to see if she'd slip and give them any gossip about Adora. There just wasn't anything to say . Absolutely nothing was happening between the two of them.

When she focused back on Adora, maybe Catra brought a little too much heat to her glare, still annoyed at DT.

"Can I help you with something?" she barked out.

Adora stopped flexing, face fully confused. *"I* was offering to help *you."*

Catra took a bit of a breath and tried to dial the aggression back a little. "And as we covered, I'm all good. Why are you holding up my route to class? Trying to lead me to truancy?"

Adora's whole demeanor changed. She stood up a little straighter and removed her arm from the locker. Gone was her dimpled smile and in its place was a slightly embarrassed scowl. Adora even bowed her head slightly, like she was worried about Catra yelling at her.

"You've been summoned," she said.

"What? What does that mean?"

Adora wilted even more. Catra felt a little bad. In the past, Adora had never been afraid to tell her anything, share anything with her. This new reaction was probably an unfortunate byproduct of, you know, Catra screaming at Adora like she'd fucking lost her mind the last time they fought.

This felt like something she needed to fix. They might not be friends anymore but Adora was one of a few select people who never needed to worry about not being themselves in front of Catra.

She reached out slowly, not really any plan in mind. Her hand made gentle contact with Adora's forearm. Her skin was still so fucking soft and Catra held herself back from stroking it by gripping Adora's arm slightly. That wasn't much better, she realized as Adora flexed unconsciously.

"Hey, whatever it is," Catra said quietly. "It's okay. Just tell me."

Adora's eyebrows flew up, glancing from Catra's hand to her face and back. "Uh"…

This wasn't working. She was just making Adora more uncomfortable. But Catra didn't know what to do except lean into this closeness more, if only to calm her own rapidly-increasing nerves. She gripped Adora's arm harder as her tail floated around and caressed along the inside of the other girl's wrist.

A strange sound came out of Adora's throat, the sort of soft whine she used to make when waking up at their sleepovers. Catra tried to pull back – this all felt like a bit much of an overstep – but Adora rushed to reach down with her free hand and hold Catra in place.

"Sorry ," Adora mumbled. Catra wasn't sure what piece she was apologizing for. Seemed like they had so many options for both of them to feel bad about. "Uh, it' s not anything bad, just so you know . My dad just wants to see you. When he comes to pick me up today after school, he asked if you'd stop by the car and say hello."

The question threw Catra off f. She jumped back a foot, freeing herself from Adora.

Randor wanted to see her? After years of her being an absolute dick and never returning to the house where she'd spent more than half her childhood? Why?

It was too early to begin to worry about this so Catra tried just avoiding it. "Y ou still get picked up after school? How embarrassing for you."

Adora rolled her eyes, her own hand going to rub the spot that Catra had abandoned. "I don't have practice today . He insisted on leaving work early so he can see you and take me to get a treat' or something. Honestly, it was weird."

Well, *Randor* was weird. He was as big as a house, as loud as a construction site, and as gentle as a little bunny. Her memories of him were filled with her and Adora trying to scale him like a jungle gym, him teaching them how to play soccer, countless hours of bad movies cause Randy refused to 'waste his time watching kids crap.' She always used to wish that all of the adults in her life could be as cool as him.

The last time Catra had talked to him, he was dropping her and Adora off at the sophomore dance. He was probably pissed when he

came to get Adora afterwards and found her crying with Catra nowhere in sight.

Catra wasn't sure if seeing him today would lead to a lecture, revenge, or a reunion. It would probably be best to avoid it altogether.

Her reluctance must have read on her face.

"It's just a quick wave at the car," Adora said.

It was not. Catra knew Randor. If she came within 400 feet of that car, he was gonna try convincing her to come with them wherever they were going. It didn't matter if it was a car wash or a 2-hour drive, Randor used to scoop Adora and Catra up, toss them in the backseat, and courier them all around town. She always suspected it was because her own ex-guardian was never able to do anything with her, but Randor was always committed to taking the two kids on adventures. His idea of an 'adventure' was incredibly loose and varied. There was always some form of sugar or greasy food involved, though, so Catra was constantly onboard for whatever.

"Maybe," she said, shrugging at Adora. "I'm a little busy today but I'll try to wave."

Adora immediately brightened. "Great!"

The bell rang suddenly, leaving Catra pretty sure that it had been conspiring this whole time to make sure this conversation happened. She'd entered school already so far behind and then space and time decided to stand still for several minutes. Only for the Grays.

When Catra got out of her last class, Adora was already waiting in the hall for her. She'd been thinking about this stupid shirt all day, how the material looked so soft but was filled out with curves and toned muscle. Catra even went so far as to make sure she rushed to

eat lunch with Entrapta in the computer lab so she didn't have to look directly at it anymore. Now it was in front of her, just waiting.

Oh, and Adora was apparently there also and talking.

"What?" Catra asked.

"I said how was your day?" Adora repeated. She was smiling a little, like she had the upper-hand. Catra didn't care for that.

"Suitable," she answered shortly. "You here to make sure I don't make a break for it?"

Adora gave a fake solemn nod, frowning dramatically. "If you don't come, he'll hold me personally responsible."

"The worst punishment he would ever give you is only one scoop of ice cream after dinner and not a full sundae," Catra replied, rolling her eyes. Randor wasn't nearly as tough as he looked.

"But it *has* to be a sundae, Catra!" Adora whined. "The nuts and stuff add texture."

Catra wasn't immediately bolting so Adora must have taken that as a good sign. She grabbed Catra's hand and broke off into a run, pulling her down the hallway and out the back door. The sudden contact, the familiarity of this all, was enough to make Catra forget that she hadn't agreed to any of this.

Randor was sitting in the car with the windows rolled down, loudly listening to 'Closer to Fine.' His deep rumbling voice somehow improbably managed to really hit that high fiiiiiiiiine', which was impressive.

"I forgot what a lesbian your dad is," Catra said. He always listened to the alt and folk stations on the radio. Catra was now old enough to realize those were filled with 90% queer and queer-adjacent women. After years of being trapped in a car with that, it wasn't really a

surprise that she and Adora had turned out so gay. The lesbian agenda was working.

As they got within a couple feet of the car, Catra called out, "Hey , Randor!" She then promptly dropped Adora' s hand and stopped moving. Adora made it all the way to the door before noticing.

"W ell, Cyra Elizabeth Dfiluth!" Randor yelled back, face split into a huge smile. He angled himself so he was almost hanging halfway out the window, not at all concerned about wrinkling the neat pale green button-up he was wearing. "How the hell are you?"

He seemed so happy to see her so Catra forgave him for using her government name in public.

"Cant complain," she answered. She was trying very hard to keep her face and her tone neutral. It was nerve-wracking to see him after so long. To not know how he really felt about her for once.

"W ell, I hope youfre hungry . Wefre gonna get a late lunch." He settled back into his seat. "Maybe this is an early dinner . *Dinner .*"

Randor always chose the best food places. And Catra *was* hungry. But this was a trick.

At the reminder of food, Adora once again reached for the car door. The back door, Catra noticed, not shotgun like a normal person. This was *def initely* a trick.

"Come on. Get in the car , kiddo," Randor sang, when Catra still wouldnt move, just awkwardly standing there.

Catra put a hand on her hip and gave him a shrewd look. "Sir , are you in a school parking lot trying to lure children into your vehicle?"

Randor just laughed. "Remember when I caught you forging Weaver's signature on your permission slip for the aqarium and agreed not to tell? Well, Im calling in my favor now ."

"That had an expiration date."

"Oh? Funny how you didn't mention that at the time. When did it expire?"

"The end of 4th grade," Catra replied, like that was obvious. W as he naive enough to believe an 8 year-old was going to keep their word forever? Though to be fair, Catra had always expected that Adora would keep the childhood promise that they'd be friends forever , so what did she know?

"I suppose I should have known better than to trust a tiny con artist," Randor agreed.

Catra nodded in return, frowning at him very seriously.

Randor pretended to sigh deeply. He closed his eyes before leaning his head back against his headrest.

"W ell, I'm out of ideas, Dora," he said, faking at being defeated. "I guess we'll just have to enjoy our burgers alone."

Her tail gave her away before anything else did. Randor slightly cracked one eye to peek out at her, while Adora leaned against the car looking back and forth between the two of them. Catra's tail began to weave behind her in curiosity. That was enough of a giveaway for Randor to shoot back up in his seat.

"BP?" he asked. "Y ou can't turn down BP . I heard they added like 4 new flavors of concretes."

Catra opened her mouth to remind him that she couldn't eat a full milkshake without being violently ill for hours afterward, when he added, "W ell just have to swing by the drugstore and pick up lactaid pills. Turns out the old man can't handle dairy so well anymore."

Shit. He'd thought of everything, including how to make it feel like they weren't just doing Catra a favor .

"Fine," she relented finally. "I can't leave Adora trapped in a car with you all evening."

Adora did some all star acting, keeping a straight face even as her eyes widened, all big and happy and excited. She reached for the door handle again and pulled it open.

With a nod towards Catra, she said, "Great. Get in," and waited patiently for Catra to slide in.

The car smelled like new leather with a hint of the Gray household – jasmine candles, too much fabric softener (seriously, that family didn't understand how unnecessary it was), and something that just felt calming. Easy, even as Catra stumbled nervously into the car near the opposite door so she could sit as far away from Adora as possible.

As she expected, Adora jumped into the backseat with her. Adora managed to keep her distance though, sticking behind Randor, who was definitely watching them in the rear-view mirror. Catra kept her eyes trained on the parking lot around them, which was great, because she could see Scorpia heading for the bus. Watching to make sure that Scorpia, a person fully capable of taking care of herself, made it safely onto the schoolbus took up so much energy that Catra was able to ignore Adora's hand slowly moving towards her until it paused on the center seat.

Gods, this felt like an awkward chaperoned date.

Randor only made it worse when he started driving off and pumped the radio up louder to apparently really appreciate 'Constant Craving.'

They had to drive past where the bus was parked at the front of the school. Much like Adora had earlier that morning, Catra tried to slide further down in her seat so that no one would see her. Randor insisted on driving this bright gold monster though. Catra noticed at

least a dozen eyes from where she peeked up through her window, practically on the floor of the car.

"Hey , buckle up back there!" Randor called. "Y ou're not too cool for a seatbelt. Or internal bleeding when we crash."

"Gods, dad," Adora whined.

Catra tried to slowly creep back into her seat, since they were almost clear of the bus and everything was fine. She buckled in right as they cruised to a stop at the intersection and sat back with a sigh of relief.

Sadly, that was premature. Catra's calm was destroyed as she heard the sound of the bus pulling up behind them.

"T urn," she urged Randor .

"There' s cars coming." He frowned at her in the mirror . "I'm being a responsible adult."

"Y ou literally promised me you'd teach me how to drift once I got my license."

"What?!" Adora shouted.

Catra watched Randor narrow his eyes. "W ell, that was a secret between us pals, Cat. So now we have to sit here and wait while you think about the importance of trust."

She hissed in his direction but it wasn't very threatening since she was busy trying to flatten the top half of her body against the seat. Of course that meant that in order to avoid the bus full of classmates stopping right next to them, Catra had unintentionally all but put her head into Adora's lap. Like an idiot, she'd even forgotten to make Adora move her hand first so it was just trapped there now , wrapped up in Catra's hair somewhere.

"Embarrassed to be seen with me?" Adora tried to laugh at Catra' s antics but really she sounded like she'd just swallowed a frog.

"I'd like people to know less than 0% of what I do in my life," Catra replied.

The bus paused only briefly since it was going the opposite direction as them. It lurched forward again quickly before turning to the right. From her angle, Catra couldn't really see anyone so she figured they couldn't see her either…

Until the end of the bus passed them and she eyed Scorpia standing at the window clear as day. Catra hoped maybe her friend was looking down the road or had (fingers crossed) suddenly forgot what Catra looked like. But nope. Scorpia was staring openly, jaw hanging in surprise, pincers holding her cheeks. She looked like she'd just seen a box full of puppies playing with a box of bunnies.

Randor still had the windows rolled down so Catra – and hopefully Catra *alone* – could hear Scorpia as she squealed, "AWWWW, way to go, Wildcat!"

The embarrassment had rendered Catra silent for the rest of the ride. Randor pretended not to notice and made up for it by filling space with some dorky Dad-rambling, broken up by him loudly singing along with the radio. After Catra returned to a normal sitting position, Adora mostly just joined in when Randor asked her a specific question or made a particularly cringey attempt at humor.

True to his promise, he spent about 3 minutes rushing into the drugstore and running back out with a small box, so quickly that Catra accused him of shoplifting.

"If anything happens, you two are my alibi. No one believes a kind and responsible father would steal."

He sped away, laughing loudly until just a couple minutes later, he was pulling up to the Bright Moon Burger Palace. It was an old school burger place where the food was delicious and greasy and

the servers were somewhere between deeply unconcerned and openly rude.

Adora jumped out of the car as soon as it stopped, screaming, "I'm gonna go check the specials!"

She dashed off as Catra and Randor followed at a normal pace.

"So..." he started before trailing of f.

"So?" Catra repeated. She wasn't really sure what she was supposed to talk to him about anymore. He was less a close confidant and more like just another random adult in her life these days.

"You want to play things that way? Cool by me." Randor shrugged while Catra waited for him to add something else that would tell her what the hell he was thinking.

Instead, he pulled his wallet out of his pocket. It was bulky and looked like it was full of sandwich shop punchcards and other beaten up crap. Randor slipped all of the cash out and handed it over to Catra without counting.

"What's this for?" she asked, even as she took it and shoved it into her pocket. If he was planning on changing his mind, too bad. She knew he could afford it.

"Linner," Randor answered and she really wished he would stop trying to make that a word. "Plus, I'm reimbursing you for your time. I know how many after-school jobs you have. I imagine you're missing out on a lot of work to spend time with us right now."

"You're paying me to hang out with your kid?" This felt way too similar to what she was already doing for Huntara.

Randor rolled his eyes. "No, I mostly just want you to buy a damn helmet if you're gonna be biking in the middle of the road. It's either

take the money or me and Marlena are gonna send a half-dozen options to your house. And once that door is open, who knows what kind of surprises you'll end up with."

"Thanks? W ait, why am I paying for the food?"

He smiled conspiratorially. "I just remembered that I have a meeting so itll just be you two girls today ."

As they entered the restaurant and the tacky decor transported them 60 years back in time, Catra's eyes shot around looking for Adora. The dummy was up by the counter, studying the menu like there was gonna be a test on it later.

Randor pulled something else out from his wallet. Catra was getting kinda tired of his surprises. It was just a card though, his work stuf f included on it.

"Shoot me an email sometime this week. I wanna see a list of what schools you're applying to. Send your GP A and test scores too."

"What are you up to now?" Catra asked.

He gasped dramatically. "I'm just an interested parent!"

Not mine,' Catra thought but that wasnt exactly true. "Fine. Y ou're not gonna do anything weird, are you?"

"I just want to research them. Make sure they're good enough for you."

"Randy" she said, trying to get him to come clean.

"Catty" he echoed. And then he laughed at her frowning face so loudly that nearby tables turned to look at him. "Y ou still coming to work for me after you graduate college?"

"I've been telling you for years that I know nothing about business."

He'd never let that stop him from bringing up before. Somehow , even with him no longer being a part of her life, she doubted that would stop him now.

"But you're the most resourceful kid I've ever met. From what I hear , you understand more about supply and demand than anyone else in this town."

That might be true but. "I don't wanna live in a small town."

"Fine," he huf fed. "I'll let you work remote. Live wherever you want." He paused to grin. "It would be nice to have someone headquartered in Eternia anyway."

Catra stubbornly ignored the Eternia part. "It' s not a terrible idea to have a fallback plan."

Randor nodded at that. Then he bit the corner of his bottom lip, looking exactly like his kid.

"Y ou know if you ever need us, Marlena and I will come running, right?" he asked, his voice too gentle.

He waited patiently for Catra to actually answer. She gave him a quick nod.

At once, Randor was back to being a total dork. "Good. Stop by and see an old man from time to time please. Call. Text. However you kids get in touch with people these days."

"Aren't you just an elder millennial?"

"Emphasis on the elder part."

Adora bounded over to them with way too much energy.

"They have some kind of green chilis on the burger special today . Sounds delicious," she announced.

"Great. I gotta run back to the of fice," Randor explained to her . He didn't even try to sound regretful about this.

Adora looked like her head was actually threatening to spin. "W ait- what?! How are we supposed to get home?"

"It' s not a long walk. You'll be fine. Catra' s in charge," Randor said, before clapping Catra on the back.

"I always am," she replied. The Grays had long trusted her more to keep the two of them alive.

Without waiting, Randor turned towards the door.

"Bye, my loves," he shouted over his shoulder as he rushed of f. He was in the car before Adora could even start forward.

Randor had left them alone, with money to pay for their meal…

Catra's whole body felt like it had come down with a fever when she realized she'd just been set up on a date by someone' s dad! W ell played, old man. Instead of thinking about the implications of this, she'd just use the meal to plan her revenge on him.

She'd have to figure out some way to get her bike from school but she wouldn't be surprised if Randor popped back up in a couple hours or texted her that he'd be giving her a ride in the morning.

Once it was clear that this wasn't a prank and Randor was actually abandoning them, Catra turned back to Adora. The dummy's mouth was trapped half-open, face still contorted in confusion.

"Let' s grab a booth," Catra suggested. Adora didn't move immediately so she grabbed her hand and tugged her over to the closest seat.

They didn't speak much until a very bored server came over and took their order. Adora had pulled out her phone and sent a couple

messages but she mostly seemed concerned about making sure she took advantage of all the limited edition shit on the menu.

"He' s really not coming back," she said, putting her phone down. "How did he forget he had 3 hours left at work?"

Catra was *not* about to explain the ruse to her. That would involve admitting that Catra had done something in some way to give Randor the impression that the two of them would benefit from a date.

Which, for the record, she had *not.*

Catra stewed in the semi-awkward silence for another minute before she built up the courage to ask, "Why isn't he pissed at me?"

Adora frowned at her, even going so far as to tilt her head cutely in confusion. "Why would he be?"

"When people stop being friends, they talk shit about each other to everyone else." Everyone knew that.

Except Adora apparently, who sounded genuinely horrified when she asked, "...do you talk crap about me?"

Catra blinked at her but all that could come out was, "..."

"Catra!"

Something about her offended face made Catra crack up. "No. That's messy."

Adora pouted at her. "W ell, I'd never say anything mean about you."

Sometimes, when Catra was feeling introspective, she would allow herself to think back to their fight. For as bad as it felt, it was never really the *words* that cut so deep. It was the *tone*. She'd been raging and screaming when she said that sometimes she felt that Adora didn't care about their friendship, so different from the quiet

vulnerable way Catra had occasionally felt it in the back of her mind. Adora had sounded so condescending when she'd said that Catra was too stubborn and unwilling to listen, which was actually pretty true, especially in that moment.

Those things weren't irreparable. So why had it felt so impossible to take a step back and try?

Their connection probably. The mountain of shit they'd never found time to say to each other. Catra's own life quietly imploding around her.

"Anyway , they never hated you and neither did I," Adora stated.

Catra forced a dry chuckle out of her even drier throat, trying to sound like that sentence didn't make a whirlwind appear in her body suddenly.

"Then you're dumber than I thought," she said, but under the table, Catra let her foot knock into Adora's, signaling that she was kidding.

Adora laughed just a little. "Yeah, I guess." She cleared her throat awkwardly. "How , umhow are you doing?"

Her voice hinted that Adora meant that in the serious 'Is your life on fire?' way .

"Not bad. Got a place, got a rhythm." Catra rocked side to side to emphasize this. It was the type of nerdy thing Adora would've done. That was horrifying. Minutes in her presence and Catra was already starting to copy her dorky mannerisms like when they were younger.

"Cool, me too," Adora said and fell into the same rhythm, bopping back and forth gently. Gods no. This was too embarrassing. "I mean, it's the same place. My parents' place. Still there if you wanted to drop by."

Catra stopped shifting and ignored the obvious invitation to ask, "How are you?"

Adora's voice went up way high, clearly lying, "I'm good!" She nodded as an emphasis but it wasn't any more convincing.

"Hockey? Your grades?" Catra pressed, leaning her elbows onto the table to get closer.

"Also, good!" Adora started to squirm a bit.

"I know you're lying."

"I-Right." Adora trailed off. "Can we talk about something else for a minute? Right now – this is the first time I haven't been thinking about all of that and how overwhelming it is. Can we just... pretend it's not happening?"

They were pretending so many other things weren't happening already. So sure, what was one more fire to ignore?

"Okay," Catra agreed. She wasn't sure what counted as a safe topic for them so she asked, "Anything fun going on?"

"Well, I came out to my parents," Adora said, so casually that Catra felt genuinely shocked.

"Uhwhat?"

Adora took a deep breath, like she tended to before a long story. "Last Pride month, they were making a big show of being very accepting." She shook her head and laughed a little. Then everything else just kinda fell out in one long sentence. "My dad was greeting everyone by loudly adding his pronouns and asking theirs. They kept starting all these bizarre discussions about being different and how it was okay and made the world bigger and better and things got so awkward after the dozenth time that I just blurted out that I was gay. In the middle of dinner."

While Catra tried to wrap her mind around that, she felt the need to reassure Adora. "That's...not too bad."

"In public," Adora added.

"Ohkay"…

"At Olive Garden," Adora continued.

Catra went to open her mouth. There were probably more awkward places to make that announcement. At least the Grays were alone.

"Right as the server came to take our order ," Adora said.

The image of a poor bystander getting caught in this family melodrama was too funny for Catra not to laugh.

"Probably their plan all along," Catra said. "They're not subtle people."

Adora politely joined in, laughing at her own life.

"So they were cool with it?" Catra guessed.

Adora nodded vigorously. "They had a little flag waiting at home when we got back. Actually, multiple flags cause they weren't really sure how I identified. I had to donate the rest to the GSA at school." She paused to take a sip of the waters that had been dropped in front of them. "I've got an extra one if you're still, uh Y... ou know. If you're still"…

She pressed her lips back to the straw and for a moment, Catra got distracted by Adora's mouth and forgot what the very not-at-all-sly question was that she was slipping in there.

Catra blinked rapidly, looking away from the other girl's soft lips. "Yes, Adora, I'm very much still a lesbian."

Catra had only spent *weeks* trying to figure out how to tell Adora that summer before they turned 15. What came out (well, what came out in addition to Catra) was a blubbering nervous mess. It made her cringe just to think about, the blur of panicked sounds about 'girls' and 'feelings' that fell out of Catra's mouth when Adora turned to her at the arcade where Randor had dropped them off for the day and asked, *totally normally*, if Catra planned on dating any boys once high school started.

She was pretty sure the end of that awful rant was the exact moment that Adora's dad had come to pick them back up. But Adora smiled when Catra was done, gave her a strong hug so briefly that Catra was sure she'd almost imagined, and then put two quarters in the Donkey Kong machine that had been eating all their money. They each hit start – Catra still in maybe a bit of a daze – and began playing like nothing had happened.

Not until they cleared the first stage, did Adora say, in an almost soft voice, "I think I like girls too."

And that was it. Adora didn't say anything else so Catra decided to just respect that? It felt like too much to follow all of that up with any confessions of feelings that she *might* have *possibly* felt for Adora. It was a better idea to wait for a less tense moment.

As soon as they lost on the 5th level, Randor appeared. He was smiling but his body was almost as awkward as the time she unexpectedly got her period while he was making them wait with him at the mechanic one Saturday.

Catra struggled to keep from laughing/crying/freaking out at those memories. "Definitely still a lesbian."

Adora stopped toying with her straw. "Well, I don't know. People evolve in their identities, according to my mom's research."

Catra laughed again, thinking of Marlena googling lesbians in the middle of the night. "They're good parents."

"The best," Adora agreed. "Don't know why my dad made us come here and then forgot about work."

Of course she didn't. It occurred to Catra for the first time that the Grays probably became so deeply obvious about everything to account for how oblivious their kid was.

"Um... speaking of parents..." Adora awkwardly began.

"Yes?..." This was a line of questioning that Catra had been dreading/hoping for. So many times, she'd wanted to tell Adora everything about what led to her leaving home. And yet, it was hard not to be upset that Catra would have to *tell* Adora, that Adora wasn't by her side throughout it all.

"Weaver's gone," Adora said, not noticing how Catra's body went rigid and she could feel her tail puffing out.

"She is," Catra responded, schooling her voice to sound like she was answering a question about traffic directions and not her toxic guardian.

Adora just waited. She was trying to be patient and give Catra time to open up but pretty quickly, Adora's hands reached to take a napkin out of the little holder. As Catra sat there, peering at her closely, Adora began tearing the napkin into little bits. Their server was gonna curse them out if they made a mess.

So to put an end to this, Catra offered, "Guess someone called the county a few too many times. The last time they came out for a wellness check, she agreed to go with them somewhere. Never came back."

Adora's hands balled into fists. She was almost spitting mad when she asked, "She just left you?!"

Catra hissed at her to be quiet. She didn't need anyone around them whispering about her life.

"Weaver gave custody of me back to the state. It was fine. Trust me. I'd already been taking care of myself *and her* for years."

Adora didn't seem to think it was fine. "Do you need help? Do you need-"

"I don't need anything," Catra interrupted. She especially didn't need Adora trying to come in 2 years too late and act like her savior. "Netossa helped me figure things out. And Angella took care of the legal stuff, found Razz to take me in."

Sparkles was annoying but she must have said something good about Catra to get the top judge in the county to speed the process along and not ask too many questions. Catra didn't know how the hell Razz and her kookiness and her mess of a place passed a state inspection but she was grateful. Even with as erratic as she could come off to strangers, Razz was leaps and bounds more steady than Weaver. She certainly cared more.

"It's fine," Catra repeated, signaling that this would be the end of this topic.

Slowly, Adora's hands began to unfurl. She looked like she wanted to ask more questions but she allowed herself to take a few calming breaths.

"I'm glad things are okay," she told Catra. "I heard what you do at school. With the papers and homework and stuff."

Catra had to look away from Adora's eyes. She could put up with the pity from earlier but she wasn't ready for whatever disappointment Adora must have in her.

"I know you probably don't approve or whatever. I imagine plagiarism's probably really dishonest to you."

"No, I think it's cool," Adora said.

Catra's head swiveled back around too quickly . "Cool?"

Adora grimaced. "Okay , not cool. You could get into a lot of trouble!" Catra opened her mouth to tell Adora to keep it down but the dummy took another big breath to chill herself and continued, "But like, I'm really happy you found a way to make money off of just being smart. You're so brilliant."

Now *Catra* was the one fumbling towards her water glass to have something to do with her mess of a body.

Through divine intervention, the server popped back up with their food. Adora's triple-patty monstrosity had melted pepperjack cheese and green chilies spilling out the sides of it. She had chosen to pair this with tater tots covered in nacho toppings. Catra felt a stomach ache just looking at it. Adora dug in before Catra' s plate of a single burger and waffle fries had even fully hit the table.

With Adora's mouth full of food, they got to just sit and relax in each other's company for a while.

Things were a little different from the last time they'd been here. Adora towered over the table more. A lot of the baby fat in her cheeks had given way to high cheekbones and a strongly defined jawline. Her blonde hair had darkened just a little.

"Do I have something on my face?"Adora asked.

She didn't but she grabbed a napkin and started wiping vigorously at her mouth. At her stupid, soft-looking lips.

"Y ou got it,"Catra lied.

"Thanks!"

As soon as Adora had woofed down her burger, she asked, "Y ou decide which concrete you want or we're splitting two?"

"Can you give me a second to at least *taste* my food first?! Jeez!"

"You eat too slow!" Adora complained, which was undermined by her huge smile. She reached over to start finishing off Catra's fries, only to get her finger bit.

Adora yelped loudly. "Are you serious, Catra?"

"Try that shit again and find out." She stubbornly shoved a fry into her mouth. "You don't even like waffle fries."

"They're way too complicated," Adora agreed.

"Adora, you just ate tater tots, which are literally potatoes butchered up into little bits, reconstructed like Frankenstein's monster, and deep fried. And you had the nerve to put nacho cheese and a dozen toppings on it. Don't fucking talk to me about complicated."

"Wow," Adora replied, faking shock. "I didn't realize you were so offended by tot-chos."

"We will *not* be calling them that."

"I'm afraid it's either that or nach-ters."

"I'm not playing this game with you," Catra insisted.

"I'm sorry. I don't make the rules. Nach-ters it is, then." Adora seemed so pleased with herself that Catra just accepted this awful new reality where nach-ters were a thing and set about finishing her meal. The whole time, Adora's eyes didn't move from her once.

They'd survived dinner together, which was still fairly surprising to Catra. Even with Weaver coming up and the million clues that she could have accidentally dropped about their unknown texting, Catra had navigated things well. They stuck to easy topics and really, for the most part, just talked about nothing at all. They gave each other shit and justexisted peacefully next to each other for a couple hours.

It was, as much as Catra hated to admit it, kindanice?

Truly the only blip was when Adora got a text, glanced at it looking super confused for about a whole second, and quickly put her phone away to focus on Catra. As Adora went off to get the bill, Catra checked her phone. Huntara had texted 'what up' and Adora had once again just not even cared? What the hell was happening there? It wasnt like her to be so inconsistent, engaging with Huntara half the time and ignoring her the rest. Clearly, Catra would have to spend a little more time with Adora to figure out what was up with her.

Adora fought her on paying for dinner but relented once Catra admitted that her being placed 'in charge' meant that she had been trusted with the money. For some reason, Adora didnt question that. She did, though, turn suspiciously red and shut up immediately.

Despite Adora checking her phone a dozen times after they wrapped up, Randor didnt seem to be coming back for them. So they set off, wandering down the side of the highway in the general direction of Adora's house, without actually communicating that to each other.

"You going to the party this weekend?" Adora asked. She kept her eyes on the wildflowers they were traipsing through. "It's at Glimmer's place cause her parents are away for a couple days. I think you'd have fun, you know, cause you and Glimmer are friends now." Catra ignored how her voice was just a little bitter at that last part.

Adora had said a lot of dumb things today but this was by far the dumbest. Catra didnt even know where to start with all this.

It seemed simplest to point out, "You're gonna throw a rager at the principal's house?"

"Uh huh."

Catra tried to throw Adora a look but she was still focused elsewhere.

"You're all gonna get expelled, dummy."

At that, Adora's head shot up. Bad idea mode' was fully engaged – shoulders high, hands moving to dazzle you with terrible excuses that would never work.

"Nope. See that's the brilliance of this plan," Adora said and Catra already knew that this could only end in failure. "If *all* the seniors go then they can't expel anyone. Cause they can't expel us *all.* Having no graduating class would be super embarrassing."

"You're all gonna get expelled," Catra repeated since she was still completely unconvinced. "And then I'll immediately be valedictorian on a technicality."

"And you don't want that," Adora shot back quickly. She smiled, trying to bait Catra now. "You wanna win it fair and square."

What Catra wanted, she realized with horror, was to kiss that stupid smirk and see if she could still taste the cotton candy-flavored ice cream that Adora had insisted on trying.

"Come on, Catra," Adora teased. "You don't want them to have to print a footnote in the yearbook. 'Catra Driluth, Valedictorian… because she was too scared to have fun.' That would really ruin your street cred."

"Yeah, the mean streets of Bright Moon would really eat me alive after that," Catra drawled, turning her mouth into a flat line so Adora could see how unimpressed she was with this logic.

But Adora wouldn't relent. She kept smiling hopefully at Catra until she felt herself begin to cave under all this attention. She never was very good at saying no to Adora.

Very reluctantly, Catra finally said, "I'm not going there to party. I'm just going to save this plan from tanking."

Adora balled her fist like she was seconds away from pumping it into the air, the same way she did whenever she scored a goal.

She managed to pull herself together to shrug and casually say, "Whatever excuses you tell yourself aren't my business. Can I pick you up?"

No. Nope. Absolutely not.

Adora picking Catra up alone and taking her to a party felt a bit too much like some sort of date scenario. Dinner she could excuse as Randor's fault. Knowingly accepting an invitation to attend a party with Adora would be her own damn fault and answer a lot of questions that Catra wasn't trying to ever consider.

Plus, this party was supposed to be when Huntara confessed her feelings or whatever. Adora would decide to give her a chance and then Catra would be left alone. Just there by herself like a loser. Besides, it didn't make sense to accept a ride there knowing that Adora would bail and Catra would be stuck without her bike.

"Nah, you and Glimmer are besties. She'll probably want you there early to set up or something." It felt like a reasonable excuse. "I'll just bike or have Scorpia pick me up."

Adora leaned so close that their shoulders accidentally bumped against each other. "You sure? I bet Glimmer would love to have you come help. And by help, I mean, make fun of every decision she makes and every time she freaks out about something."

Shit, that was a tempting offer. Terrorizing Sparkles would actually make an evening of dealing with her classmates worth it.

Before Catra could walk back her decision though, a gold SUV sped past them and then stopped abruptly. There were no cars behind it

and Catra really hoped that Randor had actually bothered to check before pulling this move. He threw the car into reverse and slowly eased back towards them.

Once they caught up to him, the passenger side window rolled down and he bellowed, "Your chariot awaits, my dears!"

Just like on the ride there, Adora opened Catra's door and slid in behind her so that they were sat together in the back. Randor took off down the highway, rapidly shooting them questions about BP – what they ate, how it was, and mostly annoyingly, if they had talked about 'anything important', which he asked *more than once*. And again, when he convinced Catra that he had just installed this new bike rack on the car totally coincidentally' as they swung back to the school. And once more after he drove Catra and her bike all the way home.

The attention was starting to make Adora all fidgety, though Catra couldn't figure out what big shit they'd have to discuss that Randor would've been interested in. When he pulled into her driveway, Adora dove out of the car, insisting on walking Catra up to her front door.

"I, uh," Adora stuttered in the entryway. She was wringing her hands, glancing down at Catra's.

"Thanks for this," Catra said, her face all warm. "It was decent."

Adora nodded. She looked like she wanted to say something else but she glanced back over her shoulder towards Catra's driveway. Randor was half out the car window again. He had to scramble to climb back inside once they noticed him.

"Get him home please," Catra begged, embarrassed for all three of them.

Adora just nodded and turned to leave. "Goodnight." She got halfway back to the car, falsely thinking she was out of earshot, when Catra

heard her say, "Chill out! You're gonna ruin it, Dad!"

"I can't help it. I'm just so excited you might get back together!"

Catra slammed the door quickly. Her heart was racing and honestly, she kinda hoped the shock might kill her. If it didn't, Huntara was definitely gonna finish her off.

She'd just gone on a date with Adora, she was pretty sure. And she had kinda loved every moment of it, poking around, sharing a meal, catching up. In one evening, she'd just taken the entire objective of this project and kicked it right in the nuts.

Catra was dead fucking meat.

Chapter End Notes

i haven't actually seen more than the first 2 minutes of "first kill" so apologies for stealing its plot and then throwing werewolves in there instead

the next chapter is called "I thought nothing could go wrong" so...yep.

I Thought Nothing Could Go Wrong

Chapter Notes

> happy tuesday!here's another thicc chapter - parties and the past and skinned knees and hot pockets galore!
>
> warning: a little underage drinking. for the most part, everyone is sober but i was once again amused by drunk glimbow.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You're going to a party?" Scorpia asked. Even through the phone, Catra could imagine the way she was probably wrinkling her white eyebrows and turning up her nose. "You? Catra? My best friend, Catra?"

Catra wasn't about to explain this for a 5th time so she just ignored Scorpia. "Entrapta, do you have anything helpful to add?"

"The weather forecast says it'll be 50 degrees on Saturday at 11pm," she informed them. "You should wear your red flannel and your black hooded sweatshirt."

Both of those items actually belonged to Adora, leftovers from their friendship that she never asked for back. Did Entrapta know that? Catra wouldn't put it past her honestly.

"I'm just confused," Scorpia said next. "I mean—lunch was one thing. Then you hung out with her outside school-"

"I'm not going to the party to see Adora," Catra jumped in to clarify. "I'm going"…

She had to pause there. The excuse she gave Adora was enough but there was no way Entrapta would believe that Catra was trying to save their entire graduating class from expulsion. Catra would've

asked Entrapta to hack the grading system and give Bow straight Fs to guarantee her road to valedictorian *if* she thought she could get away with it. If Catra suddenly pretended to be interested in academic fairness, Entrapta would think she'd lost her mind.

"Because I want to try it once before graduation," Catra said. "Being, uh, normal and young and carefree and shit."

The answer – or really , the honesty in it – surprised her . But yeah, one night of feeling welcomed wouldn't be terrible. Or maybe she could at least just feel like a regular teenager , like everyone else there. Someone who didn't have to worry about money and college tuition and taking care of herself when she aged out of the foster system, who could just focus on drinking and fun and whatever the fuck happened at these parties.

The line was quiet for a long while after that. So quiet that when Catra swallowed, she was sure both of her friends could hear it. She tried to find the place where she'd last stopped in the personal statement she was writing before she made the dumb mistake of texting these two about going to the party and immediately got a group call from them. Offering to knock out a few early admissions essays for her classmates seemed like quick money , but all that idiot Starla could come up with to talk about was her bird. How the fuck was Catra supposed to write 2,500 words about an *owl*?

"Oh, buddy ," Scorpia said gently . "I'm sorry . I didn't mean to make fun of you. That's" Scorpia had to pause as she snif fled, "I think that's great. Of course I'll support you."

"I wasn't aware that you felt left out of these experiences," Entrapta began tentatively, sounding uncharacteristically lost. "I don't, personally. But I'd be more than happy to accompany you-"

"No, that' s fine," Catra interrupted again. Just because Glimmer and Adora and Bow had her suddenly feeling like a big enough idiot to try and be included, didn't mean that Entrapta needed to come out of her bubble for this nonsense. "I'll be fine on my own."

“Oh, no, I’m definitely going,” Scorpia told them. “W ouldn’t miss it for anything. Especially now that you’re going, Wildcat. Oooh! Do you want to carpool? My mom was gonna give me a ride. We’ll swing by and pick you up.”

Well, that was at least one problem solved. Linda was the kind of responsible but ‘cool’ parent who always told Scorpia she would pick her up at any time anywhere just to make sure she was safe. She'd made the same offer to Catra dozens of times too, but the only people who talked more than Scorpia were her mothers. As much as Catra wasn’t looking forward to being trapped in a Subaru with them, it was better than the long walk back to her house after Adora bailed on her to make out with Huntara.

“W orks for me,” Catra said. “My backup plan was to hitchhike so it’ll be nice not to risk my life just to attend some stupid party .”

Entrapta chimed back in with, “Hmmm. Actually , I think I’ll attend too. This will be a good opportunity to observe everyone in a new environment. I wonder how the social hierarchy will shift after this event.”

Scorpia squealed in joy . “What are you going to wear? Should we all coordinate? I have so many ideas.”

Before Catra could think of a way out of that, Entrapta replied, “I hear Emily’s alarm,” referring to her weird supercharged roomba that she had hacked to do just about everything for her . “Better go. Bye.”

After the uh, date-like… *situation* that had happened with Adora, Catra spent the next couple days dodging Huntara, because getting squashed like a fucking bug wasn’t really a part of the high school experience that Catra was looking for. She did her best to keep that trip to the Burger Palace on the low, even going so far as to swear Scorpia to secrecy.

Adora must have immediately blabbed to Glimmer though, who wouldn't stop trying to pry Catra's take out of her. Shit, she was worse than Randor, begging to know if she and Adora had any "news" they wanted to share with everyone.

Once DT popped up after school on Thursday, sniffing around for gossip, Catra knew it was over. When Huntara sent Girl Me with a message summoning Catra to the football field shortly before practice started, she shot off a quick text telling Entrapta that if she mysteriously disappeared, it was Entrapta's job to take care of Razz.

Catra arrived, both hands in her pockets so Huntara wouldn't be able to tell that her claws were already out. As the big oaf posed on the field for her teammates, pretending to be stretching her throwing arm, Catra sized her up quietly. A defensive plan was forming quickly—Catra would just wait here, pretending to lower her guard so she could catch Huntara by surprise. She probably had one chance to get in a good scratch, hope to stun Huntara, and then hide until Huntara left town for college. Godsdamnit. What Catra wouldn't give for a gym sock and a roll of quarters right now.

"What are you doing here?" Catra suddenly heard next to her.

She was quite proud of herself for only jumping about half a foot in the air because of the shock. Catra had been so focused on looking as if she wasn't paying attention to her surroundings that she actually forgot to pay attention to her surroundings.

Turning to her left, she found Adora standing there in her practice uniform, stick in her hand and everything. Catra looked away quickly, eyes still projecting that she was just totally casually hanging out near the endzone as a normal thing.

"What are *you* doing here?" Catra asked instead of answering. Adora was probably just finding some excuse to come by and check Huntara out, deeply unaware that she was about to be a key witness in Catra's downfall.

"Coach sent me over to borrow an extra water cooler ," Adora replied. "But then I saw you standing here. What are you up to? Thinking about trying out?" she jked.

"I'm getting into sports gambling," Catra lied. She lazily leaned back against the fence behind her, suddenly feeling calm enough to forget about her impending showdown with a couple of melon-sized purple fists. "Think I'd make a pretty good bookie."

Adora laughed. "Cant imagine youll get too many clients who are that invested in Bright Moon's football team. They havent had a winning season in 6 years."

"That' s the genius of this plan. Ill get a couple ringers, cut 'em in on the action, throw games in my favor."

"Y ou've watched too many mob movies," Adora told her . "Again, thisll only work if the team actually had the ability to *win* anything. You'd be better of f trying this scam with the hockey team. We're def making the playoffs again."

Catra didnt want to chance a look at her again but Adora' s voice gave away that she was probably smirking, all proud of herself for being able to hit a ball and run simultaneously. Like that was supposed to be impressive.

It wasnt, for the record. Though, on a few occasions, Adora had had to body check another player and had practically knocked some girls into next week. Catra could always appreciate that.

"W ell, I wouldnt risk asking you to take a dive," Catra replied.

"Why not?" Adora poked her in the calf with her hockey stick. "Dont want to damage my perfect record?"

"I jst dont think you'd be able to hack it," Catra tossed back.

"I'm good under pressure."

"You're a bad liar and a worse actress."

Adora gave a sudden nervous laugh that had Catra's fur standing on end. She turned to look at Adora but unfortunately caught Huntara staring at them out of the corner of her eye.

Sounding way more anxious than necessary, Adora quickly said, "Better go grab that cooler! See you tomorrow night!"

She rushed off without another word. She *did not* head towards the row of water coolers lined up next to the football team but instead jogged towards the hockey field on the other side of the gym. That was bizarre.

Huntara marched up to Catra as soon as she was alone. Internally, Catra braced herself to be punched. She was *sure* that Huntara was starting to get suspicious about her motives.

It was a bit confusing when Huntara asked, "Did you talk to Adora about me?"

"No?" Catra answered. What the fuck could she possibly say about Huntara? She was fucking up her chances with Adora all on her own – she didn't need Catra's help there. "Is that why you dragged me here?"

Huntara glanced self-consciously over her shoulder, back towards her teammates. "I'm getting ready for tomorrow night. I lost the lists you gave me."

"Are you fuck-" Catra started but shut up when Huntara's eyes began to scream 'I will crush you.' So Catra sighed and tried to recite what she'd already shared over and over again. "Horses. Music. Singing and/or dancing competitions. Compliments. Be nice. *Uh-boring* sports talk. Just ask her some fucking questions."

It wasn't that hard! Catra had barely spent more than a week with Adora lately and she already had her agreeing to start a gambling

scheme!W ell, as a þke, obviously .

"Dude, Iḿ doing the best I can,"Huntara argued.

"Really?!"Catra shot back. "Cause your best is *shit!* Adora should be þmping at the chance to get with you."As soon as the words were out of her mouth, Catra felt her tail twitch erratically behind her. Huntara was literally everything Catra wasnt. Everything Adora should want. "Y ouŕe popular and youv̀e got stupid muscles and youŕe starting qarterbac-"

"What' s up your ass about it anyway?"Huntara asked, which was fair. Even Catra could hear that her voice was weirdly bitter about this whole thing.

"Y ou!"Catra answered qickly . "This is what youŕe paying me for and you dont even listen to what Iḿ telling you. Here' s how you have to act to get Adora to like you-"

"All I asked for was shit to talk to her about. Iḿ not acting like a fake fuck þst to hook up with her ."

"Then this is doomed!"

"Why do you care?"Huntara asked, narrowing her eyes.

"I dont!"

Catra *didnt.* It was þst another þb. Huntara was such an ungrateful asshole. She didnt appreciate how Catra was trying so much more than she was even. Shed̀ better fucking appreciate Adora, who definitely deserved a girlfriend who actually *knew* things about her and was interested in more than þst how ćool' she was or whatever bullshit Huntara was attracted to.

"Fine,"Catra conceded. She didnt know what she was so pissed about. It was probably þst the adrenaline from preparing for a fight. With a couple of deep breaths, it started to fade, leaving behind only

the feeling of being drained. Her voice was much quieter when she added, "Just be yourself. Use my conversation starters if you want. But it should be fine. It's a party – just get in some good facetime and see what happens."

Huntara nodded and, for once, Catra felt like she was actually listening. That was good, Catra told herself. Adora made sense with someone like Huntara. Sorta. Maybe.

"Uh." Huntara kinda stalled out for a moment. "Thanks," she mumbled.

Before Catra could respond, she jogged off back towards her teammates.

What the hell was one supposed to wear to a party?

Catra had spent all of Saturday helping Razz sort her coins in those little paper rolls, delivering groceries for a couple of the other old biddies that Razz hung out around, and bartering with the bike shop owner for the repair she needed. Apparently, her free labor wasn't enough to completely replace the part with something new but he had a used, only slightly fucked up version that he'd swapped in in exchange for her helping stock inventory over the next couple of weekends.

She'd unfortunately run into Sea Hawk in the grocery store parking lot, while he was suspiciously tying a cart to the back of his own bike. Apparently, since he was the only person with a fake ID that worked, thanks to the mustache that he grew overnight in 9th grade, he was in charge of taking the months' worth of allowances that Glimmer had saved up and securing alcohol for everyone.

Like an idiot, Catra had asked what he planned to wear tonight.

For five fucking minutes, she had ended up having to stand there while he explained how carefully he'd chosen every detail of his outfit

—from his jacket to his shoes to his fucking *neckerchief thing* —how each piece related to his love for Mermista and even where he'd purchased them in case Catra was interested in picking up something similar for herself.

If she'd been less stressed out about the evening, Catra probably would have chased him and his ridiculous cart off. But she didn't exactly have a lot of people to talk to about high school party expectations, not at least any she trusted to not immediately sus out what she was up to and each and every one of her insecurities, so Sea Hawk would just have to do. Turns out, once they got past the importance of his blue jacket and how it was Mermista's third-favorite color and, therefore, very critical to his wardrobe for the night, Sea Hawk went on a long rant about all the activities he was looking forward to at Glimmer's house.

Party games. Dancing. Camaraderie. (He'd shouted that one, which somehow made it sound even more annoying and exhausting than Catra had already thought.) Drama.

So now Catra needed to find something to wear that would: a) compliment whatever resting bitch face she'd probably be sporting for the entire night, surrounded by loud music and louder drunken idiots, deeply aware that she didn't belong there and b) be comfortable enough that she could move around quickly, dodging offers of shots and maybe some stray punches if things really got out of control.

By the time Scorpia had texted to say they were about a minute away, Catra had already changed at least 10 times. She was sure about her favorite black jeans with the rips and the annoying black boots she had to wear to make sure no one stepped on her bare feet (Catra's preference really) while they were stumbling around. The Dreams honked just as Catra pulled a ridiculous black croptop with a mock turtleneck over her head;it was the sort of unwise shirt that she could picture Bow in, protecting your neck while leaving your entire stomach freezing. It didn't even have sleeves for Gods'sake – what the hell was she thinking when she grabbed this from the thrift

store? Worried about being chilly, Catra grabbed the first flannel she found in her pile of clothes and a silver chain to dress it all up with.

Catra rushed out of the door, only to almost run right into Razz. She didnt look to be heading anywhere, just standing right in front of Catra's entryway like she was waiting for something. That damn broom was in her hand once again.

"You should be at bingo already," Catra pointed out.

"Dont tell old ladies what to do," Razz snapped back.

Catra locked her door behind herself.

"Where's your gift?" Razz looked at Catra's hand, which only held the outer layer that she really needed to put on because it was already colder than she'd thought.

With a start, Catra realized she'd grabbed the red flannel after all. Stupid unconscious decision.

"What gift?" she asked. "Runnin' kinda late here."

The broom swung in her direction but Catra jumped out of the way just in time, sliding past Razz.

"You bring a gift to a party!"

"Oh my Gods! This isnt time for an etiquette les-" Catra paused halfway through yelling. "Wait! I didnt tell you where I was going."

"Ha!" Razz laughed smugly. "Like you have secrets from ol' Razz!"

Catra leaned a little closer to look at her, those words sounding creepily familiar. "I swear if you've been DT this whole time, Im moving."

It would be a weird scam but Catra could just imagine them thinking this would be a hilarious long con to slowly drive her out of her mind.

"Dont try to distract me," Razz told her . "Gift!"

Linda honked again so Catra turned to run off. The back of her head met a swift whack.

"Dude, seriously?!" she said over her shoulder .

Razz called out as Catra ran down the stairs, "And no alcohol for you tonight. You need a clear mind."

"Oh, *that's* your excuse for being batty?!"

"A w, she seems nice," Scorpia said, once Catra was in the car . She cheerfully waved a pincer at Razz, who just shook the broom like a menace as they reversed out of the driveway.

Linda was playing the easy listening station, which didnt really matter because Scorpia nervously chatted over the radio the entire drive to Glimmer's house.

"What' s got you anxious?" Catra had to interrupt to ask, since Scorpia clearly wasnt gonna be able to slow down on her own.

"Hmm?" Scorpia replied. Seated behind Linda, Catra could see just the side of Scorpia's face and how she'd sucked both lips in and bit down.

"Nevermind. Not my business."

"No, no, it' s fine." Scorpia blew out a nervous breath. "I'm hoping to talk to Perfuma for a little bit."

Linda gasped loudly. Aside from her jet black hair , she had the same height and build as her daughter so it was a little silly to watch two people who looked like pro wrestlers acting all gooey about a girl.

"It' s not a big deal, mom."

"I know ," Linda argued but her voice sounded all watery . "I'm just really excited for you. First girlfriend!"

"Oh, well, I don't know about that," Scorpia said with a slight wince. "Let' s maybe not jinx it."

It was cute, maybe, how supportive Scorpia' s moms were of her. Not just dating but hockey , school, everything. When Catra first started having to spend time with them, it was brutal, an annoying reminder of the Grays. But now it just felt kinda nice. She was happy for Scorpia.

"You'll be fine," Catra said quietly . "She'd have to be out of her mind not to want to date you."

Scorpia turned her entire body around in her face so she could face Catra. Her eyes were already tearing up. She went to open her mouth, very likely to say something sappy but Catra cut her off.

"Nope. Only party vibes from here on out. There'll be enough people crying later."

Her phone buzzed in her pocket and Catra pulled it out slyly, trying to angle so Scorpia couldn't see. The last thing she needed was Scorpia asking more questions. For someone who had sworn she wasn't helping, Scorpia sure as shit had a lot of opinions about Adora and Huntara and what was best for everyone.

Adora
Excited about tonight?

Catra sighed. At least Adora was starting to warm up to Huntara again. She scrolled up to see what boring small talk they'd been making without her interference.

But all Catra found was a bunch of two-year old messages that she was honestly shocked to realize she'd never deleted. Adora hadn't texted Huntara;she had texted *Catra,* who let herself immediately

get sucked back into their chat history. The car started to feel a lot smaller as Catra thumbed through the old thread.

Adora
So youll be here at 7?

Adora
Catra, youŕe almost late

Catra
Dude, Iḿ literally climbing up the side of your house as we speak
Chill

Adora
Well, stop texting!
Youŕe going to fall!

Catra
Then stop bugging me!
Asdkqwuoa

Adora
There’s not a body in my bushes so I know you didn't fall
You still a block away?

Catra
I actually did fall and now I'm a ghost
Standing right behind you

Adora
Iḿ gonna take a shower

Catra
With a ghost there?
Scandalous

Adora
I locked my window

Have fun hanging out with my mom when you're forced to use the front door


Adora
Hey, the dance is ending and you havent come back
Are you okay?
Im sorry
I shouldn't have done that

Adora
Cat, can you answer?
My dad's here to pick us up

The memory made Catra feel like she was about to break out into a panicked sweat. She quickly jumped back down to the present, ignoring how any mention of her past with Adora made her hands shake as she typed back.

Adora
Excited about tonight?

Catra
New phone who dis

Adora
This is Glimmer
I consicfated Adoras phone
Stop fucking with her and get here NOW bitch
Love you bye


Not that Catra could blame her, but Scorpia pretty much abandoned her as soon as they entered Glimmer's house. Whatever this fancy front room was, the comfy-looking leather furniture had been pushed all into one corner and the place was packed with kids. Catra definitely wasnt going into there. Scorpia, though, had spotted

Perfuma and decided to dive right in. She gave some unnecessary apologies before she took off.

Walking further into the house, Catra hit the dining room, where the table was covered in half-eaten bags of chips and some dips that looked absolutely disgusting. She could see the kitchen right off to the side of it and a den further up ahead.

The kitchen seemed like a good first stop so she headed that way. It too was full of too many people, including kids even lower than their grade and a handful of folks who she was *sure* had graduated the previous couple of years. People were grabbing beers from the fridge or mixing drinks on the counter, most of them already a little tipsy.

Weaver was always more of a wine person – *too* much of a wine person frankly – and Catra still had no idea where Razz hid her booze. So Catra had only had beers 2 or 3 times, usually smuggled from the Grays' fridge and drank in Adora's room on a special occasion like New Years'. It seemed like the safer choice tonight. She grabbed something that looked cheap and dark and slipped out of the room before anyone had a chance to say anything to her.

The den was dark with mood lighting, which would be a good place to hide and catch her breath. It was all a bit overwhelming already. The mess of sounds that somehow counted as pop music wasnt helping her calm down any. Being alone for a moment should have given Catra a chance to pull herself together.

Of course, that meant that she immediately heard, "Catra! You're here!" loudly slurred in her general direction.

A couple of nearby people turned to look at her in surprise. Those people then were basically thrown out of the way by Glimmer and Bow, who were stumbling arm-in-arm up to Catra.

"Omg, hi!" Glimmer screamed, seconds before her sweaty body was collapsing on top of Catra. For balance or something, Bow tossed

himself on the other side and then Catra just had to stand there while the two of them used her as a human support beam.

"This hug is getting kinda creepy , dudes," Catra grunted, struggling to hold them up. She felt the beer in her hand dangling and was genuinely worried it was about to fall until some unseen person pulled it away from her.

"We're just so happy to see you," Bow tried to whisper in her ear , but instead ended up basically yelling over the music. "Adora was getting worried."

"I was not," Adora argued.

Catra shifted so her head was peeking out of this drunken pile of dumbasses.

Adora was standing behind them, arms crossed as Catra's beer bottle hung between two fingers on her right hand. She'd left her ponytail down tonight and the silly holiday lights Glimmer had decorated with twinkled on Adora's blonde hair as her bangs fell gently onto her eyes. Her style was completely different – she looked like she'd robbed Catra and not the other way around in her black tights, dark gray Queen tank top, and dark red hoodie tied around her waist.

"Shut up," Glimmer mumbled into Catra's shoulder. "She totally was. We had to hide her phone to keep her from checking it every 3 seconds."

"Okay , I'm dropping you both now ," Catra warned. Neither of them moved an inch.

"Come on, guys," Adora said. "Remember , you were on your way to see if the jello shots had set."

Glimmer whipped her head up so quickly that Catra had to dodge to avoid getting her nose broken accidentally.

"Yes! Jello shot time!" she whooped, before grabbing Bow's arm and prying him away and into the kitchen.

Adora remained behind, just standing there and staring at Catra. Her energy was all nervous as she looked Catra over and shifted slightly back and forth on her feet, but Adora tried valiantly to hide it well. If Catra hadn't known her better, Adora would've looked like the perfect picture of cool.

"Thanks for coming," she said.

"I can't believe you're encouraging them to drink more," Catra replied.

"Oh, no. *I* made the jello shots while they were decorating. I lied and told them I put booze in them but I didn't. Knew they wouldn't be able to taste the difference by this point."

"What a wholesome con."

Adora made a face at Catra's sarcastic tone. As revenge or something, she lifted Catra's beer up to her lips and took a sip.

"Thief," Catra accused dryly. It wasn't very mean since she couldn't take her eyes off of Adora's mouth long enough to really care about losing her drink.

The bottle was still lowering, just inches from Adora's lips when Catra felt something tug on the bottom of her shirt. Reluctantly, she had to look away from Adora and glance down to make sure she hadn't accidentally stumbled forward and walked right into a table. What she caught sight of, though, was Adora's hand pulling at the hem of the flannel Catra was wearing.

"Takes one to know one," Adora teased. "I've been wondering where my favorite shirt disappeared to."

It was hard to know how long her hand was lingering there. All Catra could really take in was how her own breathing seemed to stop. How she could almost feel the heat of Adora's hand against her fur. How NSYNC was singing "T earing Up My Heart" way too loudly over the speakers.

Adora tugged on the shirt again, probably a signal that Catra had been zoning out for too long and that her attention was needed back on Etheria.

Her feet had a mind of their own tonight apparently. When Adora pulled, Catra's feet just let themselves be dragged along. Catra glanced up quickly , still stunned and confused. Adora's eyes looked wild with surprise, which was definitely mutual since Catra didn't know what the hell was going on either.

She managed to get a hold of herself about half a second before she slammed right into Adora. Instead, Catra's legs decided to remember they were capable of being controlled and came to a sudden stop a couple inches from Adora. They were way in each other's space, entirely too close for..., acquaintances or whatever they were.

The shock on Adora's face melted into a sly smile. Catra realized, for the first time, that she'd missed Adora' s confident grins. Without being around her often, especially when she was on the field, Catra hadn't had many opportunities to catch a glimpse of it the last couple years.

"You've only had, like, a sip of this," Adora said with a smirk, gently tilting the bottle back and forth where it was still lifted in the air. "Falling over already? Lightweight."

Catra attempted a glare but her insides were fucking jelly . All of her muscles had just thrown in the towel and it seemed like her body just wanted to keep her upright to protect the last shred of her dignity.

Down, to the right of her bellybutton, she felt the pressure of Adora's hand still there. Years of holding hands, teaching each other how to

take a punch, soothing scraped knees flooded back into Catra's brain. She had to reach out and grab the beer out of Adora's hand to ground herself.

It was cold at least, a nice contrast from how warm the room felt. Catra tossed back a big swig, enjoying how it was a little bitter and a little roasty. It made her feel a little tough for some irrational reason. Adora's smile was growing but her eyes were doing something Catra had never noticed before, staring at her so intently.

Then Catra remembered that Adora's mouth had just been on the same bottle. And she fucking *choked.*

Literally, Catra began *hacking uncontrollably* as ice cold beer flew up her nose. It burned her eyes as she gasped for breath. Through her tears, she could just barely make out Adora' s face, full of worry. Strong hands went to take the bottle while trying to pat Catra on the back.

"Wildcat! Are you dying? Do you need the heimlich?"

Catra turned to find Scorpia running out of the kitchen and in her direction. She had no choice but to duck into Adora's arms to avoid being crushed by Scorpia, who often forgot her own strength.

"No!" Catra called out hoarsely . She appreciated the quick thinking but bruised ribs would just make the situation worse. She could already feel a bunch of people around them staring at her.

Dutifully, Adora hugged Catra close. Her awkward panicked back pats had turned into a gentle massage.

"You okay?" Adora whispered. She had to duck her head down to look into Catra's eyes. As soon as Catra nodded, throat still too sore to speak, Adora stood up straight. Her hold felt weirdly protective. "She's alright, Scorpia. I think it just went down the wrong pipe. No worries!"

“Oh my gosh, that's great!” Scorpia said, sounding relieved. “I mean, that's terrible. But it's good that Catra's okay. And you two areuh.., yepno need for me here. Better go see if I can catch up to Perfuma. Okaybyesorry.” Her footsteps retreated loudly .

Adora laughed a little. Catra could just barely feel it rumbling where her head had found itself tucked against Adora’s collarbone.

“Let's go outside and get some air ,” Adora suggested. She didn't wait for an answer. She just kept one arm around Catra's back and guided them to the door.

By this point, Catra felt like she must be bright red from choking and embarrassment and how everyone had just seen her basically be carried out by Adora.

Ugh, it was all just unbearably gay .

Once the cool air hit them, Catra untwined herself to walk over to the darkest corner she could find on Glimmer's huge deck. There was a long table with a big ugly yellow umbrella where a handful of kids were smoking. A few were shooting the shit out in the yard, trying and failing not to be loud and attract the neighbors’ attention to the house full of drunk and rowdy teenagers.

There was a small corner where the porch light didn't reach. It felt like a good place to disappear for a while. Catra leaned against the side of the house and rested her elbow on the wood railing. Adora followed, stopping so that she was facing Catra and leaned onto the rail as well.

“Did you think Scorpia was gonna tackle you?” Adora asked. She began to laugh. “One time, we saw a spider in the locker room and she picked me up and threw me across the room to save me.”

Catra tried to laugh along but it came out sounding hollow.

She felt exposed. Out of her element. The crowd was making her anxious enough and Adora's sweet and annoying attention was just making it worse. It didn't help that Huntara might appear at any moment, the possibility of her presence looming over this whole night and filling Catra was a creeping sense of dread. The clock was ticking;Catra had barely just gotten here and she already felt like she was running out of time with Adora.

Thank the gods she hadn't actually had anything to drink. Catra was already fighting two very opposing urges to both tell Adora everything –the dance, their fight, this stupid thing with Huntara – and to also run away with her secrets and hide forever.

"Hey ,"Adora whispered. She let her foot tap against Catra's. "What are you thinking about so hard?"

I miss you,' Catra wanted to tell her . It was idiotic but somehow, the more she spent time with Adora, the more Catra missed being around her.

Instead, the only thing she trusted herself to say was, "Are you taking the practice tests?"

Adora looked completely caught off guard. "What?"

"The practice tests. The other day I was." Catra stopped to think of a lie but the truth sounded as ridiculous, "I dont know , thinking about how you might be struggling right now with school and admission exams and shit. Remember to do all the practice tests for your math work. SATs too. The repetition always used to-"

"Help me remember stuf f and not panic,"Adora finished for her , nodding. Her face was some mix of sad and impressed that gave Catra a stomachache. "I'm a total idiot. I completely forgot about that."

"W ell, do it."Catra lowered her eyes to the dark wood deck, trying to peer between the slats for no damn reason. "Or dont. It' s not any of

my business.”

After tonight, they'd probably never speak again. The least she could do was help Adora out a little. Increase her chances of getting into a good school. Help take some of the pressure off her shoulders.

Adora's foot tapped her again. “I think about you too,” she whispered. “A lot actually .”

The weight of that statement felt too heavy. There was too much in those words. Too many crossed wires. Too much time invested and then wasted.

“Catra?” Adora whispered softly .

Catra wasn't sure what she was going to say to that. What she was supposed to say to that. She swallowed down the knot of emotions that had formed in her throat and decided just to fucking go for it. Adora was being honest. Catra owed her the same.

Her mouth was barely open when Huntara stomped out onto the deck. Without communicating anything out loud, Adora and Catra took one look at each other and both quickly jumped a couple feet apart. Suddenly, the deck became super interesting as Catra tried to focus on anything except Adora and Huntara. She didn't look over to question why Adora was acting sus cause she was pretty sure the dummy would be wondering about her motives too.

Huntara spotted them quickly . Catra hadn't ever really noticed Huntara in anything except her uniform or letterman. It was almost shocking to see her dressed for a fun night, tall leather boots, tight purple shorts that looked like spandex and showed off thighs that could crush a cinder block, and a purple and gold men's suit vest that she left open so everyone could see her red sports bra and hard as granite abs.

Catra was pretty sure she'd done enough visual research on the deck that she'd be able to rig it so that Huntara would fall through

and she and Adora would be left alone.

Even *Adora* didn't seem happy to see Huntara. But this energy felt weirder than the interactions Catra had spied on before. From what Catra could see from the corner of her eye, Adora looked like she'd been caught. It was the way she grit her teeth, wrinkled her nose, and pulled her shoulders up;Catra had witnessed this many many times, whenever Marlena caught on to one of their schemes.

"There you are, Blond- uh, Adora,"Huntara greeted. She seemed nervous and didn't bother acknowledging that Catra was standing right there too. "I've been looking all over for you."

Adora laughed awkwardly, like someone who just saw their grandparents making out and planned on immediately giving themselves a concussion to fix that problem. "That's fun!Cool. W ell, I've been all over."

Adora waved her arms around to demonstrate this. She must have forgotten the beer bottle was still in her hand cause it flew right out, floating up in the air, and then turning improbably upside down. It continued its trajectory , which of course was to head towards Catra. As gravity caught up to it, dark beer began to spew from the bottle in a long stream. Catra felt it on her shoulder first then through her shirt and onto her pants and shoes.

She didn't really know what to do there besides to laugh and surrender to a full meltdown.

"A w, crap!"Adora yelled, looking her over . The damage wasnt terrible but Catra wasnt looking forward to smelling like stale beer all night. "I'm so sorry!I know where the towels are. I'll grab you some."

Adora moved to run off but Catra grabbed her arm. "It's fine. I just gotta find a bathroom."There was no need for Adora to ditch Huntara and the beginning of their love story. Not for her embarrassing ex-best friend who didnt even belong there.

"I'll take you," Adora offered quickly.

"It's fine," Catra repeated. "Don't worry about me, Adora." Her chariot was about to turn back into a pumpkin or something. Time to make a quick exit. She dashed off, not even looking back to see how things were about to go.

The house felt even warmer and more lonely when she re-entered. She waded through the sea of people dancing in the den, seeing Sea Hawk try to talk to Mermista, who looked like she couldn't be less concerned about his existence. Bow and Glimmer were still in the kitchen, tongues shoved into tiny plastic cups of jello. Trying to get either of them to help seemed like it would just draw more attention, so Catra carried on with her exploration of the house.

Not immediately seeing a bathroom on the first floor, she broke what was clearly some unspoken rule for people to not go upstairs to the quiet, empty 2nd floor. She slipped into the hallway bathroom up there without bothering to turn on any lights on the landing.

She'd just shut the door when there was a quiet knock.

"I said it was fine, Adora," Catra groaned out.

Scorpia's voice floated through the door. "Afraid it's just me, buddy."

Catra grabbed a white towel hanging on the rack with one hand and turned the knob with the other. Scorpia was smiling shyly like she knew she'd intruded.

"Just *us,* I mean," she clarified.

Entrapta pushed past Scorpia and walked in, sitting on the edge of the tub as if this was normal.

"You're both tanking," she announced.

Scorpia looked around the dark empty hall and scrambled inside to lock the door behind them. Catra set about drying herself off. It was

hard to do with Scorpia grabbing another nearby towel and immediately trying to help, tossing it over Catra's head so she could barely see.

"Have you been here the whole time?" Catra asked in Entrapta's direction. If Entrapta thought they were tanking before, Catra was sure she'd have even worse luck now that Scorpia was thoroughly fucking up her hair with her vigorous drying technique.

"I showed up shortly before you both, yes. Did you know you almost kissed Adora?"

"I did not!" Catra hissed.

Scorpia's pincers froze for just a second before returning to their work.

"On two separate occasions you appeared as if you were moments away from kissing," Entrapta continued. "You didn't seem very aware of it as it was happening. Is that common for you? Entering a fugue state when you're around your romantic interest?"

"What's a fugue state?" Scorpia asked.

Catra decided to distract Entrapta by asking, "How'd Scorp tank it?"

"Unlike you, she seems to be *hyper aware* of her surroundings, body, and all of her decisions."

Catra became hyper aware of Scorpia's decisions when her pincers began drying her mane even more vigorously.

"Okay! Got it covered, Scorp!" she had to yell before jumping back. A quick look in the mirror confirmed that all of her hair now looked like she'd gotten into a fight with a small but vicious cyclone. Catra shoved her claws into it, trying to tame it back down. "What's going on with you and Perfuma?"

Scorpia kept the towel in her pincers, nervously twisting it around. "I dont know! She' s so nice whenever we talk and then when I think about telling her I like her or anything, I just-" She waved the towel around hopelessly. "I dont know what to say and I get all weird and I can hear myself talking and Im like, 'oh my Gods, shut up, Scorpia' but I just keep going and-"

"Dude, take a fucking breath," Catra ordered. Her hair was still a mess but she pulled the towel away from Scorpia to both protect it and to clean up her clothes.

Scorpia was turning about as purple as Entrapta's hair. But she did as instructed and visibly took a huge gulp of air before letting it out loudly.

"Thanks, Wildcat." She trudged over to sit on the closed toilet seat. "What am I supposed to do? I dont want to mess this up."

Catra looked to Entrapta, since she seemed to have all the answers. For once, Entrapta just shrugged. Fair . No one in this large, absurdly fuschia bathroom was an expert in this area.

"Just fucking go for it," Catra tried. "No spiraling. No bullshit. Just go back down there and say it straight to her face. If you fuck it up, she's probably too stoned to notice anyway."

"That' s not helpful," Entrapta felt the need to point out.

"Fine," Catra sighed. "You're a fucking catch. You're sweet and strong enough to kill anyone who annoys her."

"Are these your only requirements for a relationship?" Entrapta asked.

"If you didnt have shit to say 2 minutes ago, shut it!" Entrapta zipped her lips and Catra turned back to Scorpia. "She clearly likes you, you idiot. I dont know why the hell she hasnt made a fucking move

herself but someone's gotta be bold and do something. So just go for it. Dont overthink it. Trust me, she'd be lucky to have you."

As Catra feared, Scorpia began crying as if she'd just heard her own eulogy.

"Please stop doing that," Catra begged but Scorpia just bawled louder.

One of Entrapta's pigtails reached over and patted Scorpia on the head. "There there," she said in the stiffest voice Catra had ever heard.

"I just," Scorpia descended into blubbering again. "You too, buddy. Anyone would be lucky to have you. You should tell Adora how you've always felt about her."

As if the towel hadn't been through enough tonight, Catra heard her claws tear right through it as she paused wiping her boots off. She froze where she'd half bent over at the waist. The walls suddenly felt as if they were closing in on her.

Wha. How. Just. Scorpia was so wrong! Just. So wrong!

"That sentence didn't quite make sense," Entrapta said, alerting Catra that once again any thoughts of Adora caused her brain to disconnect itself from her mouth.

Scorpia dried her eyes enough to come over and help Catra stand up. The smile on her face was achingly gentle and Catra fucking hated it.

She used their close positions to shove a claw right up near Scorpia's nose. "Look! 1. Many years ago, something happened between us but Adora made it *very clear* that she wasn't interested." '*Painfully clear*,' one might even say. "2. Anything I may have felt is *very* in the past."

Scorpia's pincer carefully lowered Catra's accusatory hand. "See, the problem, buddy, is that the second point is so untrue that it makes me question the first point too."

Catra felt her fingers twitch. "What the-"

"You never got over her," Scorpia told her. Her eyes were soft, her voice tender. Two big pincers fell on Catra's shoulders slowly, light as a feather. "And she never got over you. I don't think she even tried. It's pretty obvious to just about everyone. Except the two of you."

"That is accurate," Entrapta agreed.

Catra must have made some terrible face because Scorpia rushed to say, "And that's okay. Move at your own pace. Do whatever you want, no pressure. I'm just saying – it wouldn't be terrible if you took your own advice. Be bold and go for it."

Current Catra hated Catra from 3 minutes ago for ever opening her big fucking mouth. Most of all though, she hated Catra from 12 years ago for falling so godsdamn head over heels in love with the dork seated next to her in 1st grade just because Adora had the fucking nerve to tell Catra that she was cool and they should be best friends. Even at 6 years old, Catra had to fight the urge to say let's run away together instead. Really, she never stood a chance.

It hit her like a sledge hammer – this secret that Catra had thought she kept tightly hidden, even from herself sometimes, was supposedly just common knowledge. She had loved Adora – *did* still love Adora, no matter how much it hurt to never feel it reciprocated – so thoroughly, so inescapably that at some point it had stopped being a whisper that only Catra heard and was now just a loud blaring siren that apparently everyone could hear.

Entrapta removed a ponytail holder from the pocket of her overalls and handed it over. Catra, still half-dazed, just took it.

"Your hair is unrecoverable," she explained. "You should probably just put it up for your confession to Adora."

That only managed to slightly jolt Catra back to life. "I am *not-!*"

Scorpia cut off Catra's web of lies by taking the ponytail holder and sweeping all of her hair up into it. Catra could just barely see herself in the mirror out of the corner of her eye – pieces were half hanging out and the whole thing looked like they'd teased it to death.

Well.

This would just have to do.

Halfway between the bathroom and the backdoor, Catra realized that she'd lost her damn mind. 15 minutes into the party and she'd already been convinced to make a big stupid announcement of her feelings. What the fuck.

She skidded to an immediate stop only to have Entrapta and Scorpia, hot on her heels, slam right into her.

"Careful!" Bow slurred from somewhere in the kitchen. There were too many bodies trying to get at the liquor for her to be able to see him.

Finally coming to her senses, Catra tried to turn back around and leave. Out of nowhere, Entrapta was suddenly on her left, a long purple pigtail wrapping around Catra's right shoulder for support.

"This is dumb," Catra tried to whisper. "I'm gonna be the second person tonight to hit on her. That's tacky!"

"Scorpia, Perfuma's on the dancefloor," Entrapta informed them. "Let's move out."

Ignoring Catra, Entrapta dragged the both of them back into Glimmer's den. It was somehow more crowded than before. Where the hell were these people coming from?

Perfuma's tall figure stood out amongst the bodies. Catra shot a glance at Scopia, who looked like she'd just seen an angel or something descend to Etheria. It was actually pretty amazing that Catra had never noticed how into Perfuma her best friend was. Maybe she was so busy trying to ignore any feelings like they were contagious, that she'd just managed to overlook this giant glaring crush right in front of her eyes.

With a sigh, she turned to Scorpia. "Go get-"

In a damn flash, Scorpia took off running in the opposite direction. It happened so quickly that Catra was sure she'd imagined that Scorpia had ever even been there.

"Thanking," Entrapta said again as they watched Scorpia push people to the side in her hurry to rush further into the house. "I'll go find her."

That just left Catra alone. Truth be told, Scorpia had put up such an embarrassing display that Catra felt a lot better about herself. Huntara had been striking out with Adora for weeks. Scorpia would literally rather hide than pony up. Most of the school thought those two idiots were so intimidating. Catra, who had always suspected that she was better than everyone else, could probably actually pull this off. Fuck them (except, not really Scorpia who was definitely making the wiser decision by disappearing). Now she was just doing this out of spite, which was probably not the mindset to tell someone you love them.

Regardless, she took a deep breath and headed out towards the backyard once again.

It didn't matter that Huntara had decided tonight was her time to shine. It was Adora's decision to make. Huntara or Catra. Or the more reasonable option to run away from both of them once Catra

explained everything: her feelings, her involvement in this dumb scam. If everything was out in the open, then Adora could choose what or who she wanted on her own. Catra owed her that at least.

She pushed all her insecurities and her anger and her fucking *'why cant things just be normal for once'* thoughts to the side along with the backdoor. The same idiots from earlier were now practically passed out in their chairs. Catra was too anxious to even laugh at them, heads basically lolled over to the side.

Her eyes searched quickly for Adora and landed on her and Huntara, still locked in the same spot Catra had left them in. They'd switched positions, though – Adora was backed up against the side of the house, Huntara caging Adora in with her bulk.

Huntara was smiling awkwardly, droning on about some nonsense. Adora nodded along and seemed as bored as ever. Perfect. Catra could just swoop in and save her and everything would be fine. That would already put Catra ahead. Look, I got you out of the world's dullest fucking conversation ever. Want to make out and also please be my girlfriend forever.'

she'd figure out the best way to phrase it on the way over.

Catra took another step closer, for a brief foolish second completely sure she was doing the right thing for once.

And then Huntara leaned in.

Catra watched as Huntara's chapped-looking lips met Adora's perfect ones. Huntara tilted her head to deepen the kiss. Adora's eyes were wide open, her hands still unsure what to do.

It- *fuck*- it looked shockingly similar to Adora's first kiss. *Their* first kiss. That thing that lived in the farthest back corner of Catra's mind, never to be addressed again. That stolen moment under the bleachers sophomore year that happened so abruptly and was ruined before it even had a chance to begin.

It was like someone had just cut Catra out of the photo and pasted a pic of Huntara on top of it. That stung. Seared. Felt like a fucking tire iron to the stomach.

There wasnt a goddamn place in Catra's life that she hadnt been replaced. Bow and Glimmer got her best friend. A fucking *backpack* got her seat. And now Huntara got to finish the kiss that she never did.

Bolting was the only option. Having to stay and watch this – or *worse*, getting caught staring at this trainwreck and looking like a fucking obsessed creep – was something that had to be avoided immediately. Catra took off back into the house, vision blurring so badly that she could barely even make out the faces that she pushed past. Scorpia and Entrapta didnt seem to be nearby so there was nowhere to go but *out.*

She was pretty sure that was DT's voice that called, "What's wrong, Kitten?" as she sped past the front room. There was no time to check. She had to get the fuck out of there before the entire school, and half the town it seemed like, watched her fall apart at the seams over a situation that Catra had absolutely created herself.

Blowing through the front door with no plan, Catra was just about to jump off the front porch and take off at a full clip before someone threw their body onto her back. It had taken all of Catra's energy and resolve just to make it out the door so as soon as the extra weight hit, she crumbled like a tower of matchsticks. Through some divine intervention, Catra managed to cover her face as she went down so she wouldnt have to take the Moons to court to get them to pay for replacing all her teeth. Instead, Catra's knees and chest took the brunt of the fall, air knocked out of her lungs even further when a body landed on top of her.

That just made this all the more of a banger night. Definitely top 10 of Catra's life!Covered in beer , crying like a little bitch, knees probably skinned, gasping for air for the *second time* tonight. It got

even better when the asshole who bodychecked her landed right on top of Catra's back, pinning her down.

Her nose picked up that kind of cheap body spray that a certain mall underwear store pumped into their AC system, fields of fake flowers' with fake fruit'and the very real manufactured scent of bullshit and lies.'It burned into Catra' s sinuses and made her eyes water even more.

"Oh my Gods!"Glimmer screamed into the back of Catra' s head. She braced herself for an apology that she'd have to duck out of. Instead, Glimmer fumbled around on Catra's back until she yelled, "What' s wrong with you?!"

"Me?!"Catra shot back, matching Glimmer 's rage. "People cant leave your fucking house without getting attacked?"

It was a good tackle, Catra was forced to admit. Glimmer was a natural at field hockey, thanks to years of tips from her aunt Casta. She was just too much of a menace to actually be allowed on the field;Catra had been there for her first tryout in 9th grade, when Glimmer got sent home and asked not to ever return after she injured the team captain, a senior twice her size, and nearly cost the team their season.

"DT said you were crying!"It still felt like an accusation, as if DT had seen Catra stealing and not having a meltdown.

With too much grunting and effort, Glimmer managed to roll off of Catra so that she was sitting on the porch. Catra was pretty sure she couldnt stand up without falling in a pile of tears so she just eased her body away from Glimmer until she ended up seated on her ass and could pull herself into a slumped over position, face buried in her sore knees.

"Did you seriously come to my house just to cry?!"Glimmer was beyond tipsy now. At any other point, Catra would have found this

amusing but she kinda needed to get home and lose her shit for several hours until it was Monday and she could drop out of school.

The thought of having to see Adora in class made her feel sick all over again.

"Oh, shit," Glimmer whispered. "You're, like, actually upset." Her voice took on an edge of panic. "Oh, no. No no. Please stop. Don't be sad. I'm sorry."

Like a toddler, Glimmer threw her arms around Catra. Her head fell onto Catra's back and again that offensive perfume floated up to her nose. It wasn't so bad now, somehow, knowing that it was Glimmer.

"What's wrong?" It was the most tender Catra had ever heard her.

A month ago, Catra probably would've lost her temper at being treated so delicately. She wasn't a baby. She didn't need Glimmer's pity.

But Glimmer was a bitter old hater like Catra. She'd never done anything just to be fake nice and Catra imagined that a blood alcohol level of 2‰ wasn't about to make her start now. Besides, Glimmer probably wouldn't remember any of this tomorrow.

"I just wanted to feel normal like everyone else for a night." Go to a party. Kiss a pretty girl. *Not* have this night end like every other tragedy in Catra's life.

Glimmer laughed drunkenly, having to pause to hiccup and everything. "No one in our class feels normal, you idiot. We're all on the verge of a panic attack or an identity crisis or a porn addiction at literally any moment. Don't you remember when Scorpia cracked last year during playoffs and midterms? She ripped a water fountain right out of the wall!"

With her face still pressed into her jeans, Catra's laugh came out slightly muffled. "Yeah, I guess. I just feel like no one ever wants me

and all my problems around."

Glimmer leaned her weight even further into Catra's body. "Everyone thinks you're the coolest person on Etheria, you know that, right? You walk around all..." Her voice went gravelly for a second to say, "No one wants to hang out with me," before returning to normal. "And literally everyone around you is dying to be your best friend."

"Oh, ha ha," Catra barked out. "I know you all hate me. The person who matters the most can barely stand me."

Glimmer was silent for a long moment before she shrieked, "Do you mean *Adora*?"

"Yes, her!" Catra hissed. "The person who spent two years pissed off at me and avoiding me."

"I knew you two idiots had different ideas of what had happened but fucking hell! All Adora's ever wanted was to be right next to you. Are you *completely* clueless? I've had 6 shots – how am I making more sense than you right now?"

"You're not! You sound like you're out of your fucking mind."

"Whatever. Get on my level, bro!" Glimmer leaned over further to yell into Catra's ear and somehow managed to almost topple over. "I threw the fucking party of the year and me and Bow and Adora spent most of the day talking about whether or not you'd actually come. When you're not being a bitch and pushing people away, everyone loves you. *Especially* Adora. You're, like, the shit. And *I* should know. Cause I'm also the shit." The idea made a goofy laugh bubble up out of her.

"You're wasted," Catra pointed out.

Glimmer hummed in agreement. "That too, yeah. And I want a fucking hot pocket. You want a hot pocket? Bow should drive us to the store."

No store in Bright Moon was open this late. Also, Bow was fucking wasted too!

For as annoying as they were, Catra preferred them *alive* so she suggested, "Maybe just see what you can find in your freezer. I bet your parents keep it stocked."

"Oh, shit. Good idea! Okay, you stay here. I'm gonna look for a hot pocket for you to pour your tears into."

"And then I'm supposed to eat it?" Catra asked, thoroughly disgusted.

"Salt," was all Glimmer muttered before she stood, leaning too much of her weight on Catra's shoulder, and went back into the house. "BRB!"

Catra waited until she heard the front door close. She was sure Glimmer would get lost or distracted along the way and this would all be like a confusing dream for her in the morning.

With one last look at the house, hoping against hope that a certain *someone else* would come out searching for her, Catra dragged herself to her feet and down the road into darkness.

Chapter End Notes

shout-out to resflower for suggesting that catra would be writing college admission essays to make money too. and for giving glimmer an entire field hockey backstory. honestly, a lifesaver that res.
shout-out to vertical drive for suggesting more catra and huntara competition. i was resting on threats of violence but feelings are important too.

next week? would you believe me if i told you that adora and catra finally talk?

But I Was Wrong

Chapter Notes

> happy teen lesbian angst tuesday!this chapter makes me want fried food from a bowling alley.
>
> thanks for all the amazing and hilarious comments folks have left on this fic. i'm perpetually behind on replying but i read all of them and it brings me lots of joy and motivation. ❤

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora
Hey, where'd you run off to?
I cant find you anywhere

Adora
Things are getting WILD
You still here?

Adora
Hope you got home safe

"Put that phone down and help me," Razz ordered, grunting as she lifted the largest pumpkin Catra had ever seen.

Razz had stormed into her room that morning, unconcerned that Catra had scheduled a super busy Saturday of staring at Adora's texts in bed, rethinking her entire life, and crying in the shower. On repeat. She wasnt ready to message Adora back yet, not wanting to invest anymore time into this doomed semi-friendship, so instead she'd bailed on her responsibilities to wallow for a bit.

Despite Catra's protests, Razz insisted that they needed a pumpkin. Start of the fall or something. It had better be for decorations only

because Catra put up with a lot of bizarre pies, but she was drawing the line at eating sugar-covered squash mush in a crust.

A trip to the grocery store seemed like a decent distraction from replaying Adora and Huntara's kiss over and over on a loop in her head so Catra eventually dragged herself out of bed and chased after her guardian. Razz hadn't even bothered to grab a cart when she entered the store and now she was trying to pick up a gourd that was pretty much the same size she was.

They didn't own a car. How were they supposed to get a 4-foot tall pumpkin home?!

"I'd like to take a house vote on this purchase," Catra told her, already grabbing the opposite side to lift it off the floor.

"It'll feed us til winter!" Razz argued.

"That one's actually just for display only," a weak voice called out. Catra barely glanced over her shoulder to find Guy Dude standing behind her, wearing a little green apron with the store's logo.

"Do you work here?" she asked, kinda forgetting what they were in the middle of. Catra couldn't once remember running into Dude there before.

"Yeah, it's new," he answered. "Just so you know – the manager's got pictures of you and Sea Hawk in the break room. We're supposed to alert her if we see either of you in the parking lot doing anything weird."

Catra was both honored to be known as trouble and offended to be lumped in with Sea Hawk.

"Hey, I'm a paying customer," she shot back.

"The display models are free," Razz chimed in, ruining everything. Her tiny legs suddenly kicked up like she was ready to run off with

the pumpkin.

Unfortunately, she didn't share this plan with Catra first, who stumbled to catch up. They'd only gotten the damn thing a foot or so off the ground once Catra realized that she was losing her grip, but she imagined that was high enough of a drop to smash it or, more likely, have it fall and break her foot. He must have seen the panic in her eyes cause he rushed over, the straws he called arms being surprisingly strong enough to carry most of the weight by himself.

"Scram!" Razz yelled. And then she was taking off in earnest, rushing right out of the store.

Catra had no choice but to follow – she wasn't gonna stay behind and take the heat all on her own. She mumbled an apology to Hale as she left him holding all the weight alone, ignoring the dozen or so nearby shoppers watching them curiously.

She caught up to Razz, already halfway down the block. They were in the main strip of town, families going about their day of window shopping and errands all around them. Razz had eased into a casual stroll, pretending to be all innocent now so she could blend in. Catra did the same, only sorta wondering how long it was before the grocery store put up a picture of Razz too.

"What the hell was that back there?" Catra hissed.

Razz didn't bother turning to address her directly, instead speaking the words up into the air. "We're going to have to start going to the other supermarket. That one has better produce anyway."

"Why didn't we just *buy* a pumpkin like regular people?"

"No one likes pumpkin," Razz replied with a laugh. "Smells like dead broccoli."

"Then why did *any* of that just happen?!"

Razz went for what was probably supposed to be a comforting pat but ended up slapping Catra on the back. "You're too young to be holed up in your room. We needed an adventure."

"And the Great Pumpkin Heist was the best you could come up with?"

"It's Bright Moon!" Razz whined. "There's no action here. Gimme a break."

She turned a corner quickly. Catra wasn't quite sure where they were going. Today had really set a new bar for Razz's level of unpredictability.

They went a couple more minutes in silence, Catra becoming convinced that Razz had maybe invented a new shortcut to their house, when she randomly observed, "You came home from your party early."

Catra felt her ears drop. "Yeah. Was pretty boring."

Razz hummed quietly. "We can't always trust our eyes, dearie."

"Meaning?" Catra sighed.

"Sometimes we need to..investigate. Question. *Listen."*

"I told you 12 times that I didn't want to go outside today and you didn't listen to me once," Catra muttered.

"No moping in my house!"

Catra's phone buzzed in her pocket, signaling that she had another message. And then another. And another. It was probably just Scorpia sending her 4th long slew of panicked thoughts about last night. When she was in her feels, Scorpia usually texted a concerning 6-7 pages minimum.

Catra stumbled slightly when she saw Adora's name. She'd honestly figured Adora would have given up after she didn't receive any responses yesterday.

Adora
Good news: no one got expelled
Better news: doesn't seem like you were there when the cops came last night
Bad news: Glimmer may be grounded until middle age

When Catra looked up from her phone, Razz was doing a terrible job of pretending to be looking in a shop window.

Adora had reached out about something pretty neutral. It was safe to reply to that. Just two classmates discussing current events, nothing serious or personal.

Catra
As social chair, she won't be able to attend her own events I'm hoping
That would be hilarious

The phone buzzed again before she'd even had a chance to turn off the screen.

Adora
She lives!
I was starting to get worried that you'd gotten arrested or something

Catra
The jail hasn't been built that can hold me
You get home okay?

Adora
Yeah
Actually can we talk about that in person?

Catra had never read a more upsetting message via text in her whole life. She couldn't imagine what she and Adora needed to talk about in person from that night. Or, rather, she *could* , she just didn't understand why Adora would want to detail out how she hooked up with Huntara. Even if they were on the verge of almost possibly maybe becoming friends again, they weren't close enough to gossip about *girls.* That seemed like a job for Bow .

Like she'd always been good at, Catra just bowed out. Just really hoped the fuck out of any opportunity to be even within Adora's line of vision for the next several days. It involved learning which classmates she could hide behind to get in and out of classes, which had even driven her as far as sizing up Bow's backpack during physics and wondering if it was possible to slip into without detection.

More than once, Catra had caught a glimpse of Adora's searching eyes, scanning the halls and the cafeteria. She'd pretended to not notice Adora trying to pass her notes in Art. Adora *never* passed notes ~~to~~o paranoid about getting caught and having them read aloud ~~so~~ she must have been desperate to dish to Catra.

It was best just to shut that shit down forever .

Unfortunately, some people were a bit harder to avoid than Adora.

DT, for example, was just eating all this drama up. They'd tried more than once to catch Catra off guard and invite her to spill her guts. Of course, they'd dressed it up as needing a sounding board for their homecoming outfit. But Catra could see through the bullshit ~~D~~T had designed their own clothes for the semi-formal event and forced the theater's costume department to make it for them *weeks* ago. A black lacey low-cut shirt and a pair of shimmery pants with a fucking tulle train. It was gaudy and complicated-looking, neither of which Catra knew anything about so she couldn't be of any help. Even more suspiciously, DT's first topic each time they tried to talk to Catra was to inquire about what had made her "un crying" from Glimmer 's house. (Their words, obviously, cause Catra would never

characterize the *very calm and totally chill way* that she exited the party in those terms.)

Glimmer was harder to dodge. The cretin had a tendency to just *appear* in places, almost like it was magic. Catra didn't actually really think that often about the supernatural but she was sure that Glimmer's whole bloodline was full of some kind of mystical nonsense. This theory was supported by the fact that her mother was 7 feet tall, her aunt coached a winning field hockey team even though their small town statistically shouldn't have enough lesbians to complete a roster, and that Glimmer herself was clearly a bridge troll.

She kept leaping out at Catra, jumping in front of her at random places. It was forcing Catra to stay on her toes, be alert at all times. She knew that if she agreed to do literally anything with Glimmer, Adora would be invited along. So she had to outrun lunch invitations and offers to come pick out homecoming dresses at the mall. Glimmer apparently actually was grounded for forever, which sucked for her, but it meant that Catra only needed to avoid being ambushed by Glimmer and Adora on school grounds.

That was doable. Catra just had to run out the clock on the school year and then Bright Moon was in the rear view. No looking back. Getting her heart broken by Adora twice was plenty. No need to ever return to this town again once Catra escaped it.

There was one last piece to this doomed project that Catra needed to close out. As they had agreed upon, she'd held up her end of the bargain and now Huntara owed her money.

Catra dealt almost exclusively in cash. She didn't *totally* understand how banks worked and there wasn't a single adult around her that could explain how this wasn't a scam in a way that Catra actually believed them. Plus, she was sure the state would attempt to pull some kind of bullshit if they found out she had any money and try to cut off the monthly check Razz got for housing her or something.

There were only two people Catra trusted to get her money from Huntara.

"Huntara has told me Im not allowed within her line of vision at any moment," Entrapta had shared. "She says the questions I ask are too freaky." Catra had to agree with Huntra there unfortunately. "And Scorpia would like me to remind you that, similar to you, she doesnt intend to ever show her face in public again."

Smart. After they both crashed and burned at the party, Catra and Scorpia had made an unspoken pact to hide from their mistakes forever.

With no other options, Catra was forced to come out of the hole that she had disappeared into. Huntara wasnt hard to find, thankfully. Catra caught her in the annex bathroom between classes, trying and failing to pretend she wasnt self-consciously checking herself out again.

This was just a transaction, Catra had to remind herself as she stalked closer. Shed done a job and she deserved payment for her labor.

What this certainly was *not* was an opportunity to have a full meltdown in front of a near-stranger, which is what she was feeling like doing. Every step towards Huntara, Catra felt more and more like running the other direction or trying to concuss herself on the shiny white porcelain sinks that were half-falling from the wall so that she could go to the nurse and be excused for the day.

She desperately didnt want to think about Huntara and Adora dating. Even just having to *look* at Huntara was painful. Having to remember back to Huntara's lips on Adora's made Catra's stomach feel like it was full of live scorpions.

Trying to avoid peering directly at Huntara in any way, Catra got close enough that she was within arm's reach.

"Pay up," she ordered. "It's over." This deal. Her friendship with Adora. All over.

Huntara pulled a folded small stack of cash from her pocket and handed it over without a fight. As soon as it met Catra's palm, she turned to rush out.

"Thanks by the way," Huntara grunted out. She didn't seem happy about this, which was stupid. She'd just gotten her dream girl or whatever. "I know I gave you shit but those tips actually ended up being useful."

"Congrats," Catra huffed. She didn't need this reminder that this was her own fault. That once again Catra had proven to be a very special combination of smart enough to construct her own failure and dumb enough to ignore all warnings and just let it happen. Like a lesbian Icarus.

"Yep. Everything's all good with me and Perfuma now."

Catra swung back around on her heel. Maybe the stress from the past few weeks had been getting to her. Because she was 99% sure that instead of Adora, Huntara had just said, *"Perfuma?"*

Huntara ignored how Catra's voice was so screechy that it hurt her own ears. She merely nodded.

"So," Catra shoved the money in her pocket, leaving her hands free to rub her temples. She could feel a rage headache forming. "What was this all? Just some game to get into girls' pants?!"

Huntara's eyes narrowed in anger but Catra was too busy feeling that pit of scorpions in her tummy turn into a ball of volcanic lava. She'd gotten played. Catra..had gotten *played?* by *Huntara*, of all people?

She'd basically sold Adora out to this wannabe fuckboi and her ugly-ass ponytail that Catra was about to slice right off.

This was *worse* than Adora and Huntara being together. At least that way, Adora would be happy. Instead, she probably felt gross and used. And Catra couldn't help but blame herself.

"You're a scumbag," Catra heard herself say but she wasn't sure which of them she was describing.

Huntara's giant hands balled into fists. "Watch it, Driluth. I'm 18. What'd you think I was gonna *carry* her? Me and Adora hung out. It was okay. Now I'm gonna give Perfuma a shot."

"*Okay*?" Catra repeated. They'd spent weeks trying to get Adora and Huntara to exchange more than two words; it finally happened, and it was just 'okay'?!

"Why are you making a big deal out of this?"

"You wasted my time!"

"No one asked you to play matchmaker," Huntara pointed out. "You *chose* to be extra. That's on you, bro."

This was still unacceptable to Catra. Who the fuck did Huntara think she was, rejecting Adora who was objectively the best person in the world?

Not that Catra had any business having an opinion about that. It wasn't like she'd bothered asking Huntara's intentions before she agreed to help.

"Look," Huntara added. She seemed uncomfortable, like she was almost embarrassed for Catra. "Me and Adora gave it a try. I kissed her at the party and then she looked fucking miserable and ran off." She paused, rubbing at the back of her neck.

Now Catra was actually embarrassed for the both of them. No one knew better than her what it was like to share a disastrous kiss with Adora.

Though all of Catra's sympathy went out the door when Huntara continued on. "Perfuma came over to make sure I was okay and we ended up really hitting it off. We've got a date on Friday actually."

"Can you fucking believe this shit?!" Catra yelled right into Scorpia's face.

After hearing the whole story, Scorpia had decided that they could blow off a couple classes to hide in the thin woods behind the school parking lot. Glimmer had made most of Catra's typical hiding places unsafe, popping up at the auditorium or in the computer lab and everywhere else, so hopefully she wouldn't consider this space at all. No one ever really seemed to notice the tiny piece of forest that lined the back of the school. Catra didn't particularly like nature and she had her fingers crossed that Glimmer was the same. Cause Catra really needed to scream about this clusterfuck she got herself into for maybe the next several hours.

Scorpia and Entrapta were both leant back against thick ancient oak trees, watching as Catra paced back and forth, going from shouting to muttering like she was fully losing it. Catra had all the feelings. So many feelings. A fucking swirling of thoughts and fears and something that felt suspiciously like a ball of shame in her gut. And that was especially annoying because, as Catra had kept reminding her friends…

"I did nothing wrong," she reiterated yet again. "I tried to help an idiot get a date. Out of the kindness of my heart!" Catra had to ignore the noise of disagreement that Scorpia made. "And then she went and fucked it all up!"

"Well, it does seem like Huntara's interest in Adora was genuine," Entrapta pointed out. "Same for her interest in Perfuma. Sorry, Scorpia."

Scorpia sighed sadly. "No worries, buddy. I suppose I shouldn't have expected that someone as great as Perfuma would wait around for

me forever. Starting to really regret not taking a chance and stepping up. But I guess there's not much I can do now. I'd hate to ruin my chance to at least be friends with Perfuma."

Entrapta nodded thoughtfully. "Did you know the average lifespan of a high school romantic relationship is 2 months? Additionally, given the capricious nature of Huntara's feelingsI .give 'em 2 weeks."

Scorpia laughed softly but it missed her usual cheerfulness. Honestly, even the fact that she was being so quiet was concerning. Catra had been late to realize Scorpia's feelings but clearly they ran deeper than she thought.

"I could try using my powers for good?" Catra of fered. "All the shit I did for Huntara, we could figure out how to do that for you and Perfuma. Oh! I could text Perfuma rude shit from Huntara' s phone!"

Scorpia looked less than excited about Catra's brilliant plan. "Oh, thanks? That'suh., really kind of you, Wildcat. I just dont think that's a very good idea. I mean, not talking to people directly is what got us all in this mess in the first place."

"Looks like that' s the only way out of this for you, Catra," Entrapta said.

"Out of what? This is over . It's done. I just have to move on with my life." Catra mimicked wiping her hands clean of this whole situation. One day, this would all be a weird, embarrassing story that she would hopefully forget.

Entrapta peered at Catra more closely. "Are you not going to talk to Adora about this?"

"T alk to Adora?!" Catra shrieked. "Why would I ever talk to Adora again? She's." Catra' s train of thought quickly ran out of track. She and Adora couldnt be friends because Adora would be busy with her new girlfriend.

Except Adora was still single. She'd been making an effort to talk to Catra.

Oh fuck, Catra suddenly realized. Huntara and Adora didn't end up together after the party. So what the hell was Adora so intent on talking to Catra about in person?

"Did you just give up on your own denial?" Entrapta asked.

"I'm not in denial about anything!" Catra argued. Adora was clearly full-in on Huntara. She probably just wanted to get Catra's advice on how to salvage their relationship. And Catra was absolutely *not* meddling in anyone's love life again.

"Your feelings for Adora are painfully obvious," Entrapta replied. "And vice versa. If you want to pursue a relationship with Adora, you have to come clean first. Plus, it was apparent from your text messages that you regret the way your friendship with Adora ended."

"I regret nothing!" Catra insisted, fully aware that she was being a total shit. "Everything ended up just the way it's supposed to be. Adora and me are continuing on our separate paths and I'll be out of Bright Moon in just a few months. All's well that ends well or whatever."

Entrapta opened her mouth to reply but was cut off when Catra suddenly swiveled her whole body to the side. There had been a quiet crunching sound not too far away. Catra was sure no one else could hear it but she could tell it was too loud to be a squirrel or whatever hung out in the woods.

Soon, there was a second leaf-flattening stomp.

"Let's bail!" Catra whispered to her two friends. She nodded in the opposite direction of their new intruder. They'd have to go deeper into the woods and then make a wide circle to get back to school. Hopefully, this was just someone coming out to smoke and not a teacher or anyone.

Scorpia and Entrapta were quick to follow. The three ducked out quickly, dodging low-hanging branches and trying to be quiet until they stumbled back into the parking lot a couple minutes later. Catra didn't see anyone following them so she went to head back into the building.

"I don't see them anywhere!" she heard, coming fast at them from the trees. "I *know* I saw her come in here."

Damnit, Glimmer. Somehow that kid was part-bloodhound. Catra's eyes charted a path straight to the annex door, and as long as she broke into a full sprint, she'd be in the clear.

"Catra!"

She froze hearing Adora's voice. It was strained, frustrated.

With a quick glance over, she caught Adora coming out of the woods, eyes already set on Catra. Adora's jaw was tight and she looked tense all over, ready to snap.

"Hey, Adora," Catra tried but the nervous, unsure way it came out was a surprise to even her.

With a grunt, Glimmer jumped out of the brush. "Ah hah! I told you I saw her sneak off here."

"Glitter, if you were so obsessed with me, you could just admit it instead of stalking me all around school." The joke fell flat, since 50% of everyone gathered was clearly annoyed with Catra, while Scorpia and Entrapta just seemed to feel bad for her.

"Adora has some things she'd like to say to you," Glimmer told her, cherub face threatening violence. "And apparently literally herding a cat is an all-hands-on-deck type of deal."

"Sensitivity training! I'm telling Netossa!" Catra lied.

Glimmer went to launch herself forward, only to be cut off by Scorpia's pincer moving into her path.

"Oh, boy —was that the bell?" Scorpia said with a nervous laugh. "I'd hate to miss chem so we should really." She grabbed Entrapta's hand in one pincer and tossed the other around Glimmer's back, shuffling them both off.

They all looked reluctant to leave, with Glimmer in particular keeping her eyes on Catra until Scorpia dragged them out of sight.

Adora apparently was done wasting time. Catra noticed that she'd barely moved an inch during all the commotion. A still Adora, for someone who was always on the go, was jarring to see. She was practically a statue, face etched into a stoic slight frown.

"You're avoiding me." Even her voice was dif ferent. Somehow full of accusation yet open, tense and resigned maybe? Her whole energy had alarm bells ringing quietly in Catra's head.

"I'm just busy ," Catra shrugged.

"Too busy to reply to my texts or say hey to me in Art?" she asked with a hard edge that made Catra's fur stand on end.

The last thing she wanted was to fight with Adora again. Clearly they were both upset. Nothing good would come from trying to talk right now.

"I gotta head to class. Ill give you a call later tonight, okay?" It was a lie but it would buy her a few hours at least.

Adora wasnt budging but Catra tried to turn and go anyway .

"We have to do this in person," Adora said. "No more hiding."

Catra's feet tugged her slowly a couple more increasingly reluctant steps.

“I know it was you, Catra.”

The words made her stop in her tracks. She struggled to keep her hands steady but her stupid tail was already looping down to hide between her legs.

“What was m-“

Since Catra refused to turn around, Adora jumped right into her path.

“I know it was *you* texting me half the time as Huntara,” Adora said, which should have clarified things but instead made Catra certain that she was hallucinating. “You've been avoiding me for days but I just wanted to talk to you and say we all needed to be honest. I was being a jerk, *you* both were being *huge* jerks, and we all needed to tell the truth. I was gonna give you a chance to explain yourself.”

It was hard to look at Adora’s face, now drawn tight with anger and guilt. Something wasn't quite clicking for Catra though, and she wasn't about to take the blame for Huntara until she knew all the facts.

“What are you talking about?”

“Oh my gods!” Adora shouted, throwing both of her hands up. “I don't know how you did it, but I'm 100% certain it was you, Catra. Just for once in your life, can you apologize?”

That knocked the wind right out of Catra’s chest. Adora wasn't the only one who'd been waiting two years for an apology that was never coming.

When she still refused to speak, Adora added, “I asked Huntara if she actually wanted help changing her style and she looked at me like I'd lost my mind.”

That idiot had *one job.* Catra groaned but Adora was on a roll, arms flailing about to emphasize her point.

"Plus the mac and cheese. Asking about our friendship – Huntara doesn't care why you and I don't talk anymore. My Gods, your *handwriting,* Catra! You didn't think I'd recognize your writing on the candygram? I've still got every birthday card, every note, everything you've ever given me!"

Catra felt her eyes go wide as everything was spelled out for her, like a total dummy.

"Wait." Cause no. Adora Gray wouldn't just... You're saying you *knew* it wasn't Huntara but you kept messaging back?" Catra couldn't keep her face from making what she was sure was the dumbest deer-in-headlights look possible. "You tricked me?!"

She took a step further away from Adora, still astounded. "I can't believe you lied to me."

Adora stomped closer. "Oh my gods! Are you seriously playing the victim here? Just take accountability for your part!" She stopped to mutter to herself, "This is sophomore year all over again."

At the mention of the thing they'd obviously decided to *never* mention, Catra saw red. One claw was up in the air, pointing at Adora before she could stop it. "Hey, *you* rejected me. What do you want me to take accountability for there? Getting my fucking heart broken?"

As soon as those words were out there, Catra immediately wished she could swallow them back into her body.

Adora's stupid finger came up to point back. "Hey, *you* pushed *me* away. *Literally*. I kissed you-"

"*I* kissed *you* for the record," Catra argued, as if *logistics* was the fucking issue here.

"-and then you freaked out and jumped back like you were gonna be sick!"

Now that Adora had mentioned it, Catra once again felt like she was gonna hurl. Between the memory of Adora's face that night, so thoroughly crushed, and Adora right now, hurt by Catra once more, it was all too much.

Catra's voice was a lot quieter when she admitted, "I heard someone coming."

"Why would that matter?"

"Because you weren't out! You couldn't be seen kissing me! You didn't even want to *dance* with me in front of everyone – we had to hide under the bleachers like we were doing something wrong!"

Catra paused and took a breath. This was going even worse than she had imagined, way back when she thought there was a chance that their stupid 10th grade drama might blow over. "Look, we were young and you were still figuring your shit out. I wasn't gonna pressure you or out you. I was... I was trying to protect you that night."

She was trying to protect herself, Catra knew. She was so in love with Adora – had *been* so in love with Adora for so long – that if the kiss was something that Adora was trying out as an experiment, Catra would've been wrecked.

She felt the urge to comfort herself but settled for crossing her arms.

Adora seemed to take that in slowly, some of the chill melting away. She sounded a lot younger when she asked, "And that's why you ghosted me?"

Catra swallowed the lump in her throat. "*You* stopped taking my calls, Adora."

Adora shook her head. "No, I went by the next morning after you ran off from the dance and you refused to see me. I thought that's what you wanted. A clean break."

Catra barked out a cold laugh at the most ridiculous thing she'd ever heard. "When has anything ever been clean between us? It's always muddy and-and confusing! And I *never* refused to see you! Where the hell did you get that dumb ass idea?" Adora just blinked up at her and Catra didn't even need an answer. "Weaver."

Fucking *Weaver.* The old girl was in top form that night when Catra rushed home from the dance, still shaking from the adrenaline. She found Weaver drunk, miserable, nearly unresponsive in one of her episodes. There was no time to have a full breakdown about her first big lesbian kiss or the inevitable rejection from her crush cause Catra was too busy trying to coax her guardian off the floor. Once she finally got Weaver into bed, they got a couple hours of sleep before Weaver's desperate shouting woke Catra up, pleading with someone at the front door to please go away and leave them alone. That no one in the house wanted them there.

Honestly, at the time, Catra figured it was the sheriff's office out for one of their usual wellness visits. But when the deputy came by the next day and finally convinced Weaver to head off somewhere to get help, Catra kinda never thought about that first visitor again. Since, you know, she was so busy worrying about possibly getting shipped off to some hellhole of a group home far away from Bright Moon and Adora.

"She didn't tell you?" Adora asked.

Catra shook her head. Weaver barely said goodbye so she sure as shit wasn't passing along messages. After that, Catra was being hustled into temporary custody of the state, missing a few days of school or in Netossa's office trying to get help while things got sorted out.

"Well, I guess I get why you were so angry the next time we saw each other."

Catra hated to admit it but she got why Adora was a ball of fire the next time they spoke too, both of them convinced the other had shut

them out of their lives forever without another thought. "Uh, yeah. Same, I guess."

"So." Adora had to pause to swallow loudly, "When you moved and I never reached out. You just thought I bailed on you?"

Catra nodded. It was now her turn to swallow audibly. She realized she was trying to keep down her tears. 2 years of thinking that her best friend – the most important, most trusted person in her entire world – had left right at the worst moment of her life.

"Fuck," Adora said and the defeat in her voice felt like a kick to the knees.

Catra laughed, choking on tears halfway through. "You cussed!"

"I'm so sorry, Cat. I should've tried again. I would've never left you alone through all that. I thought you hated me or you were grossed out because we kissed. And when we fought and we stopped talking." Adora paused to sigh, her eyes wet as well now. "All this time, I've saved your seat. Hoping one day you'd change your mind."

Catra couldn't imagine a sentence in the Etherian language that could make her feel more miserable. The idea of Adora waiting two years for Catra to pull her head out of her own ass, completely fucking clueless about what had gone down that night and the weeks following, was like someone slowly crushing her chest.

"You were wrong," Adora added, seemingly unaware that Catra was spiraling around the *dozens* of things they'd both been wrong about for years. "About the bleachers, I mean. I wasn't hiding. I just- I wanted to be alone with you. To make the night special. No one — no one, Catra – really sees me the way you do. I just wanted to make you feel as special as you always made me feel back then."

There was a feeling in Catra's chest, like her heart clenching. This level of hopeless love was, quite possibly, fatal.

It felt like that confession deserved something in return. Acknowledgement at the very least so Adora understood she wasnt alone or waiting for a day that would never come. But all Catra could do was stand there, trying to understand that the last two years were much much different that the reality shed let herself believe in.

Adora still wanted Catra in her life. Adora had stayed, had *waited* for her all this time. Catra couldnt even begin to identify the things that made her feel, let alone put them into words. For so long, Catra's friendship with Adora was the only stability in her life, the only place she could count on without a second guess. And shed gone and fucked it up so thoroughly that Catra was sure the next thing she said to Adora had to be perfect, or else shed risk losing her last chance to know Adora at all. Unfortunately, Catra had lost all of her ability to think clearly and probably needed to process all of these new and terrifying revelations and emotions before she said some dumb shit and drove Adora further away.

The slight relief that Catra had noticed in Adora's stance earlier was slipping. The more Catra stood there, mouth flopping open like a fish, the more Adora's perfect face fell. She must have been taking Catra's silence as a rejection and not ~~fu~~ck, what had Entrapta said? ~~a~~ sign of her being emotionally stunted or whatever .

The bell rang suddenly from the large speakers attached to the side of the building, startling Catra so badly that she jumped about a foot into the air.

Adora all but folded into herself, looking too wrung out to even notice the bell. Catra hadnt seen her so defeated since she missed a basically unguarded shot in 8th grade and her error cost the team a trip to the championship game. Catra had spent that evening in Adora's bed, holding her while she cried and trying to give her snacks and terrible ideas of how they could sabotage the rival team. That didnt seem like the type of problem-solving that could fix their current issue.

"Uh, well," Adora awkwardly began, "If there's nothing else you want to say, I better get to class."

Catra helplessly opened and closed her mouth a couple times, still trying and failing to come up with something that was enough to make Adora understand but not so much to drive her off, before Adora gave up and turned to go.

The last thing she could survive was Adora's silence. In a rush, Catra's hand sprung out and grabbed Adora's wrist, stopping her progress.

"Let's go do something," Catra said, not caring how desperate her voice sounded. She had easily a million things that she needed to tell Adora and not a single brain cell was firing to make that happen. But fuck if she was letting Adora wander off before Catra had had a chance to make this right. "Please?"

"Catra, I dont kno-"

"The other day you asked if we could pretend nothing was going on. And I did it, no problem. I'm just asking you to do the same for me."

There were several problems with running away from school in the middle of the day. One: Catra was starving. Two: Nothing was open except fast food places. Three: This was Bright Moon and even if it had been 6pm on a Friday, their options would still only include the mall, driving in circles, or the movie theater. Luckily, Catra thought of the one place with food that never seemed to be closed and wouldnt give two shits if two teenagers hung out there while ditching.

"You hate bowling," Adora laughed, while she watched Catra try to get used to wearing a stranger's shoes. It was gross. And slippery. Why were bowling shoes so fucking slippery?

Adora had put on her shoes, found the perfect ugly red ball, and set up the scoreboard. All Catra had done was complain and tentatively

walk around in tiny circles. Honestly, after she'd gotten them there without dying, she deserved a bit of a break. It was really fucking hard to steer a bike with a gorgeous girl standing on your back axle thingy, pressing her body into yours, and giggling the whole way.

Some of the tension from earlier has faded but Catra could tell that Adora was still holding back. She wasn't wrong to do so. She'd kinda put everything out there and got nothing in return.

"You ready yet?" Adora asked. She smiled slightly, probably to assure Catra that she wasn't losing her patience.

"My turn first?"

When Adora nodded, Catra stepped up to grab her ball. She didn't really care which one she used. Bowling was kinda dumb but the chicken fingers at the concession stand more than made up for that.

Catra took her turn, not paying much attention to form or strategy. When they were kids, Randor had taken them to the lanes a few times. Neither was very good but that didn't stop them from getting unnecessarily competitive about it.

She was going back to pick up her remaining three pins when Catra noticed the scorecard.

"Are you fucking kidding me?"

"Hmm," Adora hummed, failing very badly to hide her smile. "Something wrong?"

Clear as fucking day, the giant tv named both players. Princess' and Meowmeow.'

That was supposed to be a closely kept secret between the two of them. When Catra was in 2nd grade, she was finally old enough to realize how very different everything about her was from everyone. Including her fucking mouthful of a name. No one could correctly

pronounce ‘Cyra Driluth,’ not school admins or classmates or even the fucking teachers who she explained it to countless times. Wanting to fit in a bit, she asked Adora for advice and instead received a whole new name. Catra Meowmeow. Obviously, part of it stuck. *Like obviously*, part of it was fucking embarrassing and the exact opposite of what Catra was looking for so Adora had been sworn to secrecy. Secrecy that she’d just fucking broken!

“I hope you realize that I will have my revenge, Princess,” Catra promised.

“Whatever you say, little Meowmeow.”

Catra was overly ambitious. Apparently Adora had gotten a lot better at this game. She was kicking Catra’s ass and had nearly doubled her score before the 6th frame had even started.

“Didn’t realize you were a ringer. How come you didn’t mention this when I was considering becoming a bookie?”

“I’m not helping you become a crime kingpin,” Adora told her. “You’ll just have to do it yourself.”

“Well, I appreciate you having faith in me,” Catra drawled.

“I know you can do just about anything if you give it a real try.” It was a simple sentence but Adora clearly had a lot on her mind. She turned away quickly before Catra had a chance to really examine the pained look on her face.

Without another word, Adora went to go pick up her ball. Adora had always been shit at pretending and it was clear as day by her stiff body language that she was struggling to maintain the normalcy Catra had asked for.

Scratch that—Adora *was usually* shit at pretending. Catra would have to integrate how thoroughly Adora had conned her and Huntara into her ideas of just what exactly Adora was capable of. There were

so many questions she had about that. She imagined it must have been the same for Adora.

"Get a strike and Ill answer one question," Catra offered.

Adora spun around on her heel, somehow already excited and bewildered. "I thought we were pretending nothing's going on."

That was a polite way of putting it. What they were really doing was being deeply uncomfortable and stilted with each other, while pretending they didn't notice. Outside of the ride there, they'd both been avoiding accidentally touching or even holding eye contact, like the past few weeks together had been erased. Catra hated that.

"Yeah, well, that's pretty fucking selfish of me, isn't it? So. One strike, one question." Catra shrugged in a pitiful attempt to hide her nerves.

She wasn't sure what the hell had gotten into her. But she needed Adora to know. She needed Adora to know that Catra had never hated her, had never wanted to hurt her. This mess with Huntara – Catra still hadn't figured out how to pull it all apart, get to the root of just what the fuck Adora was up to there. Maybe they could finally put some of the old shit to bed though.

Adora gave her a determined nod, making the pinched little face she pulled when she was focused on something. Moments later, Catra watched as the pins practically exploded from the force that Adora had used. Perfect strike.

Godsdamnit.

Adora was kind enough to only be a little smug and insufferable when she skipped back over. She opened her mouth before snapping it shut.

"What's wrong?"

"I don't even know where to start," Adora admitted.

To be fair, Catra wasn't sure where to start either. Most importantly, she *didn't* want Adora to ask why Catra had kissed her all those years ago. And she also desperately *did* want Adora to ask why Catra had kissed her.

No. That was too complicated, too deep for a mostly-empty bowling alley, where the only other patrons seemed like half-drunk loners scattered along the other lanes.

"I'm sorry," Catra said. "For everything."

Adora looked surprised but slowly accepted it with a nod. "Me too."

"I know. You don't have to say it again. I should've I should've tried harder to talk to you. It didn't make any fucking sense—you're not the kind of person to just bail. If things hadn't been so fucked up with Weaver and all the legal shit, I would've had a moment to slow down and realize how ridiculous it was to think that you'd just leave."

"I'd never do that," Adora swore.

It took Catra a moment but eventually she said, "I know." She shoved her hands in her pockets and cast her eyes down towards the floor. "Sorry for running off in the first place. Just kinda panicked when I heard someone coming. I didn't want to get you in trouble or make things awkward for you."

"I thought you hated me," Adora whispered.

Catra scoffed, "I wish."

She watched as Adora's eyebrows rose theatrically. "Wow."

"You know I didn't mean it like that. Don't be a dick."

"I'm sorry it's soooo hard to hate me," Adora said sarcastically. "I'll try to make myself less amazing to be around."

"You're doing an excellent job right now, trust me."

Adora giggled before slipping into a soft smile. "I know what I want to ask you now."

Catra backtracked in her mind. Like a total dork, she'd spewed all that shit out without any prompting.

"Go of f then."

To her surprise, Adora pulled her into a tight hug. "Friends again?" she whispered against Catra's neck.

She had to fight not to curl further into Adora's body. They could be friends. She'd missed Adora' s friendship so much, more than she'd let herself admit in the past two years.

And it was a generous fucking offer. So much more than Catra thought she deserved. Even if – and this was a huge fucking *if* – Catra had ever considered wanting more, their one chance at it had ended so terribly. Had ruined everything. It wasn't worth wanting.

Catra wasn't worth wanting.

"Y eah, friends," she agreed, afraid to speak above a sigh and risk scaring Adora off.

Catra's hands reached around to grip at Adora's back. Adora began to quietly hum in that low , steady way that she'd picked up when they were kids. Slowly, a soft purr kicked up in Catra's throat, matching Adora's rhythm.

"Always."

Chapter End Notes

> it's honestly just kinda fluf f town from here on out. there's processing - with me, there's always multi-chapter processing - but now adora and catra get to be pals. pals who totally aren't constantly thinking "I love you i love you oh my gods i hope you don't realize i love you" over and over on a loop.

But You Always Really Knew

Chapter Notes

> happy teen lesbian angst tuesday!the angst to fluf f ratio here is actually more like 30/70.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Being Adora's friend wasweird. Catra still wasnt sure she was very good at it. It was different than before. They both had other friends, for a change, and their lives didnt revolve around each other. For the past week, Catrad actually had to intentionally make plans with Adora, which was so strange. Adora couldnt just decide to do something and assume that Catra would pop up. Adora had to want Catra to be there and vice versa. And the two of them had to actually communicate that. It all felt very mature.

Being Adora's friend made Adora happy. Like ridiculously happy. She was practically skipping everywhere. She had a newfound energy that almost made Catra smile just thinking about it. Being able to bug Catra whenever she wanted to about schoolwork helped Adora regain some confidence around her grades and her upcoming college applications. On the couple of occasions that Catra had had time to drop by hockey practice, Adora had been playing like a whole new person. She was still a terror on the field but she appeared to be having such a good time (especially when she got to showboat, winking up at Catra in the stands.)

And that was all they were, to be clear. Just a couple of friends. A couple of buds.

"It's weird," Glimmer said.

"It's not," Bow argued. "It's sosweet."

"I thought they were awful as enemies. They're even worse as besties."

Catra didn't bother looking up from her desk. Her *new* desk. The day after bowling, Adora had grabbed Catra's hand as soon as she walked into Art class and dragged her into the empty chair next to the blonde. (Usually, Catra didn't think teachers paid much attention to their teenage angst drama bullshit but Spinnerella's eyes had gotten huge for one brief second before she went back to pretending that she was super focused on handing out supplies for the day.)

This week, they were supposed to be cutting shapes out of construction paper and gluing them to a giant piece of cardboard to make a collage. Spinny had said something about balance and aesthetic but it was pretty hard to have any particular vision for this because it was a two-person project. And Catra's partner insisted on doing most of the work while basically sitting in Catra's lap.

"They're not doing anything *bad,"* Bow tried to explain.

"Bow, they're actually somehow dumber together than they are apart. I swear to the Gods, if Adora falls over *one more time* just because she's staring at Catra, they can say goodbye to that one brain cell they have left to share." Glimmer paused and half-gasped. "Lookit, she's gonna tilt all the way over."

Catra glanced to her left quickly where Adora was indeed leaning very closely against Catra's side. Adora hadn't seemed to notice that that meant her seat, one of those hard plastic torture chambers that their school distract called 'chairs,' was only on two legs. One more little tilt and Adora was gonna crash right onto the floor.

"Watch it, dummy," Catra warned. She turned to the side and threw her legs into Adora's lap to keep Adora *balanced,* obviously…

Adora sunk back into her chair with a frown. "What did I do?" She'd just missed her chair floating on air, because of course she did.

"You're using too much glue," Catra lied. Well, half-lied. Adora did need to have a lighter hand or this whole project was gonna be a sticky mess. But more importantly, Catra wasn't about to point out what had just happened or let Glimmer and Bow (but let's be real, *Glimmer* mostly) make fun of Adora.

"Here," Catra said, before grabbing one of the wing-like shapes that Adora had cut out. "I glue, you place." It was a good plan, one that would support Catra only being able to reach the table with one arm thanks to the awkward position she was now seated in.

However, the plan had an unintended consequence. Adora *also* now only needed to use one arm as they worked together as a unit, quickly building a pretty bad-ass collage that almost looked like a scary bird of prey if you tilted your head just right. Adora's free hand slowly migrated into her own lap then onto the chair before finding its way onto Catra's back and lingering there until the bell rang. It was such a light touch, Adora's palm so low on her spine that her fingertips landed on the short strip of exposed fur where Catra's jeans didn't quite meet her tshirt. Catra had to direct her full focus to the project in front of them to make sure she didn't do something mortifying like try to arch further into Adora's hand.

Adora's eyes were completely honed in on gluing, tongue peeking out between her lips. So it was just Catra who felt like a complete mess. She was desperate for this to mean something to Adora, for Adora to want Catra the way she'd always wanted her in return. At the same time, a little voice in the back of her head wouldn't stop reminding her that: A. Adora could never feel that way and more importantly, B. Catra would just fuck it up if that impossible dream did somehow come true. Their friendship was fragile and Catra had only just begun earning that back – it wasn't a good look to be a selfish dick and push for anything more. What kind of asshole goes around asking for a million dollars after someone just generously offered them a quarter?

For the rest of the class, Adora seemed content to just use Catra as a human arm rest, totally unaware of what she was doing to her poor

seatmate. Every once in a while, a couple of Adora's fingers would brush mindlessly back and forth across Catra's fur, so gently that she had to bite the inside of her cheek to keep from purring.

Catra knew Glimmer had seen that, mostly because she wouldn't stop whispering "Bow, do you see this?!" over and over. The idiot couldn't seem to get it through her head that no matter how much Catra – and also apparently *Glimmer* now – wanted there to be something between her and Adora, it just wasn't happening.

She wasn't in a mood for whatever useless dating advice Glitter was definitely gonna try to throw at her, so Catra ducked out of the class as soon as the bell rang. She even managed to dodge Glimmer and Bow during lunch, but Adora was having a scrimmage after school with the fancy prep school from Elberon. Catra had already agreed to be there, even though it was a casual low-stakes game, because Adora had pleaded and made big sad eyes at her. Bow and Glimmer never missed a game. Catra brought Entrapta along as a buffer but she knew Glimmer was unstoppable once she had a mission.

The first quarter had barely begun before Glimmer popped up on the bench next to Catra. One second, she'd been down in the front row, then Catra blinked, and Glimmer was suddenly up on the highest bench, just a fucking hair away from Catra's face.

"Demon!" Catra hissed, tail fluffing out behind her.

"Stop being so dramatic," Glimmer said with a sneer.

"Something wrong with your seat?" Catra asked. The bleachers around them were only half-full, maybe even a little less, which Catra pointed out, waving lazily at all the places Glimmer could be, except in her damn space.

"Why aren't you going to homecoming with Adora?"

Out of the corner of her eye, Catra watched Entrapta lift her head from her tablet for the first time since they'd sat down. The prospect

of Entrapta accidentally saying—well, pretty much *anything* about Catra in front of Glimmer was too scary. The *power* it would give Glimmer? Etheria-shattering, for Catra at least.

"You know that the title of 'social chair' doesn't actually put you in charge of everyone else's life, right?"

"It's a week away," Glimmer continued. "Adora says you haven't talked about it once."

"*Entrapta* and I haven't talked about it either," Catra replied. "So fucking what?"

"You know it's not the same!" Glimmer had barely been talking to her and was already pink in the face from anger.

Catra huffed and turned her attention back to the field. Adora was sneaking down the side, subtly motioning for Mermista to pass to her. Her eyes were already twinkling with joy, like she was certain that she was about to surprise the defense and keep them on their toes. Stupid gorgeous cocky jerk.

"Why isn't it the same?" Catra asked. "Me and Adora are just becoming friends again."

"Uhhh, cause you're super fucking gay for each other," Glimmer said, like it was obvious.

Entrapta hummed quietly in agreement.

Catra tucked her chin against her chest. Glimmer was annoyingly effective at getting Catra to say shit didn't want to acknowledge ever.

"We barely have a friendship right now. What if it's a bad idea to try for more?" They had – *Catra had* – basically ruined everything last time she let herself act on her feelings for Adora.

Glimmer slid forward so she could look past Catra at Entrapta. "Is this bitch for real?"

Catra sat forward and blocked Glimmer off so that nothing incriminating could be said about her. She was capable of doing that on her own.

"Look, I kinda dicked Adora over . I don't even deserve how nice she's being to me now."

"Y ou were *both* idiots. And everyone deserves to be happy," Glimmer grumbled at Catra, in a tone that would be more appropriate if Catra had just thrown dirt in her face, not whispered a secret.

This was getting nowhere. Catra opened her mouth to defend herself but suddenly there was the sound of a collision from below on the field. She jerked forward instantly , surprised that she'd let herself be distracted from the game. Some girl in a yellow jersey was still stumbling off to the side from a hit while Adora grinned and ran off. Her eyes were already looking up in the stands, trying to find Catra.

"W ell, if your next weaksauce excuse was gonna be that you're not sure if Adora even likes you like that, you can dub that now," Glimmer said.

Catra made sure to exaggerate being impressed when Adora caught sight of her, so that Adora would know that she was totally faking it.

"Pay attention to the game, Gray!" Glimmer shouted, so loudly that everyone within 3 square miles heard it. The rest of Adora' s team laughed at her expense as she went bright red and immediately moved to chase after the ball.

Catra had to wipe the grin off of her face cause Glimmer was still zeroed in on her and clearly not going anywhere until she heard what she wanted to hear.

"Sparkles, I don't know what Adora told you but she clearly only went along with this stupid Huntara thing so she'd be able to talk to me. We're talking now . We're friends. Just let it go."

Glimmer's face contorted into a funhouse mirror. Everything was somehow both pinched and wide at the same time, her mouth flapping open while her eyes narrowed to pinpoints.

"Oh, you dont even fucking *know?*" Glimmer whispered in horror. "Bow!"

Catra turned to Entrapta to see if she was noticing how weird Glimmer was being but Trap just shrugged. When Catra looked back, Glimmer was suddenly back down in the first row, whispering harshly into Bow's ear.

Between the sound of the small crowd and Glimmer doing an amazing job of keeping quiet for once, Catra couldnt make out anything she was saying. She watched as Bow slowly swiveled his full body to gape at her, then noticed Catra staring back, and basically threw himself behind Glimmer to avoid getting caught.

"Those two are about as subtle as a fucking fireworks display ," Catra grumbled.

"I wonder what you don't know ," Entrapta said. "I mean, logically , there's many things you don't know. I'm referring specifically to Glimmer."

"Y eah, you didn't need to dumb that down for me."

Catra kept her ears strained to hear what Glimmer was up to but let her eyes drift back to the field, where Scorpia soon accidentally stumbled into a defender and sent her basically flying into the parking lot. It was a shame Catra had stayed away from the games for so long. She'd forgotten how much she enjoyed watching poor souls get their shit destroyed over a dumb ball.

The casual violence was the real draw for Catra and *not* the sweaty team captain who was running around and shaking everyone's hand like she was campaigning for president as soon as the match ended. As had been their tradition in the past, Catra came down from her

perch to hover near the sidelines and wait for Adora. The trouble was that she had kinda forgotten to communicate that so Catra got to have a super fun half a minute of pure frightening anxiety while she stood there looking like a lost idiot. What if Adora had new traditions? What if she did something special with Bow and Glimmer or Scorpia and Mermista now? What if she-

"Catra!" was about the only warning she got before Adora grabbed her around the waist and crushed their bodies together. "Did you see that last goal?!" Adora screamed right into her neck.

Her uniform was soaked and had that mesh/sweat/last-hints-of-the-Grays'-fabric-softener-obsession smell. Catra hated to admit that she closed her eyes and melted right into the familiarity of it. Her hands went to grip at Adora's back. The practice jerseys didn't have numbers, she remembered too late, so where Catra expected to find a plastic 9, her fingers instead landed on firm muscle.

Thoughts of *Adora* and *muscles* clouded Catra's brain.

She felt herself choke a little on her own spit but managed to turn it into a fake laugh. Clearing her throat, she stuttered out. "Did you see how that defender blew apart like she was made of dust when you fucking trucked her?"

Adora pulled back to look at her face but didn't release her yet. She must not have noticed anything wrong cause Adora smiled, full of herself. "Impressive, right?"

"Considering that you couldn't walk and chew gum at the same time until we were 12, yeah. Pretty amazing."

"Jerk!" Adora yelled, using her hold on Catra's hips to poke at her lightly. "Come on. Any tips?"

Honestly, Catra's hockey insight was a little rusty so she threw out a joke. "Keep your eyes on the field and not handsome *jerks* up in the stands?"

She had clearly meant it as a joke, but to Catra' s surprise, Adora's face went red all the way up to the tips of her ears.

Adora opened her mouth, probably to defend herself, but was cut off by someone from the rival team calling her over. Catra glanced over Adora's shoulder to see a group of kids from both sides shooting the shit in the middle of the field.

Adora looked reluctant to leave just yet, but Catra shooed her off. "Go, piss off. Talk about reps or creatine or whatever. Ill see you on Monday."

"Not soone-?"

"Gray!" Mermista yelled in a voice that made it very clear that she wasnt fucking around. "Get your ass over here!"

Catra turned to head back to Entrapta so that Adora had no choice but to go join the other sports lezzes. She was kinda proud of herself —a few years ago, she would've been super annoyed at having to share Adora's attention. Look at that growth or something.

She made it about two steps before a giant weight hit her back. For a moment, Catra thought Sparkles was taking her down again.

Instead, she felt arms wrap her up in another hug. Adora was so close that her lips brushed Catra's left ear, light as a feather, when she whispered, "Thanks so much for coming, Cat. It means a lot."

Before she could respond, Adora was gone, her loud steps rushing off in the other direction.

Looking to see if Entrapta had moved, Catra accidentally caught Bow and Glimmer, still waiting in the stands and staring right at her like they'd just seen the cutest thing on Etheria.

"Silence," she ordered both of them before they could make a sound. Catra knew she probably looked like a mess;she could feel the heat

rushing to her face and no matter how much she tried to bite it down, her wide smile wasn't going anywhere.

Saturdays were made for sleeping in. Though 'sleeping in' was pretty generous cause it meant Catra was usually up at 10 am, instead of 7am. Razz wouldn't be awake for another hour usually so it was weird when someone knocked on Catra's door just a few minutes after she'd showered and gotten dressed.

The sight that greeted her was a godsdamn shock to the system. Adora was hovering on the landing in a pair of gray sweatshorts, a tight white tanktop, a silly red headband, and a fucking red and black checkered fannypack, like she was a 'cool' dad heading of f to the gym.

Catra fought the urge to once again ask if Adora was lost, just showing up at her place randomly.

"Morning!" Adora sang. She'd clearly been awake for too many hours already, just based on how bubbly and happy she was.

There wasn't any way to hide her wild, unbrushed hair or the bags under her eyes from staying up too late texting with Adora, but Catra tried to distract from her ugly weekend errands outfit by shoving half her body behind her door. If she'd known she'd be seeing Adora today, she would have put on something slightly less embarrassing. There was nothing attractive about her too-big acid-washed overalls or her too-little super worn-in dark red Bright Moon Middle School tshirt. Not that trying to be attractive was a priority for Catra all of a sudden.

"What up?" Catra asked. It was the first time she'd spoken out loud today so her voice came out extra gravelly.

Adora's bright smile faded away. "Oh, shoot! Did I wake you up? Im so sor-"

"I'm up," Catra interrupted. "The question is – why are *you* up? Aren't you tired from yesterday?"

"Why? Cause I was being lectured about liking house music for two hours past my bedtime last night?" Adora teased. It was a new thing she'd learned about Adora last night, her terrible tastes had shifted to include the muddled nonstop sounds of dance music; Catra *had* to spend several minutes roasting Adora for her bad choices.

"Cause you chased a ball around for 90 minutes, duh." Adora's face lit up with an 'oh, riiiight' expression that had Catra laughing quietly. "What are you up to this morning?"

"I brought you coffee," Adora said. For the first time, Catra realized she had been holding her arms behind her back. With a flourish, Adora revealed her hands, both filled with giant frozen sugary-looking beverages.

"Is it pumpkin spice season so soon?" Instead of reaching for hers, she just pointedly raised a mocking eyebrow at Adora.

"Fine, guess that means I get to enjoy *both* of these mocha fraps." Adora moved her arm about an inch towards her own body before Catra grabbed the drink out of her hand. Unfortunately, that meant that she could no longer hide behind her door. "Oh my Gods!" Adora laughed. "I can't believe you still have that shirt. Or that it still *fits*. I guess being so short has some advantages."

Catra glared at the dork's taunting smile, while she greedily drank her sugarbomb of a coffee. "Aw, look at you trying to be funny. How precious. Especially for an idiot wearing shorts when it's already cold enough to freeze a nip out here. That's some white nonsense."

Adora rolled her eyes. "Well, my hips' aren't on my legs so I should be fine."

"That's the dumbest logic I've ever heard."

"Plus, I don't wanna overheat while we're riding around today ."

"While we *what?*

Catra had assumed the dummy had jogged there or something. Leaning a bit further out the door, though, she could see an expensive-looking bike parked in the driveway below. While Catra still hadn't learned much about the damn things, even with her time down at the bike shop, she was pretty sure the thing was a mountain bike, with its rugged look. It was pristine, black matte, and, most confusing, had a silly little trailer attached to it.

"What the hell is that?" Catra asked.

Without bothering to put on a jacket, she pushed past Adora and hopped down the stairs. Catra tried not to seem too interested in this whole thing, since she wasn't really sure what Adora's plan was yet. She chose to slowly sip her drink while circling the bike.

It really did look like no one had ridden it much. And the trailer thing screamed brand new' since its two wheels barely had any wear and tear and its red canvas cover thing still had that 'fresh out the box' smell.

She turned as Adora joined her , pace much more tentative than needed. Adora was nervously sucking down her coffee.

"It's a bike," she said with her mouth still around her straw .

"And where are you planning on taking it today?"

"Wherever you need to go," Adora answered back in an unusually timid voice.

Catra glanced back at the bike. This would be a lot less fun than Catra riding with Adora basically draped over her shoulders like they'd done on the way to the bowling alley and a couple quick rides after school since then.

Adora must have thought Catra's silence was because of her plan and not their mode of transportation, because she rambled on, "I don't know. I mean, you were right about what you said a few weeks ago—you spent so much time having to follow me to games and practices and errands with my dad. I know you're busy now. I just thought maybe I could tag along with you. Help you out with whatever you have to do today."

Catra couldn't really handle looking back at Adora right now. She knew that if she saw the earnest but nervous expression on Adora's face that Catra could definitely hear in her voice right now, she'd buckle and agree.

A stubborn part of Catra wanted to decline. She didn't need Adora's help. She didn't need anyone's help actually. But it might be nice to have it?

"You better keep up, princess."

Catra headed off on their first stop, letting her tail wrap around Adora's wrist to tug her in the direction of the rest of the house. Razz opened the door before Catra could even reach for the knob. Adora jumped back in surprise when the old lady was standing in front of them, dressed in a pink housecoat and already holding a handful of crumpled up sheets of notebook paper.

"Stop making so much noise," she ordered Catra, before pushing the papers into her hands.

"We've literally been silent all morning." Catra leaned over to look at Razz more closely. "Are you hungover?"

"I haven't had a drink since 32," Razz lied through her teeth. She waved her hand to shoo Catra away.

"Since *you* were 32 or 9?"

Without taking her eyes off of Catra, Razz reached behind her door. Catra knew what came next and took a quick step back so she was out of broomin' reach. Once she was sure that Razz was neutralized, Catra straightened the papers out in her hands. Four different lists, each more incomprehensible than the last. Names, places, shit to pick up that Catra would have to weave into her own tasks and gigs today.

She groaned. "The hobby shop? Really?" The DReams owned it and Scorpia would definitely be there helping out on a Saturday. Catra would never hear the end of it if she showed up with Adora. "What are you even making?"

"All *you're* making is a ruckus on my porch so scoot!"

This interaction was beneath her so Catra turned to leave without another word. Razz's broom flew out to stop Adora from following.

"Mara, dearie," Razz practically sang to her. "It's so nice to have you back. Your dress is going to be so beautiful."

"Feel free to ignore literally everything she says," Catra called over her shoulder. "I certainly do."

"Uh, good to see you too, Razz," Adora said anxiously.

They stopped for Catra to grab a hoodie and for Adora to have a brain freeze while she chugged her entire drink, even though Catra had warned her that that's exactly what was gonna happen.

They ended up spending the morning and most of the afternoon riding around town and terrorizing Bright Moon. And by that, Catra meant that Adora tagged along while she stocked inventory at the bike shop, delivered meds to Razz's bingo buddies, and tried to avoid running into Sea Hawk at just about every parking lot they passed. Everything went a little faster with Adora's help, especially when she distracted Scorpia at the DReams' store with praise for her play at the scrimmage while Catra darted through the aisles and

grabbed everything Razz needed. Escaping without being questioned or having to witness Scorpia's very unsubtle faces was worth all the many times someone else from school saw them outside on the street and stopped to say hi to Adora while Catra awkwardly had to pretend that she totally knew who they were. Even the damn trailer came in handy. Catra would have to thank Randor for that later cause she was sure it was his idea.

They split a gas station sandwich in between stops but as they rode past the ice cream place on South Street, Adora started complaining about being hungry again.

"And they might still have that mint flavor ," Adora sang, really laying it on thick. She was trying to play it off but her eyes were pleading with Catra to agree.

Catra opened her mouth to list all the reasons why this was a bad idea, when Adora quickly unzipped her fanny pack for the first time that day and whipped out a small white pillbox.

"Oh, my dad gave me these just in case," Adora paused to toss the bottle over to Catra, who was still sitting partway in the street, ignoring that Adora had already rode over to the sidewalk and was clearly ready to just jump off her bike and rush inside. "Plus, he gave me money to treat you."

"Fine," Catra replied with a sigh.

As soon as they were in the doors, Adora ran off to wash her hands. Catra was grateful for that for two reasons. 1. She'd witnessed Adora eat ice cream many many times and it never ended without a pool of melted goo all over the dummy's hands that she'd have to *lick* off for some reason, instead of just using a napkin.

2. Standing over by the counter, really leaning on the damn thing so the other half-dozen people in the shop couldn't even see the flavors, was Huntara.

The shop was pretty small, with enough space for a modest line and maybe 8 people to stay and sit if they wanted. If Adora had been paying literally any attention, she would have noticed Huntara right there in the center of the room, shoved up against the case where 10 colorful frozen flavors were on display. From what Adora had said, she and Huntara had talked. Catra hadnt been brave enough to ask for more details and she still couldnt help but feel like between the three of them, someone was still hiding something. She just wanted to avoid this whole thing if possible. Adora had forgiven her, Huntara had forgiven Adora, and Catra had decided to just never think about how Adora had turned the tables on her.

Behind the counter, Perfuma was dressed in a white tshirt with the store's logo. Bold choice for a person who was currently stacking three bright blue scoops of ice cream on a waffle cone. Huntara was obviously there to talk to her, since she couldnt seem to look away from her. Perfuma was moving quickly through orders, but kept shooting Huntara soft smiles every time she got a chance.

Perfuma was the first to spot Catra once a couple people moved to the register where that grumpy blue-haired sophomore gremlin, Frosta, was checking everyone out. Catra didnt know the kid but shed seen her around, skulking through the halls and being all emo.

"Catra!" Perfuma said with a huge smile. "Fun! I love seeing you *not* at school."

Catra wasnt sure what she did to earn that so she just shrugged and gave a small salute. Perfuma moved to help another customer while Huntara tossed Catra a look over her shoulder.

"What's up, Driluth," she said.

"What up," Catra muttered back. She kept her eyes on the menu for longer than needed, really examining every single option so she wouldnt have to talk more. There were still 4 people ahead of her and she already knew that the mint was the only thing she was interested in.

"Let me know if you want to taste anything," Perfuma announced in the direction of the entire line. Unfortunately, *all* of the idiots in front of Catra decided to take her up on that offer, each asking for tiny spoons of several flavors. While they all stopped to get each other's opinions, Perfuma floated over to give Huntara another grin.

For some reason, she then turned to Catra and asked, "How's Scorpia doing? I haven't seen her around much lately."

"Uhhhh," Catra stalled. "Um. She's fine. Just busy. Field hockey's starting up."

Perfuma accepted that with a quick nod. "Fun!" Catra decided then and there that she hated the bright way Perfuma said that word. "Tell her I said hi."

Catra would not be doing that. However, she did try to dial back the frown that she felt she was accidentally giving Perfuma. The other girl hadn't done anything wrong and she was still being nice to Catra, even though she didn't need to.

"Sure," Catra lied. More than likely, she'd just forget anyway.

Perfuma floated back over to the other group.

"So," Catra awkwardly said to Huntara's back. "Looks like that's working out."

"Yep," Huntara answered shortly. Was she angry? At Catra? Who, maybe Huntara hadn't heard, had not done anything bad?

Maybe Catra hadn't been stressing that enough to everyone? Maybe she'd been stressing it too much and Huntara could see through it to her obvious inner guilt?

"Why are you all nervous back there?" Huntara asked. Before Catra could tell another casual lie in this establishment, Huntara turned to face her. She kept her body slumped against the counter, still very

much in everyone's way, including the small line forming behind Catra.

"Look, I talked to Adora," Huntara shared. She ignored Catra getting even tenser to add, "She apologized for leading me on but.." Huntara shrugged and Catra wondered if she was strong enough to accidentally lift the counter off the floor with that move. She wasn't, it turned out. "It's not a big deal. I shoulda known it wouldn't work with Adora when I had to force it so much."

Everything in Catra was deeply uncomfortable with this level of vulnerability from someone who was seconds away from crushing her several times in the past weeks.

"Well, the real lesson was the friendship that you and I developed along the way," Catra said to her, knowing that whatever punishment Huntara gave her for that would be worth seeing the big lug look surprised, annoyed, and grossed out all at once.

"I honestly don't think I could dislike you more if I tried, Driluth."

Catra could tell she really meant it but also that deep *deep* down, she'd gained Huntara's respect. Okay, fine, she hadn't—and she honestly didn't fucking *care* to—but the idea made Catra cackle internally and feel a little delirious. So she reached all the way up and booped Huntara right on the nose.

In a flash, Huntara rose off the counter and stood up to her full height to tower over Catra. Her face set into a hard line, very ready to deliver a threat or maybe even a public beatdown.

Adora chose that moment to reappear at Catra's side, standing stiffly and tall. A sleeveless arm went around Catra's shoulder.

"Oh, hey, Huntara," Adora said. Her voice was quite a bit lower than usual. "How's it going?"

Catra glanced over to see what the fuck was up and noticed Adora seemed to be flexing, like she'd just been lifting weights instead of using the bathroom.

Speaking of which, Catra thought it would be a good idea to cut this confusing tension by turning to Adora and asking, "What took you so long? You fall in?"

Because Huntara probably wanted nothing to do with whatever the answer would be, she quickly swiveled back around and parked herself at the opposite end of the counter. She had to push a couple people out of the way but none of them, including a couple parents, looked like they wanted to challenge her.

Adora took a calming breath, Catra noticed, before she lowered her arms and her full attention was back on just the two of them. She could have just been imagining it butAdora had just saved her? From Huntara?

She didn't really have a moment to process that before Adora began rambling. "I went in and then I remembered I had to pee. I don't know why but it was so hard to get in and out of this fannypack."She waved at the thing, which did look a little damper than before. "The zipper caught on my shirt and it came open and then things *f ell* everywhere and-"

The rest of her words were cut off by Catra's loud cackling. Adora was brilliant and thought of everything and had even made all of Catra's life easier today by making a system for inventory and shopping. Adora was also an idiot who couldn't work a simple snap buckle.

Catra's laughter drowned out Adora's grumbling. With a cute little pout, Adora made a big show of stomping closer to the counter as the people ahead of them moved along.

Hell, Catra's laughter drowned out the first part of Perfuma's spiel about the ice cream, as she imagined Adora crawling around, trying

to pick up all her stuff.

"I'm not sharing with you," Adora threatened as Perfuma handed her no less than 6 tiny taste spoons.

"Catra, we still have a couple of the summer flavors left if you're interested," Perfuma said, repeating what she'd just said to Adora before going over all the best combinations.

"Just mint and chocolate for me," Catra told her .

"But the peach sorbet is so good," Adora argued, a tiny spoon still in her mouth. "And it's the last of the batch."

"You know how I feel about non-chocolate desserts, Dor."

"Fine," Adora sighed. "Perfuma, I'll do the peach and a scoop of sweet cream in a waffle cone please."

Perfuma went to work as Adora started to hum quietly to herself. The tune was familiar, even though she could tell Adora was just humming the same part over and over, likely cause she couldn't remember the rest. When they were kids, Adora would always memorize every word of *half* of a song and then somehow completely miss the rest. Catra used to live for that moment when Adora would forget the lyrics midway through something on the radio and just start singing gibberish. It never failed to crack her up.

"What is that?" she asked as Perfuma handed over their ice cream.

"Peaches and Cream!" Adora answered, smiling wide. And then her voice slipped into something lower and she began to sing right at Catra. *"Peaches and cream. I need it cause you know that I'm a fiend. You know what I mean. Peaches and cream."*

Oh, man, that was the good stuff, Catra thought as she laughed to herself. Adora was missing half the lines in there.

She gasped, pretending to be scandalized. "Keep it PG, princess. There's kids here."

Adora rolled her eyes, diving into her cone while they waited at the register. "They play that song on the radio. It's already PG." She took another long lick of ice cream that ended with her brows furrowing in confusion. "Wait, what's that song about?"

This time, Catra practically gasped for real. "Are you-Adora!" She couldn't be *that* oblivious. Though, she had conveniently not remembered the parts about 'getting freaky.'

"What?! I really don't know…"

Frosta just frowned as she gave them the total and snatched Adora's $20 bill out of her hand. She pretty much threw the change back at them.

Before they could walk away, Perfuma used her long frame to lean around Huntara, who was still a silent wall, and closer to Adora.

"Think of how the title would translate to emojs," Perfuma whispered loudly. She dramatically raised her eyebrows like that was gonna do something to help Adora figure it out.

Catra led them outside back to where they'd locked up their bikes on a random streetlight pole. Adora was absolutely right about the mint – it was perfect and luscious and creamy… The mint flavor was so godsdamn fresh and the way it mixed with the richness of the chocolate was a dream come true for Catra.

Fucking Adora Gray. Of course Adora would try this and immediately be thoughtful enough to know that Catra would love it. It almost hurt to imagine Adora here with her parents or with Glitter and Arrows, taking a photo just for Catra.

Shit. What if there were more? Did Adora have a whole slew of pictures in her phone that she'd taken with only Catra in mind?

"Oh my Gods!" Adora shouted so suddenly that Catra almost dropped her cup. "The emoj! *Catra!*"

Adora's mouth was flapping open, eyes wide. She was embarrassed and horrified, which seemed like an overreaction for not understanding a mid-level 20-year-old song.

"Why are you yelling at me about something you should have figured out in middle school?"

Adora's expression didn't change. "My *mom* s heard me sing that song, Catra. My *mother* thinks I'm a fiend for-!" She cut herself of f before she had to finish that sentence, both arms flailing around wildly.

Catra kept an eye on that cone. She wasn't about to have a repeat of what happened with that godsdamn beer at Glimmer's party.

"W ell," she said, reaching out to grab Adora' s hand and steady the ice cream, "that's probably how she figured out you were a lesbian before you did."

Adora's eyes narrowed in fake anger. She looked like she was about to give Catra a piece of her mind. Catra distracted her by leaning over and taking a lick of her ice cream cone, curling her tongue around it slowly as she maintained eye contact. It was damn delicious, another excellent choice from Adora. While Catra was enjoying how sweet and almost syrupy the flavor was, she noticed that Adora's tongue was practically hanging out of her mouth. Catra smirked when she saw that Adora's eyes had dropped to linger firmly on her lips. The small movement, Catra's cocked smile with a fang on display, was enough to knock Adora out of her daze.

"So, uh, you..you been thinking about homecoming?" Adora asked, clearing her throat awkwardly.

No, Catra had been doing a valiant j ob of ignoring homecoming, even though Glimmer kept trying to drag her into the planning

process.

"Not really ."

"W ell, if you wanted to go,"Adora began slowly . "I was gonna go. Meet up with Bow and Glimmer and everyone. You could come with me. Maybe come over early and get ready with me?"

Shit. A dance. Adora at a dance. *Going with* Adora to a dan-

"Y eah!"Catra' s mouth yelled before her brain could finish panicking. Her voice was so damn loud that a couple people walking nearby shot her weird looks.

It was worth it for how Adora immediately looked like she'd just won the lottery.

"A wesome!"the idiot basically shouted.

Adora was so excited that she started to do little fist pumps, trying to contain them down by her side like Catra wasnt looking directly at her.

"This is gonna be so great!T rust me."

Catra was trying to. Was *starting* to again, at least. She and Adora just didnt have a good track record with dances.

Chapter End Notes

raptor was the inspiration for adora's 'peaches and cream' foolishness. i couldn't miss a chance to reference an early 2000s r&b song for no reason at all. if you haven't read meet me (halfway around the world) and adora's 'no scrubs'-related spiral then you're missing out.

this story is almost over!next week - razz and entrapta and marlena and randor. edited to add: i literally forgot to mention catra and adora and a dance. jesus, i had one job.

I Just Wanna Be With You

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The next few days went by in a blur. Catra knew she should be finding something to wear or thinking about what she was gonna do on Saturday to make sure Adora had a good time. She kinda owed the dork since Catra had ruined the last dance and everything. She was just very booked and busy with jobs and schoolwork and trying to pretend like homecoming *wasn't happening.*

Feelings can't hurt you if you swallow them all down into the darkest pit of your soul, right?

It was also taking a lot for Catra to get used to Adora's constant friendship. They fit back together seamlessly, yes, but Adora also came with a whole host of additional friends now. There were group text chains with way too many people – Glimmer , Bow, Scorpia, Perfuma, and on and on – plus the non-stop messages from just Glimmer, endlessly trying to fuck up Catra's plans to ignore that homecoming was happening soon.

Since Glimmer was still grounded, she insisted on coordinating hangouts during school hours so that had to be built into Catra's schedule, ditching study hall to bullshit around in the woods or staying after school to bug Glimmer while she was doing yearbook stuff. With Catra not continuing to declare war on field hockey, Scorpia and Adora expected her at every game. Mermista and the other players had even popped over to say hey to Catra while she taunted Adora during warm-ups that day. Being friendly was *exhausting* and now Catra had to spend a Saturday evening with everyone .

She wasn't sure how tonight' s boring football game was gonna go but the field hockey team's season opener the day before was a

banger. It wasn't *close* by any stretch of the imagination because Adora fucking dominated but it was still fun to watch. Randor and Marlena were there and Catra made sure to wave from afar and run off immediately afterward so she wouldn't have to talk to them or apologize for disappearing for two years or thank them for the extra helmet that Adora had found in the bike trailer last weekend and mysteriously forgot to ask for back when she headed home.

When Catra skidded into her driveway, she was expecting to have some alone time to freak out about the dance for the next 18 hours, only taking a small break to help Razz when she got home. What Catra was *not* expecting was to see the lights on in Razz's half of the house. The old biddy should've already been halfway to the bingo hall in the weird passenger van that couriered her and her group of elderly miscreants off.

Instead, it seemed like every lamp in the place was still on, as was the tv. Catra was instantly worried. What if Razz was sick or she'd fallen or something? Catra wasn't exactly her caretaker but she felt a lot of responsibility for making sure that Razz was okay, since she'd taken a chance on Catra when no one else had. Moments like this made a little guilt over leaving Bright Moon next year well up in Catra's throat.

She dashed off towards Razz's door, hearing multiple voices as she got closer. That was even stranger. Razz rarely received visitors and it was even rarer for her to actually let them into her home.

Catra rudely opened the door without knocking and let herself in. She immediately walked right into a creepy disembodied torso on a stick and screamed.

"What the fuck is that?!"

In the center of the room, amid the orange velvet couches, fringe-covered lamps, ancient wooden tv blasting a black-and-white sitcom, and dozens of knickknacks on every surface imaginable, Razz and Entrapta turned to look at her like she'd lost it.

Razz's visitor was *Entrapta?*

The old bitty was knelt down on the floor, a soft yellow measuring tape in her hands and a couple of thin little metal pins tucked between her lips. A section of the tape ran along Entrapta's calf as she stood stock still next to Razz.

"Hello, Catra," Entrapta greeted, like it was normal that she was there.

Catra had many questions but ignored them all to get an answer to her first one. She pointed at the thing that had assaulted her when she entered.

"What *is* that?" she repeated.

"I believe it's called a dress form," Entrapta answered.

"You!" Razz yelled as best she could with pins in her mouth. "Out! Youll ruin the surprise!"

As Catra's shock faded, she slowly looked around the room, actually taking everything in. The creepy dress form thing (seriously, who kept a fucking cloth torso on a stick? That was bizarre) was wearing a tuxedo jacket in a kinda dark magenta color. It was an older style, like something from one of Razz's favorites movies, with boxy shoulders and a shade of pink running along the collar. Catra noticed that it was pretty small, too thin to be for Razz and too short to fit anyone who was taller than her or Entrapta.

She peeped that Entrapta was wearing a pair of pants that matched the jacket, fancy dress slacks. Catra had known Entrapta ever since her parents stopped homeschooling her and sent her to Bright Moon Middle to spend time with kids her age – she'd never seen Entrapta in anything other than overalls.

"Trap, what's going on?"

"I came to see you last week and this elderly woman pulled me into her house," Entrapta explained. She didn't seem to realize that *technically* she was a victim of kidnapping. "Did you know that she has no sense of time and space? I have a hypothesis that the multiverse exists and Madame Razz is trapped, mentally and psychically, floating from universe to universe."

"That would explain a lot," Catra replied. "What does she have you doing?"

"Oh?" Entrapta looked down at Razz, who was still knelt down by her leg but had moved on to doing something to the bottom of the pants. "I don't quite know. She never explained. She just told me to change in the bathroom and then stand still. I mostly just make notes about whatever she says. She rambles a lot, probably having conversations in the other universes simultaneously."

"How long have you been here?" Catra asked.

"Well, between last week and that random time a couple days ago and now 5 hours?"

"Razz!" Catra shouted in surprise. "You can't just take people's kids."

"Then people shouldn't leave them outside lying about," Razz muttered. "Besides, I would have asked for your help but you're too difficult."

"You realize calling me that all the time only makes me *more* difficult, right?"

Razz quickly stood and moved to her small desk in the corner, which was covered in random junk just like everything else. "Scissors? Scissors? Did Loo-kee move the scissors again?"

"Have you ever seen this Loo-kee?" Entrapta whispered.

Catra waved it off because it was too much to explain.

"Cyra, go into the kitchen and grab me the scissors," Razz ordered. While Catra was still opposed to whatever was happening here, this seemed like a simple enough request. She turned to leave, just as Razz zoomed over back to Entrapta. "We should be done soon, dearie. And then everything will be ready in time for the ball!"

"Ball?" Catra threw over her shoulder. "You're about a century late then. Better get to work!"

Catra's phone buzzed in her pocket as she began to look through Razz's drawers for a pair of scissors. She knew they wouldn't be with the cutlery because, duh, that was too easy. No, Catra would have to think like Razz, which always felt like a terrifying glimpse into her future.

Pulling her phone out and unlocking it with one hand, Catra used the other to open up cupboards. It occurred to her that she'd definitely end up finding them inside the fridge or something, like that time she couldn't place her wallet and it turned out the damn thing had somehow sprouted legs and crawled into Razz's crisper.

There were two messages.

Adora
The dance starts at 8
Want to come over around 7?

"We'll have to buy Mara flowers," Razz called to Catra. From across the room. Where she definitely couldn't see Catra's phone.

Maybe Entrapta's hypothesis was correct?

"I'm not buying her flowers," Catra called back as she started to climb up on the counter and look in the tiny couple of inches of hidden space on top of Razz's cabinets. "That's weird."

"That's what you do for a date!"

"It's not a date!"

Catra kept reaching around in the dark up there and all she came up with was dust, cobwebs, and a fucking box of sugar.

"I swear if the scissors are in here, I'm gonna fucking lose it," she mumbled to herself before shoving her phone back into her pocket so that she had both hands free to look.

"Not in there!" Razz yelled, suddenly much closer to Catra. She felt a broom pushing into the small of her back, similar to how Razz poked the wall loudly when Hordak yelled at her for making too much noise.

Catra was too far in though. Her claws had already started to poke into the tiny box. She wasn't surprised that she didn't feel anything resembling little granules inside. Nope, it was only paper.

"Are you hiding receipts in here?" Catra asked, now just fully digging her hand in. She had to ignore the broom becoming more insistent against her spine. It took a bit of wiggling since the wad of paper was jammed in so deeply. To her shock, Catra pulled out a stack of money. A stack of *hundreds.*

Turning on Razz quickly, Catra jumped down from the counter and landed easily on her feet. "Did you rob a bank?! I'm a minor! You can't make me an accomplice."

"Am I still needed here or not?" Entrapta called from the living room.

"Stay still," Razz quickly shot off. To Catra, she only said, "You've ruined two surprises today."

Razz snatched the box out of her hand, opened the freezer door, and tossed it inside without looking. Then *also without looking*, fucking pulled the scissors out from next to a pint of rum raisin. Catra would have to wait until Razz was distracted to check if there was rubies or something inside there. She literally could expect anything at this point.

Catra rolled her eyes. "How is your criminal activity a surprise? I've been saying you were some kind of crime kingpin for years now. So what's your thing? Baby fights? Counterfeiting coupons?"

"It's money from bingo." Razz had the nerve to be exasperated, even though she was the one wasting Catra's time here. "Always so dramatic, you."

"Liar. I've hidden bingo money all over this house and you sure as shit aren't raking in hundreds every weekend, hustling the other geriatrics out of their social security checks."

"Decoy money, duh," Razz said with an attitude that mimicked her young ward. Catra was proud of being a bad influence on her elders.

"What do you need decoy money for?"

Razz had reached the end of her patience it seemed. "So you don't find your inheritance!" She paused and thought about her words. "Ugh, I've said too much."

"Inheritance?" Catra repeated, thoroughly stunned.

"Nothing big," Razz quickly told her. A few thousand dollars was plenty big enough for Catra. "Just a little pocket money. You're not allowed to work next summer. Take your girlfriend and go—be young and have fun, how you'd always planned it."

There was a 0% chance that Catra had mentioned anything that she and Adora had planned all those years ago growing up for their last summer before college. Catra thought about clarifying that Adora wasn't her girlfriend. But that wasn't really the point, was it? The point was that Razz had apparently just up and decided to do the kindest thing that anyone had ever done for Catra.

She threw her arms around Razz's tiny frame, gripping her tightly for a moment.

"Dont be mushy ," Razz protested, even as she hugged back. Catra jumped as she felt the cold scissors on her spine. "Dramatic," Razz repeated before rushing back into the living room.

A suit! Razz had tailored a fucking *suit* for Catra! No idea where she got it from but she'd been using Entrapta for measurements since they were about the same size and Trap's parents were never home to notice their child missing.

Even though Catra offered to pay her or something for her time, Entrapta said the info she got out of it was good enough. Entrapta's family was loaded anyway and Catra wasn't about to push it.

Biking while holding a suit bag was a skill that Catra never thought she'd be asked to master . Steering with one hand, the other kept the hanger in the air to make sure her outfit never scraped the ground or got caught in her tires. It would be Catra's luck that everything was working out, only to get a block from the Gray's house, get her suit tangled up in the spokes, and end up flipping over her handlebars and knocking her teeth out. Some gay deity was on her side though, and Catra made it there in record time and with zero incidents.

Her pedaling started to slow as she turned onto the Grays' street. The home Catra grew up in – or at least the one that was *legally* her address – was a couple blocks over , in the shadow of the nice, pristine houses with their cut lawns and lack of, you know, basically falling apart-ness. She could put that out of her head; Catra had long ago learned to compartmentalize that piece of her life. She wasn't having nearly as much luck with the wealth of feelings that were simmering inside of her about the Grays' house.

Two years of not being in the place she'd considered home for so long. She was worried – about Marlena' s reaction, about messing up tonight. Nervous. Overjoyed. Sad. *Guilty* .

But Catra was committed to playing it cool. So cool that she rolled right up the driveway, sticking close to the bushes. The tall slate-

colored house had large windows big enough to see anyone walking up to the front door so Catra snuck around the back. Technically, she didnt need to do this anymore. It wasnt 1am and she wasnt 14, coming over after Adora's bedtime because she slept easier at the Grays'. They had always told Catra she was allowed to stay as long as she wanted, given she followed the same rules as Adora. But Catra never was one to mooch off of others so she'd head home after dinner and then find herself popping back over to climb into Adora's window and then into Catra's favorite side of the bed.

(It was the side against the wall, for the record. Catra liked being boxed in a little. And Adora always got up to pee in the middle of the night anyway so it just made more sense for her to take the side closest to the bathroom.)

Marlena and Randor never said anything on the many occasions that Catra and/or Adora slept through the alarm and had to be woken up.

As Catra scaled up the back of the house, hanger trapped between her teeth, digging her claws into familiar footholds, that streak of generosity came to an end. She was halfway up to the second floor when the backdoor flew open and she listened as a set of footsteps walked out onto the back porch.

"You know better than that," Catra heard.

It was Marlena's unmistakable voice. She kinda always sounded like one of those white women in a commercial for a new medication, delivering intense personal information with zero emotion or inflection. Every time one came on while she watched tv with Razz, Catra could almost hear it as Marlena saying 'I asked my doctor about diflucoxeritanus to treat my mild to severe Catritis.'

The footsteps then turned and went back into the house. Catra didnt hear the door close. The message was very clear.

Catra let herself drop and land softly in the grass. It didnt occur to her until she was moving it to her hands that maybe she *shouldnt*

have jumped half a story with a metal hanger in her mouth. She unnecessarily took about 2 seconds to try to straighten her hoodie and tights and make sure she didn't have helmet hair.

With a deep breath, she marched up the back porch and went through the open door. It led straight to the kitchen where Randor was sitting at the large granite island, a glass of red wine in his hand and an open jar of nuts next to him. Catra glanced around the room and appreciated the things that had changed. The place mostly looked better organized but they'd replaced that ugly pink checkered tile on the walls with a shiny pearly white one.

"Looking good," Catra tried to offer, lazily twirling a finger at the room.

Randor laughed quietly. "Less grandma-y?"

Catra looked away instead of agreeing. That was answer enough as Randor chuckled again. She felt too anxious to talk to him. Randor always just *knew*. He had some kind of dad super sense that she didn't really realize until the last year or so, thinking about her and Adora's friendship. Randor was such a large part of those memories, but a slightly older and maturer Catra could now recognize his subtle looks, his knowing smiles. She was sure if she tried hanging out with him right now, Randor would read every feeling on her face.

"I'm just gonna head up," Catra mumbled out.

"I'd give it a second if I were you," Randor suggested. He took a sip of wine. "Want some water? Soda?"

"What's happening upstairs?" Catra asked. She trained her ears to try to pick up something but all she got was Marlena and Adora's voices just faintly.

"I'm sure they're discussing your behavior." He looked entirely too amused by that.

Another wave of guilt came over Catra. "Is Marlena mad at me?"

The woman could hold a grudge. Catra remembered the tense, passive-aggressive feud Marlena had with the next-door neighbors over them loudly mowing their lawn at 8am every other Saturday morning. With all of her repeated threats to go over and 'say something', all Marlena ever did was give them a tight-lipped Morning!Oh, mowing? That' s great. Interesting choice. Sorry to interrupt then.'

Randor gave Catra a look that said 'duh.'That confirmed it. Even if Randor and Adora had forgiven her for the fight and everything that came after, including her absence, Marlena never would. Admittedly, Catra had been closer to Randor. Like her daughter, Marlena threw herself into work and social requirements and meeting all the expectations of being a perfect upstanding Etherian citizen. Most of Catra's interactions with Marlena had always been trying to help out as much as possible and make herself useful so that she never overstayed her welcome with the Grays. No matter how many times Marlena tried to convince her that she was part of the family, Catra had trouble believing two adults would just offer up their home and their love for free.

And then Catra went and hurt their kid before disappearing on them all? As much as it stung, she deserved whatever anger Marlena was harboring against her.

"You didn't come to the door like a gentleman," Randor added, interrupting Catra's thoughts.

She tilted her head. Were they having separate conversations?

"Like a *what*?" On the one hand, no one had ever called her that and the idea made something like a rush of pride shoot through her. On the other hand, *what?*

"Hi, Catra," Marlena said, appearing out of nowhere.

Spinning quickly on her heels, Catra came face to face with her . Like Adora, Marlena was still all angles, high cheekbones, strong jaw . Her long, stick-straight red hair was pushed back by the glasses at the top of her head and had a few more grays in it than Catra remembered. She was wearing a soft-looking navy sweater and high-waisted jeans, clearly ready to hit the couch and relax once she didnt have annoying kids in her houseand sneaking up the side of her house.

Marlena went towards the island but instead of joining Randor , she came around and leaned back against it, standing right in front of Catra.

"Hey . Sorry about the uh." Catra waved in the general direction of the backdoor. "Just, uh, habit?"

Catra glanced over at Randor to see if this would be a good time to add in apologies for all the other many things that she had done. The second she took her eyes off of Marlena, she was surprised by arms pulling her into a tight hug.

"Uh." Catra stuttered. She could still see Randor , who was now trying to hide his smile by putting his wineglass to his lips.

"Missed you around here," Marlena whispered.

Catra let herself relax, though she couldnt help but still hang onto her garment bag awkwardly. "Sorry ."

Marlena scoffed, moving back to give Catra a little space. "Hey , be sorry for scuffing up the side of my house. I hope youre not still running around being sorry for just being you." She patted Catra's cheek once before she pulled her hands back to her sides.

Catra mimicked Marlena, giving a soft scoff to cover up her shaky, unsure breathing. One piece of life advice Marlena consistently gave her was to stop apologizing for merely existing. Weaver had wired it into her, always annoyed at even the sight of Catra. Marlena must

have picked up on it early, with her endless encouragement for Catra to not shrink herself down or feel bad for needing literally anything.

"Next time you need help, you call me or you will be though."

"She'll be what?" Randor teased.

"She'll be *sorry,"* Marlena said, sounding exasperated before turning to her husband. "I'm trying to be the stern one. Can you just sit quietly for a second?"

Randor tossed a nut in her direction, laughing as she dodged it.

Marlena turned back to Catra, a fake pleading expression on her face. "I'm trapped in the house with these two. Please come visit and give me a break from time to time. I'm exhausted from replacing screen doors because one of them ran right through it and every meal turning into a competitive eating contest." Another nut flew towards them and Marlena took a step to avoid it without looking away from Catra. "Okay , I won't keep you. Head up and get ready . Make yourself at home. Let me know if you want a snack."

Catra was still waiting for the other shoe to drop. For Marlena to go "psych! I hate you!" But when she dared to glance up and all she received was a subtle fond smile, Catra nodded and accepted that maybe things were okay between them.

She took off and was halfway up the staircase when Marlena yelled, "Make sure to keep the door open, you two!"

"Mom!" Adora's very embarrassed voice shouted from her room.

Catra walked a little faster to get away from Randor's booming laugh and the thought that she and Adora could ever get up to anything that wouldn't be parent-appropriate. She gave two quick knocks on Adora's closed door.

"Come in."

If everything about this wasn't already so cringey, Catra would have liked to maybe catch her breath or mentally prepare herself for crossing this threshold. But now she could hear Randor and Marlena talking back and forth about whether they should actually institute that door rule, so Catra rushed inside.

It was a shock how much Adora's room looked like it was frozen in time. It was still too much baby blue—the carpet, the walls, the comforter. Still a mess yet somehow organized perfectly for Adora only, clothes stacked in piles in random places but *folded,* which was ridiculous. The full-size bed had too many pillows and the stuffed unicorn that Catra had won for Adora at the county fair (Swift Wind, she called him) was sitting on top, next to Melog, the weird purple cat that Adora had then won for her. Printed photos of Catra and Adora throughout the years were tacked up on the wall, with just a couple new ones of Bow and Glimmer sprinkled in. Right next to the bed, up above Catra's former spot, hung the drawing she'd done of Adora in art class only a few weeks earlier.

Adora's head popped out of the walk-in closet, blonde hair falling around her shoulders in subtle waves. She was smiling but distracted.

"Hey!" Before Catra could respond, Adora disappeared back inside. "Sorry I'm running a little behind—I know you don't take long to get dressed. I'm almost ready. My mom did my hair and I just need to get this zipped up," she said, sounding like that update was coming in real time.

"You need help in there?" Catra offered.

"Nope, almost got it," Adora grunted out.

Catra rolled her eyes. Even now, Adora would rather destroy her outfit for the evening than accept support.

The nervous feeling in Catra's tummy was getting more insistent. This was actually happening. She was standing in Adora's room and

they were going to a dance together and she just needed to remind herself constantly not to fuck it up this time. Surprisingly, that was a lot of pressure.

She busied herself getting dressed. Adora was right—it didn't take long for Catra to jump out of her clothes and into Razz's creation. In just a couple short minutes, she had changed into her suit and had everything perfectly styled except her tie. Only Razz would choose something old timey like a bowtie; Catra had no idea what to do with it but maybe she could ask Randor before they left.

"Okay!" Adora shouted. "Finally!"

Catra turned to the closet just in time to watch Adora pop out, arms extended above her head like she was introducing herself at a pep rally and *not* like she was an absolutely beautiful girl wearing a fancy dress.

Look, Catra had never really considered that the phrase breath-taking' was real until this exact moment. Everything in her body, including her lungs, went still the second she saw Adora.

The dress Adora had chosen had a high neck that Catra found a little annoying for not showing enough skin. But it was also sleeveless and left Adora's toned biceps on display. It was flowy in a way that made Adora look unusually softer. Most distracting of all, it was red. That could have just been a show of school spirit but it gave Catra an unshakeable feeling of deja vu.

"What do you think?" Adora prompted, making Catra realize she'd been silent for way too long.

She managed to stutter out, "It, uh, reminds me of that dance. Um, sophomore year...you know?"

"Yeah," Adora said, sounding kinda out of breath. "That's what I thought when I saw it at the store. I remember how you kept telling me how much you liked that one."

Catra nodded dumbly, remembering how amazing Adora looked back then.

"Do you like this one?"

Catra nodded again. *Love* dumbly.

Gods, she'd apparently forgotten how words worked.

Adora was a vision. She was the most gorgeous thing Catra had ever seen.

"You're wearing a suit," Adora seemed to notice for the first time. "It looks really good. *You* look really good."

"Thanks. You too," Catra said quietly.

"Thanks." Adora self-consciously smoothed the dress down. "I was really hoping you'd like it."

And then they were just two idiots staring at each other and smiling.

Slowly, Catra's mind started to be able to move past 'oh my gods, pretty girl brrr' and actually catch up to what Adora had said. She'd picked this dress out with Catra in mind.

weeks ago, Catra imagined. Adora had planned this, had been thinking about her in a (was it too generous to say?) romantic context?

Catra felt her eyes widen, felt her tail begin to weave up into the air behind her.

Holy fuck.

Well, if what Glimmer and Randor and Entrapta and Scorpia had said- okay, wait just a damn minute. How many people needed to point out how she and Adora felt about each other before Catra would finally listen to them?!

Adora had been amazing lately, supporting Catra and making her feel actually valued – all the shit she'd screamed about in their awful fight. Adora had invited her to the dance, had maybe wanted *something* to happen between them that was more than a friendship. When was Catra gonna get her shit together and say she wanted that too?

"I'm an idiot," Catra thought.

"What?" Adora asked.

Oh shit. Again?! Stupid fucking mouth, never doing what Catra wants.

She scrambled for something to say, to fill the silence that had gone even tenser.

"For back then," Catra said. That was true. "For now . For… everything." She had no clue how to explain this all to Adora. All the regret. All the lost time. The schemes, the bullshit, the pettiness. "I've had feelings for you for so long, Adora. And I've done all this other bullshit in order to just avoid telling you. I mean, deep deep down, I think I even agreed to go along with Huntara's idea just so I could, I don't know , be in your universe again. I'm sorry I lied about that, even when you gave me space to tell the truth. I'm sorry I let our friendship get so fucked up that I couldn't be there for you when you came out. I know how big that was for you. I'm sorry for… everything."

Catra suddenly didn't know what to do with her hands. She weirdly felt like she should get down on one knee but that was definitely the wrong occasion. How did people do this?

She settled for taking a couple steps closer to Adora and shoving her hands into her pockets.

"I thought you only responded back to Huntara' s messages cause you wanted to be friends with me again…and if friendship is all you

want, that’s totally cool too. But, uhwould you, umDo you want to go to homecoming with me? As, ya know, my date?”

Adora looked like someone had just handed her a 3,000 piece jigsaw puzzle, shock and confusion apparent. She did *not* look like someone who was overjoyed to have their long-time crush ask them out.

Had everyone just been wrong? Adora thought of Catra only as a friend and here Catra was, pining after her and then making it even more awkward by pressuring Adora into going out with her.

Catra tried to give Adora space. She took a couple quick steps back but apparently she didn't remember the layout of Adora’s room as well as she thought she did, because Catra stumbled right into the dresser behind her.

That was enough to snap Adora out of it, shaking her head lightly until she seemed to notice Catra completely panicking in front of her.

"Sorry! I didn't mean to leave you hanging, I just thought we already *were* each other’s date.”

That was definitely *not* what Catra had agreed to, or even what Adora had offered. Good lord, they really needed to practice getting on the same page.

Adora threw her hands up and her eyes looked far away, like she was practically talking to herself. "I mean, I asked you to a dance, Catra. Alone, not in a group. When you didn't come in the door, my mom said I might not've communicated it clearly but seriously, who could misunderstand going on a date?"

Them, apparently, which made Catra laugh a little to herself. Adora snapped back into the present before tossing a quick sheepish grin Catra's way.

Adora just pressed on, "Thank you. For saying all that. Can I-? I need to, like, get some things out first too." She took a deep breath, hands fidgeting nervously. "This is gonna sound pathetic"…

Catra laughed suddenly. "Did you just hear anything I admitted to?"

"I mean, it wasn't *that* embarrassing."

"Lance caught me printing a list of all the things I love about you," Catra added dryly. It wasn't a competition but she'd far and away been the most cringey one in this relationship, she was sure of it.

Adora threw her head back and cackled. "Fine!" She stepped a little closer to Catra. "I'm sorry too. I thought that pretending I didn't know you were coaching Huntara was the only way you'd talk to me, yeah. I didn't know what you wanted or why you were doing it. But I, okay, maybe I thought I could learn more about your life lately and also," Adora's voice slipped down to a whisper, "Maybe you'd remember how much you liked me and you'd want to be my girlfriend."

It was Catra's turn to be shocked and confused now. That was fun.

That swirl of emotions must have been apparent because Adora rushed to cover her face with both hands.

"Oh my Gods, it *is* pathetic," Adora whined. "I figured out who you were almost immediately. I literally showed up on your doorstep cause I thought you were hinting at your identity and wanted to see me! You must think I'm *so* weird!"

"I feel like I owe Huntara her money back," Catra said. It was really all she could think. Adora liked her enough to try to completely play both Catra and Huntara. To drop everything and rush over just cause she thought Catra was trying to hint that she wanted to see her. Adora wanted to be her *girlfriend*?

Adora groaned. "I felt like crap for leading Huntara on, but at first, I just didn't know how to let her down. How are you supposed to tell

someone you're not interested in them?"

"Literally any way except trying to be her friend and pretending like it's not happening?" Catra suggested pointedly .

Adora decided to continue like she hadn't spoken. "But when I realized that you were communicating *for her*, I mean I felt a little less bad since she was lying to me too. Eventually, I came clean to her about how I only ever really wanted you. I don't think she *understood* really, but she didn't seem to mind being outsmarted in her awful scheme."

"I'm still impressed you even figured it out."

Adora gave her a look. "Catra. You were so *bad* at it."

"I was not!" Catra was *sure*, she was sure of it. And she didn't much appreciate the look of pity and smug amusement Adora was throwing her way.

"I know you're used to being good at everything but you were terrible at pretending to be Huntara. It was literally like talking to two different people and one of them mysteriously suddenly knew everything I liked *and* texted in full sentences? It was obvious so I just… capitalized on a defensive weakness."

Catra wasn't pleased on having Adora's dumb hockey techniques used for evil like this. She didn't need to ask what her weakness was. It was clearly Adora herself.

"I can't believe you went that route instead of, I don't know , having Glimmer yell at me or something. You didn't even know what me and Huntara were teaming up for."

"I didn't think you were up to something horrible so I just decided to see what you were going to do."

"That's a dangerous way to live, princess," Catra laughed. "What if I was trying to steal your organs or something?"

"And you waited 12 years? You're not that patient, Catra." Adora threw her a smirk that had Catra practically swooning against the dresser. "That's a yes to homecoming by the way."

"Oh, we hadn't settled that? I wasn't exactly dying from the suspense, since you'd already moved on to confessing your love for me," Catra joked, pretending to already be bored with how obsessed Adora was with her. "Do Bow and Glimmer know about all this?"

"Pieces. I had to tell them *something.* They got all excited when they saw the candygram and thought it was from you. And then when they saw Huntara's name, they just felt so bad for me that I had to let them in on my suspicions so Glimmer wouldn't destroy you. I mean, she knows we're both to blame for the fight, but she's threatened your destruction repeatedly 'cause you haven't gotten over it and confessed your love,' according to her."

"Ha, please! Destroy me?" Catra scoffed. "If I say the word, she'd leave her man for me *right now."*

"You just asked me on a date – don't you want to at least wait to see if there's a second one before telling me your plan to break up with me and go for my best friend?"

Catra shrugged. "Apologies. They skipped that in etiquette class." The mention of 'etiquette' sparked something in the back of her mind. "Oh, shit! I forgot to bring flowers or something."

"Flowers?" Adora tilted her head cutely.

"Yeah, you're my date. I'm supposed to give you a corsage."

"I think that's only for prom."

"We have to do this again in spring?" Catra asked, groaning.

Adora's face lit up with a devious grin. "Oh, yeah," she nodded. "And I'll be expecting a full promposal. Ooh, and matching outfits!"

"Actually , I'm rethinking this whole thing," Catra said.

"That' s the price of being my girlfriend. Take it or leave it," Adora replied, sounding quite confident in herself.

"Does it come with perks at least?"

Adora waggled her eyebrows suggestively, which just made her look ridiculous. "One or two."

In an instant, she was rushing forward and colliding her lips against Catra's with zero grace. Her body pressed Catra's further against the dresser, trapping her there. Catra tilted her head so that they were at a less awkward angle, giggling quietly at how they hadn't gotten any better at this in two years. She didn't want to mess up Adora' s hair so her hands went to the other girl's hips.

Adora reached to cup Catra's cheeks and slowly parted her lips, moving the kiss from sweet and gentle to something a bit more racy than what Catra was expecting. She might have accidentally trilled in excitement, just a little too loudly , when Adora's tongue softly met hers.

"This door isn't cracked," Marlena called from the hall, voice getting closer with each word. She was kindly giving them a warning at least.

The two of them sprung apart and by the time Marlena entered the room, they were each in separate corners, pretending to be focused on getting ready. They were each basically done so they both looked like complete liars, Catra raising the end of the bowtie in the air aimlessly while Adora suddenly needed to *really* focus to slip on a pair of gold flats. Marlena didn't look convinced, but she was nice enough to not push it.

"Cat, why don't you ask Randor to help you with that?"

Ten minutes and two YouTube tutorials later, Catra and Randor still hadn't solved the mystery of the bowtie when Adora and Marlena joined them in the den. It would just have to lay untied around Catra's neck, which was honestly more of her style anyway.

"Okay , all done," Adora announced. "Dad, are you ready to drop us off?"

"Wait, I have to get pictures!" Marlena yelled.

She began yelling directions at them while Randor headed into the kitchen. It was not in Catra's nature to play ball with this kind of silly shit, but the suit (and the girl on her arm) had her really feeling herself. Catra pulled Adora close by the waist, smirking confidently at the camera while Marlena took several shots.

When Randor returned, he had his keys but his feet were still bare.

"Here," was the only warning he gave before he tossed the keys in Catra's direction without a second glance. Returning to the couch, he added, "Have a good date. Don't drink. Bring my baby back in one piece please."

Catra gave him a serious nod. She still felt bad for whatever fallout he had to take care of when she ditched Adora at the last dance.

"Adora's safe with me. For real this time," Catra swore.

"My car!" Randor clarified, with a mocking laugh. "Adora's a big girl. She can take care of herself. Now, get out of here. Go have fun, kids."

Catra had to admit it. As annoying as she was, Glitter had done a decent job of making the gym look *slightly* less like the smelly place where they were legally required to run laps.

It was unclear what the theme was – there were paper stars and string lights and a couple clouds. The court, DT, Glimmer, Bow, Mermista, Sea Hawk, and others, were easy to spot mingling in the crowd, in their plastic gold crowns and handmade sashes.

Adora had taken Catra's hand as soon as they parked the car and wasn't letting go even now as they walked in and several sets of eyes turned to them in surprise. Catra was pretty sure that that high-pitched squealing sound she heard was Glimmer .

Pulling her along, Adora went to say hello to everyone. Literally, everyone: first, her friends, then her teammates, and then any random person that Adora seemed to know. She made a big show of telling everyone how great they looked before loudly explaining that Catra was her date/girlfriend. It was equal parts mortifying and exciting. For the most part, everyone kept their shocked reactions to a minimum.

There were some exceptions:

Glimmer screamed, "Finally!" and threw her arms around them both.

Bow teared up and had to excuse himself.

Scorpia gave Catra probably the longest, most intense hug of her life and only seemed to stop to whisper what definitely sounded like a threat to Adora.

Entrapta nodded and walked away, probably needing to call off whatever backup plan she'd created to make sure they ended up together.

Huntara just smirked. As she left to dance with Perfuma, she whispered to Catra, "I'll be expecting my money back."

Fair enough.

Once they'd made the rounds and finished whatever polite social requirements Catra had never learned, she tried dragging them over to the dancefloor. Adora looked so good and Catra wasn't about to waste this excuse to be close to her, to hold her without having to second guess it.

"Excited to show me all the moves you learned from EBDC?" Adora joked.

Catra groaned, realizing she'd probably never live down the clusterfuck she'd spent the past couple months trapped in.

They waded through the bodies awkwardly flailing around the gym floor until they found a place that looked in the mix of things but removed enough that Catra felt comfortable there.

"Not sneaking dances under the bleachers?" she joked, as she fell in line with the beat of this dumb dreampop song, wrapping her arms around Adora's neck so they could sway together. "Really taking a step up in the world."

Adora's face was a bit more serious than it needed to be as her hands went to loop around Catra's lower back, keeping up with her lead. "No more hiding," she said.

And then her lips were back on Catra's. (This might have already become a common thing – they'd barely made it to the end of the Grays' street before Catra pulled over so that they could kiss. And then at each stoplight. And in the school parking lot. They did kinda have two years of missed opportunities to make up for.)

Adora probably meant it to be a short peck but they were already locked together so it was easy to deepen the kiss until Catra realized they'd stopped dancing and were now just basically making out in the middle of the crowd.

Vaguely, she heard a couple whistles and a catcall that was definitely from Glimmer.

Spinnerella's voice cut through with, "Hey , Gray, Dr iluth!Absolutely not! *Sepr arate!*"

Randor was dropping the last box in the corner of the dorm right as Catra came in, dragging the *last last* piece of her baggage on her back.

"Okay ," Randor said, huf fing a little to catch his breath. "That should be everything." He wiped his sweaty hands of f on his tshirt while he looked around Catra's tiny dorm room. It wasn't much, j ust a couple single beds with matching cheap wooden dressers and desks. But she was excited to be (more or less) on her own in the big city.

Her new roommate hadn't arrived yet and Catra was grateful for that because it meant that they missed the last couple of eventful hours: Marlena and Randor getting snippy with each other about how best to unload the truck. Razz getting snippy with everyone for assuming she couldn't carry a single box by herself. Adora and Randor getting competitive about who could lift the most. Adora then collapsing on the stairs and needing to be carried up on piggyback by Catra.

"Do you need me to take her?" Randor asked, nodding at his child draped across Catra's shoulders.

"I can walk," Adora pouted but she didn't bother getting down. Honestly, Catra knew she j ust liked the attention.

Randor came over and pulled them both into a hug that, logistically, was j ust the worst since Catra ended up trapped between father and daughter. "T ake care of each other, okay? If you need a single thing, Cat, you call us. Doesn't matter how big or small. Y ou hear me?"

Catra was saved from this by another loud, long honk from the ground level. She was glad that her dorm faced the street but she wasn't looking forward to rush hour traf fic if everyone relied on their car horn as much as Marlena did. She had gotten tired of everyone

crying hours ago and decided to wait in the car with Razz until Randor and Adora were ready to drive to EU.

When the honk didn't end, Randor let them go. "I better get out of here. I've got to do this all over again now . Later, Cat."

As he ran out, Catra crooked her head back so she could see Adora's face. The dummy was still red and looking like she was in need of a snack and a nap. It was ridiculous to think she was about to go lug *her own* stuff up to her dorm after she'd spent the morning helping Catra move in.

"Had enough of the free ride, princess?"

Adora gingerly climbed down from Catra's back. "Guess I better go too," she said, sounding miserable. "Will I ever see you again?"

"Don't be so dramatic," Catra said as she turned to face Adora. "You'll literally be just a 15-minute subway ride away ."

"That' s too far!" Adora whined. She pulled Catra close. "I'm gonna miss you so much."

"Again, same city , 15 minutes away. It's just 4 stops. You don't even have to transfer trains." Catra was very much looking forward to when Adora inevitably tried to come up with a shortcut, got lost, and ended up in a maze of uptown streets by accident.

"I know ," Adora said. She sniffled quietly and Catra realized they'd both begun softly tearing up.

"I love you," Catra whispered before she pulled Adora into a kiss. "I'm so proud of you. Dream school."

"Dream *girl,"* Adora joked. "I couldn't have done this without you, ya know. Love you too."

Chapter End Notes

cries quietly*it's the end!i have a lot of feelings. so so so many thanks to everyone who read and commented and left kudos and made fun of catra on twitter. i really appreciated sharing this with y'all. i'll never be able to find this comment again probably but shout-out to the person who predicted razz had secret money. you are a very powerful witch.

i will miss randor most of all. i'll likely never use this short snippet that i wrote and then decided not to shoe-horn in so i leave it to you here:
"Catra, you asked me for my permission to marry Adora when you were 9."
"I did not!"
"You did and I told you that I didn't believe in patriarchal nonsense like that."
"You did *not* use that word!"
"Fine!I said it was a little old-fashioned but I want you to remember me as more forward-thinking back then. Anyway, I told you that it was Dora's call but if she agreed, that was enough for me. And unlike your 4th grade favors, this one doesn't expire. Do me a favor and wait about 10 years, though please?"

why did i write that? where did i expect it to go? no idea!

halloween's in six days. let's see if i can crank out something by then.

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